

Author's Note

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Chapter 1: The Whisper of a New Fate

The city's evening sky painted itself in bleeding shades of bruised purple and brilliant orange—a fading, beautiful reminder of a day she had barely lived through. As the horizon dissolved into twilight, Mami Tomoe hardly noticed the view. She was too used to the encroaching dark. She had learned, through blood and shattered glass, that the shadows lingered long after the sun set, and that for a magical girl, the fight never truly ended.

But right now, the twilight outside didn't matter. Inside the witch's labyrinth, the air tasted like spun sugar and rot.

Mami stood before the grotesque, doll-like form of the witch, Charlotte. Her posture remained impeccable, her spine perfectly straight, a glint of absolute resolve in her eyes. It was the face she always wore: the flawless, unbeatable veteran. Yet beneath that practiced confidence, a familiar trinity stirred—fear, loneliness, doubt. The sheer weight of her burden often felt heavier than any enemy she had ever faced. *Alone. Always alone.* She had never told a soul how much it hurt to keep smiling while drowning, or how deeply she feared that one day, she might lose herself entirely to the dark.

Tonight, though, the script had changed.

Her gloved fingers tightened around the grip of her flintlock musket. Her mind drifted back to the promise Madoka Kaname had made just moments ago, their voices echoing in the sweets-lined corridors of the labyrinth.

"I'll become a magical girl to help you, Mami."

The words were a lifeline. Madoka was so fragile, so full of innocent hope—she didn't yet understand the terrible price of entry into this world. But she had promised to stand by Mami's side anyway. To Mami, it meant everything. The suffocating weight on her shoulders suddenly felt bearable.

I... I will finally have a magical girl friend! Mami's lips curved into a soft, genuine smile, a rare warmth blooming in her chest. *I am no longer alone.*

With a surge of newfound adrenaline, her ribbons shot forward. They snaked through the air, binding Charlotte's tiny, pathetic body tight. With elegant, ruthless precision, Mami swung the witch like a ragdoll, slamming her repeatedly into the candy-striped walls and the checkerboard ceiling. Muskets

materialized in brilliant bursts of golden light, firing a synchronized, deafening volley. Each shot struck true. Each movement was a masterclass in lethal grace.

From the sidelines, the bright, unguarded voices of Madoka and Sayaka cut through the chaos.

“Wow, Mami!”

“You’ve got this!”

“Amazing!”

Mami’s heart swelled to the bursting point. *I feel so light... so happy...* It was a euphoria she hadn’t tasted since the old days, back when she and Kyoko Sakura had fought back-to-back. She glanced down at her Soul Gem. It was pulsing, shining with a strange, brilliant intensity. She tilted her head, a brief flicker of confusion crossing her mind, but she pushed it aside. Happiness was too fleeting a luxury to question.

Charlotte lay battered on the ground, barely twitching. Mami looked up, raising her arm with calm finality.

“Time to end this.”

Golden ribbons erupted from the floor, binding the witch completely and hoisting her high into the air. Mami manifested her masterpiece—a massive, ornate, gleaming cannon. She aimed it with perfect, practiced precision.

Tiro Finale!

The cataclysmic beam of light pierced straight through Charlotte’s center. The witch’s body wilted, smoking and broken.

Mami dismissed her weapon, letting her posture relax as the ribbons dissolved into golden dust. She looked up at the defeated creature with a proud, profoundly relieved smile. The danger had passed. The nightmare was over.

And then—the universe shifted.

Something moved within the smoking crater of Charlotte’s corpse. A massive, dark shape began to aggressively push through the ruined shell. A long, serpentine body. A blank, polka-dotted mask. Massive, wing-like appendages unfurled like the petals of a carnivorous flower.

Charlotte’s true form had emerged.

It was fast. Monstrously, impossibly fast.

By the time Mami’s brain registered the motion, the creature was already upon her. Her triumphant smile faltered, then vanished entirely. Her eyes widened in dawning, paralyzing horror as the massive, snake-like maw hovered inches from her face.

The jaws unhinged, revealing rows of jagged teeth.

In a fraction of a second, the darkness closed in. Mami's head was inside the mouth.

Time slowed to a crawl. Her mind flashed desperately to Madoka and Sayaka. All her grand promises—to protect them, to teach them, to no longer be alone—crumbled into empty, tragic words. She was slipping. She was losing. *What would they think of me now? To die like a dog in front of them...*

But just as Charlotte's fangs began to snap shut, a jarring anomaly tore through the magic of the labyrinth.

A voice, faint but absolute, echoed directly into the center of her consciousness. It was like a freezing breeze cutting through a suffocating fire.

"You will not die here."

The words were entirely alien. They didn't belong to her own frantic mind, nor did they belong to any human she knew. They felt ancient, primordial, and yet—incredibly comforting.

The mysterious presence washed over her, and the terror in Mami's chest gave way to an unnatural, sudden calm. The tension drained from her muscles. The world around her began to warp.

Mami blinked. The solid ground beneath her boots dissolved into nothingness. A blinding light, purer and brighter than any magic she had ever witnessed, enveloped her completely. Reality twisted like pulled taffy, dragging her entirely out of the constraints of time and space. The snapping fangs of the witch, which should have claimed her life, simply vanished—as if they had never existed at all.

As she was pulled into the infinite void, away from the labyrinth, her final thoughts fractured. They weren't of her own survival, but of the girls she had left behind.

Oh no. Not like this. Madoka... Sayaka... please...

...please do not become a magical girl.

The last fleeting image burned into her mind was the sight of Madoka and Sayaka, their faces twisted in absolute terror, their eyes filling with tears as they screamed her name into the empty air. But their voices were lost to the distance, swallowed by a strange, roaring vacuum.

And then, everything went dead silent.

Chapter 2: The Price of a Promise

The air inside the labyrinth grew suffocatingly heavy as Mami's golden ribbons slowly withered into glittering ash.

Bound tightly to a structural pillar several corridors away, Homura Akemi felt the magic restraining her falter and snap. It had been a desperate, naive act by Mami—a misguided attempt to keep Homura from interfering, from "stealing" the Grief Seed, from warning the girls about the true nature of Charlotte.

"Oh no..." Homura whispered, her voice cracking in the silence of the abandoned corridor.

Her mind, sharpened by countless tragedies, connected the dots in a fraction of a second. The sudden collapse of the binding magic meant only one thing: the caster's life force was failing. Mami had been caught.

A familiar, crushing sense of loss hit Homura like a physical blow to the chest. With a grimace, she pushed herself up against the wall, her body trembling with a volatile mix of anger and sorrow. *I knew this would happen*, she thought bitterly. *I knew someone would fall. It always plays out like this.* Yet, no matter how many times she witnessed it, the realization never hurt any less.

In every timeline, every cruel iteration of this endless loop, she had tried to save them. She had tried to protect them—to protect *Madoka*. But the universe always broke her promises. They fought together, and they died together. Every single time. That was why Homura had chosen total isolation in this loop. She couldn't afford to rely on anyone. She couldn't let herself make the same mistakes.

Yet, as she gritted her teeth and sprinted toward the center of the labyrinth, the self-imposed isolation didn't numb the pain. Mami's horrific end wasn't just a consequence of battle; it was the direct result of the girls ignoring her warnings. The one person who could have been a guide, a mentor, was gone. Gone because they refused to listen.

Homura clenched her fists, forcing the rising tide of grief deep down into the hollow of her chest. There was no time to mourn. Not anymore.

Back in the dim-lit, dilapidated heart of the witch's lair, the atmosphere was utterly apocalyptic. The air felt thick with the sickening odor of burnt sugar and unholy, irreversible slaughter. High above the checkerboard floor, Charlotte's monstrous, serpentine second form swirled, its massive jaws working rhythmically as it seemingly consumed the last remnants of Mami Tomoe.

The space felt cavernous and oppressive, as though the candy-striped walls were actively closing in to crush the survivors. A suffocating sense of finality permeated the room. The price had been paid. The horror was absolute.

Madoka and Sayaka stood completely frozen, their boots seemingly glued to the floor, their minds violently rejecting what their eyes were seeing. They had heard Mami's elegant speeches. They had been warned of danger. But nothing could have prepared them for the grotesque reality of a magical girl being devoured alive.

"No..."

Sayaka's voice broke the silence—a fragile, trembling whisper of pure disbelief. Her breath came in shallow, panicked gasps. Her wide, horrified eyes were locked onto the thrashing monster above. *This wasn't supposed to happen. This was a magical girl. She was invincible.* "She... she can't be—" Her words trailed off into nothing, an empty plea to a universe that didn't care.

A violent wave of nausea washed over Madoka. Her heart hammered against her ribs so loudly it threatened to drown out the sickening, squelching sounds of the witch's feast. Automatically, instinctively, Madoka reached a hand out toward the space where Mami had stood just moments before. But her arm trembled so violently that her fingers simply hung suspended in the air, unable to grasp at the void left behind. She couldn't speak. She couldn't move.

This can't be real. She can't be gone.

Mami, who had smiled so brightly. Mami, who had promised they would all fight together, a team of friends holding back the dark. Shattered. In a single, horrific second, their entire imagined future had been torn to shreds.

High above, Charlotte turned her polka-dotted, mask-like face toward the two terrified middle schoolers. The creature's jaw unhinged further, twisting into a grotesque, mocking grin.

Sayaka and Madoka paralyzed completely, too gripped by primal terror to even scream.

"Hurry! One of you, make a wish now!" Kyubey's voice cut through the panic, his crimson eyes gleaming with cold, calculated opportunism. "Contract with me and save yourselves!"

"That won't be necessary."

A voice like dry ice cut through the haze of their shock.

Homura Akemi emerged from the shifting shadows like a grim specter, her silhouette cutting sharply through the labyrinth's garish light. The girl they had known only as the distant, icy transfer student was now the only person left standing—the only one unmoved by the surrounding grief.

Her presence brought a suffocating chill to the room. Her violet eyes flicked up to the witch, and then briefly to the spot where Mami had fallen. There was no shock. No tears. A passing flicker of emotion crossed her pale face—perhaps disgust at the witch, perhaps profound frustration at the girls—but it vanished so quickly it might have been an illusion.

Homura was already moving. Her efficiency was terrifyingly mechanical.

With a swift, practiced flick of her wrist, she initiated a devastating ambush. Dozens of pipe bombs and military-grade explosives materialized from thin air, pinning Charlotte to the walls.

Boom. Boom. Boom.

A synchronized barrage of deafening explosions tore through the cavernous room. The witch never stood a chance. Madoka and Sayaka could barely track the violence; Homura's movements were a

lethal, blurred ballet of gunpowder and steel, ending the creature before the echoes of the first explosion could even fade.

Charlotte's grotesque, bloated mass was sliced and blown apart with a terrifying finality. It was clear Homura hadn't just reacted—she had *known* exactly how to kill it. She had been waiting for this exact vulnerability.

As the smoke cleared, Homura stood perfectly still over the smoking, dissolving remains of the witch. Her expression was an unreadable porcelain mask. From the center of the wreckage, a dark, spiked object materialized, floating quietly in the air.

The Grief Seed.

Without a word of comfort or hesitation, Homura reached out, plucking the cold, black seed from the ashes. She flipped her dark hair over her shoulder, her gaze cutting briefly, sharply toward Madoka and Sayaka, before she turned her back on them entirely.

Left in the wake of the sudden, violent silence, Madoka and Sayaka drowned in a tidal wave of confusion and despair. They hadn't even been allowed the dignity of time. They hadn't been able to process Mami's death, not properly, not in the way their bleeding hearts needed to. Mami had died in agony, and they had just watched.

Madoka's hands shook uncontrollably, a heavy, suffocating lump tightening in her throat. The tears burned behind her eyelids, but the sheer shock locked them in place. All she could do was stare at Homura's retreating back.

But Sayaka's grief instantly transmuted into raw, burning fury.

"Why?!" Sayaka screamed, her voice cracking as she took a violent step forward, her fists shaking at her sides. "Why are you acting like this?! We just saw her die, and you—" She gestured wildly at the ash-covered floor, her face contorted with heartbroken rage. "You just walk in here, defeat the witch, and act like nothing happened?! How can you be so... so *cold* when someone who fought beside us is gone?!"

The tears finally broke down Sayaka's cheeks, hot and angry. "She was important to us! She must have meant *something* to you as a fellow magical girl, right?! How can you look at us like that—like you don't even care?!"

Homura paused her stride, turning her head just enough to cast a sideways glance over her shoulder. Her face remained a flawless, detached stone. Sayaka's emotional breakdown didn't even cause her to blink.

When she spoke, her voice was a razor blade.

"She wouldn't have died if you hadn't come here," Homura replied, her words carrying a biting, cruel resonance. "If you had listened to my warning, you wouldn't have lost her."

It was a harsh, agonizing truth—the kind of truth designed to break a person. Madoka and Sayaka were entirely unready for it, but it was the only currency Homura had left to spend.

Madoka took a trembling step forward, her voice a small, desperate plea. “What do you mean? What really happened to Mami? Why... why did she have to die like that?”

Homura didn't turn around to face her. She stared into the exit of the collapsing labyrinth, her voice cold—heavy with the crushing weight of a hundred doomed timelines, a thousand failed promises, and an ocean of witnessed slaughter.

“This is what being a magical girl means,” Homura said quietly. “You either fight and survive, or you die. There is no room for anything else.”

With a subtle sway of her dark cloak, Homura stepped forward, walking away from them without another word. She left them alone in the ruins of the witch's domain—left them to confront the shattered, bloody pieces of their reality, and the agonizing loss of the girl who had been their protector, their mentor, and their friend.

“How can you just leave?!” Sayaka's raw, broken voice echoed down the emptying corridor, desperate and full of hatred. “A magical girl just died! Doesn't it matter to you at all?!”

But Homura didn't look back. Her rhythmic, steady footsteps grew fainter and fainter, until she was entirely swallowed by the shadows.

Chapter 3: The Veil Between Worlds

The world Mami Tomoe opened her eyes to was a violent departure from the candy-coated nightmare of Charlotte's labyrinth.

Here, the air didn't smell of sugar; it didn't smell of anything at all. The atmosphere possessed an unfamiliar, crushing weight, as if the fabric of reality had been stretched until it was translucent and thin. She was adrift in a vast, non-Euclidean void—a shifting expanse of muted, swirling lights and violet shadows that defied the horizon.

Mami staggered, her boots finding no solid purchase on the shimmering floor. Her body felt unnervingly light, as though the laws of gravity had been revoked. A cold, visceral realization washed over her: *I felt the fangs. I felt the snap.*

"Am I... dead?" she whispered, her voice swallowed by the hungry silence of the void. "Was that really the end?"

She remembered the grotesque face of the witch, the heat of the creature's breath, and the paralyzing sensation of being torn away. Was this the afterlife promised to magical girls? A hollow, unfeeling haze between worlds?

"No, this can't be real," Mami hissed, clutching her head. "I can't be gone. Not yet. Not like that."

“Mami Tomoe...”

The voice was a paradox—soft and ethereal, yet carrying the tectonic weight of centuries. It possessed a haunting beauty that stirred a dormant memory deep in Mami’s soul, a warmth she couldn’t quite name. Mami spun around, her heart hammering against her ribs.

There, standing in the distance, was a girl.

Her appearance was almost like a vision, a surreal blend of light and shadow. She was dressed in a similar to a magical-girl but not quite one, but her appearance seemed to exist at the edge of Mami’s understanding — a perfect balance of elegance and mystery. Her hair was a silken cascade of deep indigo, eyes dark and unreadable, yet filled with an ancient knowing. A long, flowing ribbon danced around her as though alive, and her presence was overwhelming. She seemed to radiate an aura of both power and calm.

“You...” Mami whispered, staring at her, confused. “Who are you? What is this place?”

The girl tilted her head, but her expression remained neutral, unreadable. She didn’t answer. Instead, she stepped forward, her movements fluid, almost like she was gliding. With every step she took, the space around them warped and rippled like a heat haze. Her gaze, when it met Mami’s, seemed to pierce through her, as if seeing not just her but all the depths of her soul.

Mami’s chest tightened. She forced her voice to remain steady, though her hands were trembling. “So, I’m... I’m dead? Is this the end of the line?”

The girl didn’t respond directly. Instead, she slowly circled Mami, studying her from every angle. She didn’t seem to feel the need to clarify or explain. She simply existed there, in her inscrutable presence.

Mami’s anxiety spiked into a frantic, protective panic. “I need to go back! Madoka, Sayaka—they’re still in that place! They’re in danger! I can’t just leave them!” Her voice cracked, the carefully polished veneer of the ‘Veteran Magical Girl’ finally splintering. “I promised them! I promised I wouldn’t be alone anymore! I have to protect them!”

The indigo girl remained unmoved. She didn’t flinch at Mami’s desperation. She simply continued her silent, predatory orbit, the air growing heavier and colder with every passing second.

“Are you the witch that killed me?” Mami blurted out, the question slipping from her before she could think it through. “The one who... took my life?”

The girl’s eyes, dark and endless, finally flickered with something resembling awareness. But instead of answering, she simply looked at Mami with that same unreadable expression, her presence heavy, like a cloud that had no intention of dispersing.

“What will happen to me?!” Mami shouted, her frustration boiling over. “Is this what happens to magical girls who get killed by witches? Or is there something more? What do you want from me? *Answer me!*”

The echo of Mami's scream died quickly in the vacuum. Then, finally, she spoke, her voice calm and yet imbued with an authority that made Mami freeze.

“You are asking too many questions,” she said, her tone almost dismissive. “You will receive no answers unless you defeat me.”

Mami froze. Her breath hitched. “Defeat you? Why? If you aren't a witch, then why do we have to fight? Just tell me what's happening!”

But the invitation for dialogue was over. The girl's posture shifted, her elegance sharpening into a lethal, martial poise. It was clear: the exit was through her.

Mami's pulse quickened. The dread that had clung to her like a second skin transformed. She hadn't come here for a duel, but if this strange entity was the only thing standing between her and a return to Madoka, then there was no choice left.

Her fingers curled around the manifested grip of a silver musket. The familiar weight of the weapon grounded her.

“Fine,” Mami muttered, her golden eyes narrowing with a familiar, fierce resolve. “I'll defeat you. But when you're down, you're going to tell me everything.”

The girl didn't smile. She simply raised a hand. The long ribbon coiled in the air, snapping like a whip, its edges glowing with a sharp, dangerous light.

“Then come, Mami Tomoe,” the girl commanded, her voice both a challenge and a funeral rite. “Show me what you can do.”

The tension in the void grew heavy enough to suffocate. Mami squared her shoulders, locking her eyes onto the mysterious indigo girl. Her pulse hammered against her ribs, adrenaline burning hot through her veins. She couldn't afford a single microsecond of hesitation—not when Madoka and Sayaka were still trapped in that grotesque labyrinth, believing she was dead. She needed answers, and she needed a doorway back to the waking world.

Her fingers locked onto the silver grip of her flintlock musket, her mind sharpening into a razor-edged focus. With a sudden, explosive motion, she lunged forward, firing a point-blank, precise shot.

The bullet sliced through the vacuum, a golden streak aimed directly at the stranger's chest.

But the girl moved with a terrifying, liquid fluidity. Bending her torso like water parting around a stone, she let the bullet whistle past her cheek by a mere fraction of an inch.

Mami's heart pounded, frustration mounting. *No*, she thought, *I can't afford to miss. I can't lose here!*

She took a step back, her mind calculating the next move. Golden ribbons uncoiled from her uniform sleeves with a brilliant flash, whipping through the air like a nest of golden vipers meant to snare the girl's ankles and waist.

But the stranger danced through the lattice of fabric with an elegance that defied her ominous presence. She pirouetted, her legs drawing graceful, lethal arcs in the air. With the swift strike of her heel, she deflected the lead ribbon.

Mami's eyes widened in disbelief. She had never seen anything like this before.

The girl didn't seem to be using any magic, wasn't wielding any weapon. She was moving purely with her body, every motion deliberate and precise. Her movements were swift, almost otherworldly, like a martial artist who had mastered every aspect of her form. It was like watching a delicate yet deadly dance, the way her limbs flowed to meet Mami's attacks, never once showing a hint of effort or strain.

Her hands, bare and graceful, deflected Mami's shots with the slightest of touches, like she was swatting away an annoying insect. When Mami launched a ribbon toward her, the girl's arm would move in an intricate arc, the ribbon deflecting off her palm with a fluidity that felt almost unnatural. Her strikes—small taps with her elbows, knees, or feet—sent Mami's ribbons spiraling off-course, harmlessly bouncing away.

Mami's frustration grew, but she refused to relent. She was not going to die here, not after everything. *I have to protect them. I have to get back.* Her gun fired again, and the girl dodged yet again, her body slipping out of the way like water slipping through Mami's fingers.

Mami summoned more guns, her hands moving in a blur as she called them into existence. Hundreds, thousands of guns appeared in an instant, hovering around her like deadly satellites. Her breath steadying, she aimed them in quick succession, the barrels pointing directly at the girl. There was no hesitation in her movement this time. With a fierce resolve, she unleashed a barrage of bullets, each one coming at the girl from a different angle.

She called upon more weapons, her mind a whirl of motions and calculations. But despite the barrage, the girl only continued to evade her with effortless grace. It was like trying to catch smoke with her bare hands. Each failed attempt chipped away at Mami's sanity.

And then, the chilling truth dawned on her.

Her opponent wasn't attacking. Not once had the girl raised a fist to strike or extended a hand to harm. Every graceful slip, every fluid block, was done purely to nullify Mami's offense. It felt like a game. It felt like she was being toyed with.

"Why won't you fight back?!" Mami spat, her voice cracking with a volatile mixture of exhaustion and fury.

She was panting now, her boots feeling as though they were lined with lead. She had been attacking relentlessly, burning through her magical reserves, but the girl before her hadn't even broken her composure. The girl remained entirely impassive, those deep, unreadable eyes tracking Mami's every ragged breath.

This isn't how magical girls fight, Mami realized, a cold dread pooling in her stomach.

In every other battle Mami had faced, whether against witches or other magical girls, the fighting style was always about magic or weapons. Even in the most skilled combatants, like her, the use of weapons, guns, and magic was an essential part of the equation. But this girl... this girl was something entirely different. She didn't seem to use magic and she definitely did not use weapons. She relied on her body alone, her every movement honed to perfection, as though she were beyond the need for conventional tools. Her mastery of physicality was so profound, it felt like she could read Mami's every move before it happened.

Sweat trickled down Mami's forehead as she launched another set of ribbons, trying to ensnare the girl in one of her traps. But the girl, once again, gracefully sidestepped, weaving through the ribbons like a dancer navigating a familiar stage.

Mami's breath was ragged now. *I can't keep this up much longer.*

The fight seemed endless. Mami's movements turned sluggish, the intense physical and mental strain taking a heavy toll.

Yet the girl stood unscathed, unwavering. Her serene face and unreadable gaze only deepened Mami's suffocating anxiety.

And as Mami's musket trembled in her grip, her stomach dropped as the final, terrifying realization clicked into place.

The girl wasn't trying to win. She wasn't even waiting for an opening to kill her.

She was just *waiting*.

Lowering her weapon slightly, Mami tried to catch her breath, her chest heaving. The vast void around them seemed to mimic the silence, holding its breath with them. The quiet stretched between them, heavy and judgmental.

Mami's pulse pounded in her ears, and her heart raced. It was as though the girl was simply waiting for her to reach some kind of breaking point. She wasn't here to *fight* Mami. She wasn't here to kill her. No. She was here to push Mami to the edge, to see how far she could go, how far Mami could endure.

Mami looked up, meeting that dark, endless gaze. There was no malice in those indigo eyes. There was only something far more terrifying: absolute, cosmic indifference.

The girl took one more effortless step forward, her posture poised, her silence delivering a clear, unvocalized challenge:

I am waiting. Show me how much further you can go before you finally understand.

Chapter 4: Breaking point

The air around Mami thickened, making every shallow inhale a labored agony. A crushing, leaden weight settled deep into her bones. She had given this fight everything. She had summoned fleets of artillery, fired endless volleys, and spun intricate webs of gold.

Nothing worked.

The girl danced, shifted, and slipped through every one of Mami's attacks like mist. The longer the fight wore on, the harder it became to keep up. The strain was starting to show.

The fire in her chest had dwindled to a dim, flickering ember.

I can't... I can't keep going.

Her mind screamed for rest, but the memory of Madoka and Sayaka pushed her onward, urging her to fight, to survive. *I promised them, she thought desperately. I promised to protect them.*

Her soul gem, once a brilliant hue, was now clouded. A murky, pitch-black sludge was rapidly blooming beneath the crystal's surface, turning it dull and cancerous. It pulsed weakly, sputtering out the final, corrupted remnants of her magical power.

Her hands trembled as she summoned another round of guns. Her breathing grew heavier. She hadn't even realized it—her desperation had clouded her thoughts, her fear had overtaken her reason. All she wanted was to go back. To save them. To protect them. But everything was slipping through her fingers like sand.

The girl stood perfectly still, watching the agonizing deconstruction of Mami's spirit with an unreadable, deadpan stare. Her absolute calm was a mockery of Mami's chaos.

It's useless. The thought hit Mami like a physical blow. *I gave everything I had. It's never enough. I can't do this anymore.*

Her soul gem flickered, the final remnants of her magic sputtering like a dying flame. Her mind swirled in a haze of hopelessness. The feeling of betrayal—the endless cycle of despair she had fought against for so long—washed over her. She had given so much, sacrificed so much, and for what? Madoka and Sayaka... She couldn't save them. She couldn't save anyone. And in the end, she was still alone.

The void seemed to actively collapse inward, pressing against her chest until she couldn't breathe. Every thought, every spark of magic, every shred of identity was being dragged down into a freezing abyss.

A sickening *crack* echoed through her mind. The delicate, beautiful crystal of her Soul Gem was beginning to splinter under the weight of her despair.

I'm losing. I'm breaking.

And then, just as she teetered on the absolute precipice of the abyss—the girl moved.

In the blink of an eye, she was there, right in front of Mami. The air shifted, and time seemed to stretch, the space around them warping. The girl extended a single finger, tapping Mami's soul gem with a delicate motion.

It was as if the very core of Mami's being had been stirred. The negativity, the suffocating sadness, the despair that had been consuming her—all of it poured out from her soul gem, like a torrent of black

smoke. The dark aura wrapped around the girl, swirling in the air, growing in intensity. It was like watching Mami's very essence—her broken spirit—gathered and consumed by the girl's presence.

Mami could only watch, her heart racing, as the girl stepped back. The darkness around her pulsed, an ominous, swirling mass that seemed to suffocate the space between them. The girl didn't say a word. She didn't need to.

Mami's hands fell to her sides, and the world felt like it was spinning. For a moment, she had no idea where she was, or who she was, or what was happening. The overwhelming weight of the despair that had been crushing her was gone, replaced by a strange, almost suffocating calm.

She felt... lighter. But there was something deeply unsettling about it.

She blinked, trying to clear the fog in her mind. Her soul gem—still in her hands—felt different. Almost... whole again. But the dullness still lingered. It hadn't gone away entirely.

What... what just happened?

Mami staggered, her legs barely holding her up. Her heart pounded. "What... what did you do?" she whispered, her voice hoarse and weak.

Her mind reeled as a terrifying realization hit her like a physical slap in the face. The dark smoke. The despair. The shattering soul gem. I don't understand," Mami muttered, her voice trembling violently. "Why did that happen? Was I really about to turn into a monster?"

The girl didn't answer right away, only watching Mami as if weighing her words.

Then she spoke again, her tone carrying an unsettling finality. "You're asking too many questions, Mami Tomoe." She tilted her head slightly, as if contemplating something. "If you want to return to the world you know, if you want to save those who are still alive, then you need to hurry. You're wasting time."

The words jolted Mami's heart. *Madoka... Sayaka...* The image of their tear-stained faces flashed in her mind. *I have to get back. I have to save them from Charlotte.*

But her body was giving out, her magic fading. The exhaustion that had accumulated over the course of the fight threatened to overwhelm her. Her soul gem pulsed weakly in her hand, the last remnants of her strength fading.

She had no cards left to play. No strategic options.

But she had to try anyway. She couldn't let them down.

With the absolute last drop of her willpower, Mami summoned her ribbons, her fingers shaking as she struggled to focus. "I'll defeat you. I'll... I'll end this."

She launched her final, desperate gamble—a single ribbon whipped through the air to bind the girl once and for all.

But the girl was already gone.

In the blink of an eye, she was before Mami before the golden ribbon could even fully extend. In a terrifying display of control, the girl consolidated the massive cloud of black smoke she had purged from Mami, compressing the raw despair into a sickening mass of swirling darkness in her hand.

Before Mami could even comprehend what was happening, the girl struck.

She drove her fist into Mami's chest. The force of the blow was so sudden and powerful that Mami's vision blurred, her body jerking violently as the dark energy slammed into her. Her soul gem pulsed one final time—an agonizing burst of light—and then everything went black.

Mami collapsed, her body crumpling to the ground like a ragdoll. The last thing she felt was the strange, overwhelming stillness as her consciousness faded.

And then, there was nothing.

Chapter 5: Mami's Awakening

When Mami's eyes fluttered open, the soft warmth of the bed beneath her felt almost like an illusion. The room around her was quiet, peaceful, and—strangely—familiar in a way she couldn't quite place. She sat up slowly, her head still fuzzy from the confusion of the past moments.

The walls were made of smooth, polished wood, their grain catching the dim light of the room. It wasn't the sterile, cold environment of a hospital or the desolate, empty void of a witch's lair. This was different—natural, serene. There was something earthy about it, as though the room itself was alive, its presence calming. The space was warm, almost as if inviting her to forget everything.

It was nighttime, and the window—more of an open space with no glass—offered an unobstructed view of the night sky. The moon hung high, bathing everything in its pale, ethereal light. Stars twinkled like diamonds scattered across a velvet cloth. Mami blinked, trying to steady her thoughts. What had happened? The last thing she remembered was the overwhelming sensation of losing herself, of her soul gem cracking under the weight of despair.

But now... now she felt something entirely different. Her mind felt clear, unclouded for the first time in what felt like forever. Her body, though still sore, was not weighed down by exhaustion or pain. It was as if everything—the fight, the hopelessness—had melted away, leaving only a tranquil emptiness behind.

A sound broke her reverie.

Music.

Soft, lilting notes, like the touch of a feather against her soul. The soothing melodies of a harp and a flute drifted through the air, inviting her, guiding her. Mami stood up, her bare feet sinking into the soft floor beneath her. She instinctively followed the sound, her steps light, as though the weight of the world had been lifted from her shoulders.

She stepped outside, and the beauty of her surroundings stunned her. The night air was cool and fresh, filling her lungs with the sweet scent of flowers and the rich, earthy fragrance of the forest. Tall trees stretched high above, their leaves swaying gently in the wind. The forest felt alive, full of quiet whispers in the night. As Mami walked through the trees, she noticed how everything seemed vibrant—there was an undeniable life here, an energy she hadn't felt in a long time.

The deeper she moved into the forest, the more the sound of music filled the air. The notes grew more intricate, harmonious, like threads woven into a tapestry of sound. It was as though the music was drawing her closer, luring her toward something... something peaceful. The trees around her began to thin, and soon the forest gave way to a vast, open landscape.

And there, before her, was the girl.

The mysterious figure who had shattered Mami's resolve only hours ago. The one who had pushed her to the edge of breaking. She was sitting on the grassy ground at the edge of a serene lake, her posture graceful and composed. The moonlight reflected off the water's surface, casting ripples of silvery light.

But what truly held Mami's gaze was the music.

The girl was playing a harp, her hands moving with smooth, fluid precision. The strings vibrated in perfect harmony with the sound of the flute. The flute itself hovered at her mouth, held by no visible hands, the buttons pressing themselves in time with the notes she blew. There was no flash of magical energy, no crackle of power—just an effortless, almost spiritual flow. It was the kind of magic that seemed to move with the world, not against it.

Mami stood transfixed by the scene, feeling something in her chest shift. The music wrapped around her like a warm embrace. Every note seemed to open a door inside her, unlocking emotions she hadn't felt in so long—peace, quiet, and a strange sense of belonging. It felt like home.

For a moment, she stood there, her breath slowing, her mind quieting. The weight of the world, the endless struggle, seemed to evaporate. It was the first time in a long while she felt truly... at ease. Her heart slowed, and her breathing deepened as the gentle harmony filled her.

Beyond the girl, the lake stretched out like a mirror, reflecting the clear, starry sky above. The mountains bordering the lake stood tall and imposing, their jagged peaks softened by the moonlight. The scene was so serene, so untouched by the chaos of the world, that Mami almost forgot—almost.

But the memory of Madoka, Sayaka, the world she had left behind, came rushing back. She couldn't afford to forget. Not now. Not yet.

Her mind stirred, and with it, the questions returned. Why was she here? What was happening? Was this a dream? A trap? Was she really safe? She had nearly become a witch. She needed answers. She needed to understand.

The girl finished the final, delicate note on the harp, her fingers pausing as the last chord faded into the air. The flute drifted gently away from her lips, the music dying slowly as the final echoes lingered in the night.

The world fell into a heavy silence, broken only by the sound of the water lapping gently at the shore. Mami felt the urge to ask the questions that burned inside her—the ones about what had happened, about the girl, about her soul gem—but the beauty of the moment made her hesitate. It was as if the stillness around her was urging her to let go of her fears, just for a little while.

The girl turned toward Mami then, her eyes meeting hers. Those eyes were as unreadable as ever—no malice, no kindness—just calm, distant neutrality.

For a long moment, the two simply stared at one another.

Mami broke the silence first, her voice soft and filled with awe. "That... the music, the scenery... it's beautiful. I've never heard anything like it." Her words were hesitant at first, but the calm of the moment urged her to speak freely. "The lake... and the mountains. It feels like something out of a dream."

The girl gave no verbal response at first, but her expression softened just a touch, and Mami caught the faintest glimmer of something—perhaps approval—flicker across her face. She looked as if she was about to say something, but then Mami's curiosity broke the silence again.

"Where am I?" Mami asked, her voice barely more than a whisper. "What is this place? What's happening? I don't understand."

The girl's eyes shifted, and this time Mami caught the change. There was a subtle shift in her demeanor—something that spoke of compassion, or perhaps understanding. The girl's lips parted slightly, and for the first time since Mami had met her, a smile played at the corners of her mouth. It was a faint, quiet smile, but it made Mami feel something—a kind of warmth that seemed to extend beyond the cold, distant force she had come to expect.

"You are in a place between places," the girl said slowly, her voice carrying a weight of understanding that made Mami feel both at ease and unsettled. "A place where the burdens of the world can be set down for a moment, where you can find what is lost."

Mami blinked, still trying to make sense of it all. "Between places?"

The girl nodded, her eyes gentle. "It is not a place for the living or the dead. It is a place for those who need to find clarity, before they are called to move forward."

Mami absorbed the words, but they didn't quite settle. "And the others... Madoka? Sayaka?"

The girl's smile grew ever so slightly, and this time, her eyes softened. "They are fine."

Mami's heart skipped a beat, the tension in her chest loosening at last. "They are... okay?"

The girl nodded, her expression now open, her gaze shifting to the horizon. "Homura saved them. She made sure they were kept safe."

At those words, Mami's breath caught. "Homura... saved them?" She had to ask again, the words not fully sinking in. "But... I thought... I thought I was... too late?"

"No," the girl said softly, "You were not too late. Homura acted quickly once you were... gone. She made sure Madoka and Sayaka were protected, kept them safe from what followed."

Mami's mind swirled with relief, but there was also a strange emptiness inside her. She wanted to thank the girl, wanted to say something in response, but her mind refused to stop spinning. Her body trembled slightly with the flood of emotions that had washed over her—relief, fear, sadness, confusion.

The girl seemed to sense this and, without a word, extended her hand. A soft pulse of magic swirled from her fingertips, and Mami blinked in surprise as a shimmering projection appeared in the air before them. The image was translucent but vivid, as though it were woven from the very essence of the night sky.

Mami leaned in, her eyes wide, as she saw the images unfold.

It was a scene she recognized—a flash of light, a series of sharp, precise movements. Homura, standing tall in the midst of a chaotic world, wielding a weapon with deadly grace. And then, in the projection, Mami saw Madoka and Sayaka, their faces full of fear and confusion, as Homura guided them toward safety.

The scene shifted. Mami saw herself, though the image was clouded, distant—a flickering, fractured version of her own body as the life left her. Her soul gem, shattered and dim. The moment she had lost herself completely. But then the projection shifted again, showing Homura, her eyes filled with quiet determination, acting with precision. The scenes unfolded quickly—Homura's skillful defense, her ability to shield her friends from the chaos, and her determination to save them from the fate Mami had feared.

Mami's throat tightened as she watched the projection. For the first time in what felt like forever, she could see that her death had not been in vain. Homura had stepped in—had protected Madoka and Sayaka. They were alive. Mami thought she saw Homura, for the briefest of moments, grimace in sorrow when she saw Mami's dead corpse.

But even with that relief, Mami felt an undeniable pang of guilt and doubt. Had this been what Homura had been trying to warn us about before... when I bound her?

Mami's heart sank as the questions rose in her mind. She had forced Homura's hand, tried to control her. Had she truly understood the magnitude of what was coming? And now, after everything... had Homura known something all along? Was this the path she had feared—the path Mami had forced her into?

"Homura..." Mami whispered, almost as if saying the name to herself.

The girl stood silently, allowing Mami to process the images. There was no rush, no interruption. The girl simply watched, her eyes calm, but there was something in her gaze that Mami couldn't quite place. It wasn't pity. It was something more understanding, more knowing.

"She is always so cold and distant, always wanting to prevent Madoka from becoming a magical girl..." Mami muttered, her voice heavy. "But she did try to warn me before I bound her, and I can see the brief sadness on her face in your projection. Who is she? What does she know?"

The girl replied slowly, her voice measured and calm, "Homura has been through more than you can imagine. Someday you will understand."

Mami frowned, her brow furrowing in frustration. "I need to know. If I've done something wrong... if I've hurt her—"

"You've done what you thought was best," the girl interrupted gently. "But there are pieces of the puzzle that you cannot yet see. Not yet."

Mami opened her mouth to say something else, but the girl raised a hand, silencing her. "Your path is not over. The future is not set. And you may yet find a way to mend what has been broken."

Mami felt a strange mixture of frustration and hope stirring inside her. She didn't understand everything, but one thing was clear: the girl knew more than she was letting on. And though that made Mami uneasy, she couldn't shake the feeling that it was necessary. Perhaps, this was the beginning of something she needed to understand.

Chapter 6: The Truth Beneath

Mami stood there in the stillness, the weight of the revelation settling around her. For a moment, she said nothing. Her thoughts swirled, fragmented pieces of her past life and the fight she had just been through clouding her mind.

The girl, as if sensing Mami's struggle, broke the silence with a soft smile. It was not one of pity or mockery, but a quiet understanding that somehow made Mami feel both seen and unheard, as if she was being held in an unspoken space of empathy.

The girl rose to her feet gracefully, the light from the moon reflecting in her dark eyes. She seemed calm, even serene, but there was a certain heaviness in her presence as she began to speak again.

"I owe you an apology," she said, her voice measured and calm.

Mami looked up, confused. "Apology?"

"Yes," the girl continued, her gaze steady. "During our fight, I... I lied to you. White-lied, if you will. I wanted you to get to the breakpoint of becoming something else. And there was only one way to make you truly understand what was happening. Now, you are here. I can explain."

Mami felt a cold chill run down her spine at the girl's words. *White-lied*? That word carried a weight of betrayal. She remembered how she had felt, the overwhelming despair, the way the girl had manipulated her emotions.

"You... you lied to me?" Mami whispered, her heart constricting. She had fought to the edge of her own mind, her soul gem cracked under the strain of that lie. To hear the truth now felt like an unbearable shift in everything she thought she knew.

The girl nodded, her expression unchanging. "I had to. I wanted you to get to the breakpoint of becoming something else. And there was only one way to make you truly understand what was happening. Now, you are here. I can explain."

Mami's breath hitched, her mind reeling with questions. "What do you mean, 'becoming something else'? What was that fight about? What was happening to me?"

The girl looked at her with a deep, searching gaze before responding, her voice taking on a grave tone. "You see, Mami, magical girls are never meant to remain as they are. The truth Kyubey hides from you, from all of you, is that every magical girl inevitably becomes a witch."

Mami's heart skipped. "What... what do you mean? That can't be true. No, I—"

The girl raised a hand, cutting her off gently. "Listen. You've never asked the right questions. Kyubey never told you the truth, because you never asked. But now, I will tell you everything."

Mami stood frozen as the girl's words began to sink in, her stomach turning with disbelief. *Every magical girl? Becomes a witch?* The words felt impossible, yet the calm, somber look in the girl's eyes spoke of something far darker, far deeper than Mami was ready to accept.

"You see," the girl continued, "Kyubey, that creature you've all relied on, created the contract with a single goal: to prevent the universe from collapsing. The emotions of young girls, their hopes, dreams, fears... it all creates a kind of energy. A powerful energy, more powerful than anything else in existence. Kyubey uses that energy to stabilize the universe, to maintain balance."

Mami shook her head, trying to make sense of the words. "But... we're fighting witches. We're supposed to stop them, not become them."

"Yes," the girl replied softly, "that's the lie. The truth is that witches are born from the negative emotions of magical girls—the despair, the sorrow, the pain. It is the inevitable result of the path you walk. As a magical girl faces loss, trauma, and heartbreak, her soul gem becomes tainted, and eventually, she succumbs to the overwhelming emotions. At that moment, she becomes a witch."

Mami felt her knees weaken. The ground seemed to shift beneath her feet. "I... I almost became a witch?"

The girl nodded, her voice unflinching. "Yes. Your soul gem was cracked, Mami. You were on the edge. Your despair, your sadness over your fate, over the pain of losing others—it was pushing you to the brink. That was why I had to make you feel desperate, to show you what was at risk. So you could understand."

Mami's mind spun. The girl's words hit like a gut punch, each one unraveling the foundation of everything she thought she knew. Kyubey, the contracts, the endless cycle of fighting and losing—everything suddenly felt like a twisted lie.

"But... Kyubey... he told us that magical girls were the solution," Mami whispered. "That we were saving people from witches."

The girl's eyes darkened, a flicker of anger or perhaps regret flashing across her face. "That's another piece of the lie. Kyubey has never cared for you. You are simply a means to an end for him. The energy you create is more important than your well-being, your lives. And once a magical girl succumbs to despair... she becomes a witch, a vessel of chaotic energy. That energy is then consumed by the universe, maintaining its balance."

Mami's chest tightened, the weight of this revelation threatening to crush her. She had never even considered the true cost of what they did—fighting to save people, only to create more chaos in the process. Was that the price of her powers all along? Was Kyubey's *true* purpose to turn them into these... these vessels for energy?

"But what about the grief seeds?" Mami asked, her voice shaky. "We use them to purify our soul gems, to stop ourselves from turning into witches. How does that fit into all of this?"

The girl's gaze softened, as if preparing for the final blow. "Grief seeds are only a temporary solution, Mami. They clean the taint from your soul gems for a time, but the root of the problem is deeper. It's the emotions themselves—the very thing that Kyubey feeds off of. The seeds can't change the inevitable."

Mami could feel her heart breaking. The foundation of her entire existence as a magical girl—the one thing that had kept her going—was built on a lie.

She was never saving anyone. She was only feeding the machine.

Her vision blurred as the weight of it all crashed down on her. "So, I was never really... saving anyone?" she asked, the words tasting bitter on her tongue. "It was all just... a way to create more energy for the universe?"

The girl's voice was soft, yet firm. "Yes. That's what Kyubey does. That's what he's always done."

Mami's hands trembled, and for the first time in a long while, she felt small. Weak.

The girl's gaze remained steady, her dark eyes watching Mami carefully. The silence between them was not uncomfortable, but heavy with anticipation. Finally, she spoke again, her voice calm yet layered with a certain weight.

"What did you feel, Mami?" she asked. "What do you remember from that moment when you were about to become a witch?"

Mami closed her eyes for a moment, the memories flooding her like a tide. The crushing despair, the emptiness gnawing at her, and the utter helplessness she had felt as her soul gem cracked—fragments of her past life dissolving, her very essence breaking apart.

“I remember... the despair,” Mami said slowly, her voice distant as if she was reliving it in real time. “I was so tired. So hopeless. Like everything I fought for had been in vain. My soul gem felt like it was breaking under the weight of everything I couldn’t save.” She shook her head, as if trying to shake off the remnants of that overwhelming feeling. “It felt like I was about to vanish, to lose myself completely. To become... something else.”

The girl listened intently, her expression never changing, but Mami noticed the slight shift in her gaze as she absorbed the words.

“I see,” the girl said softly. “And that moment of despair, that fracture in your soul gem—it’s what triggers the transformation. The negative emotions that build up over time create the power needed to make you a witch. That is what Kyubey never told you, because you never asked.” She paused, as if reflecting on her own words. “He needs that power, Mami. The energy a magical girl generates, when she succumbs to despair, is used to fuel the universe—keeps it in balance.”

Mami’s mind reeled with this new information, her thoughts racing. *A witch... made to fuel the universe?* It was almost too much to process. And the way Kyubey had hidden this truth from them... it made her feel as though everything she had ever known had been built on lies.

But before she could voice her growing questions, the girl continued.

“And what I did to your soul gem,” she said, “wasn’t just removing the negativity—it was using it in a way that could be useful, for both you and the universe.”

Mami blinked, unsure if she had heard correctly. “You used my soul gem’s negativity?”

The girl nodded. “Yes. The key is that negative emotions, if used correctly, can be converted into great power. It’s the same principle that applies to when a magical girl becomes a witch. When a soul gem breaks, that energy is released into the universe—creating something powerful, something that can fuel the cosmic balance Kyubey is so obsessed with. But that power, when harnessed in the right way, doesn’t have to create a witch. It can be used for something else entirely.”

Mami’s mind was racing. “So, you... you used my despair as power?”

“Yes,” the girl replied. “Do you know of the concept of ‘**Connect**’? The ability that allows magical girls to synchronize their powers with one another?”

Mami blinked, nodding slowly. “Yes. I’ve heard of it. It’s how magical girls can work together, use each other’s abilities more effectively, and fuse their own powers. But I was fighting alone so I never had the chance to do it.”

The girl nodded. “Exactly. Now, what I’m about to explain to you is a reverse of that ability—what I call ‘**dis-connect**.’ In this process, I can physically disconnect any magical energy, including negativity,

from a magical girl's soul gem. It's a delicate process, but it allows me to siphon that negative energy and use it, redirecting it without letting it corrupt the magical girl's essence."

Mami stared, trying to process everything the girl was saying. "You... you did that to me? You disconnected my negativity, and then used it in the attack that... knocked me out?"

The girl's expression softened. "Yes. And once I did that, the energy was released, dissipating back into the universe, as it was always meant to."

Mami felt a weight lift off her chest, and the flood of confusion that had been clouding her mind began to clear. *This is it. This is the hope I was looking for.* She had been shown a path to survive, to fight without losing herself.

"So... there's a way to use our negative emotions without falling into despair? Without becoming a witch?" Mami asked, her voice quiet but filled with a newfound sense of purpose.

The girl nodded. "Yes. You can continue. You can fight. And you don't have to become a witch."

Mami felt something deep inside her stir—a warmth, a reassurance that she hadn't felt in so long. The weight of her past struggles, her self-doubt, and her fear were all suddenly... bearable. There was hope. Real hope. The energy inside her could be used, not just to fight, but to grow.

For the first time in a long time, Mami felt as though she had a choice.

The girl's expression softened once more as Mami absorbed her explanation. "While the negative energy is dissipated back into the universe, your soul gem will not replenish its magic. It's not a permanent solution. If you continue to use your powers without rest, your magic will diminish, and your soul gem's color will become duller over time."

Mami's brow furrowed, trying to fully grasp the implications of this new information. "So... I can't just keep going indefinitely. I still have to be careful."

The girl nodded. "Yes. Rest is essential. Your soul gem, like you, needs time to recover and restore itself. You cannot simply fight without considering the toll it takes on you.

However, even when your soul gem's color is dull from overuse, as long as you do not succumb to negativity, you will not become a witch"

Mami took a deep breath, trying to process everything she had learned. The weight of the situation was heavy, but there was something inside her now—an understanding that she hadn't had before. *There's still hope,* she thought. *I don't have to fall to despair.*

"But... but why? Why would you help me? Why not let me become a witch?"

The girl smiled faintly. "Because I wasn't trying to let you become a witch, Mami. I was trying to show you that there is a way to harness what seems like destruction and turn it into something else. I wanted you to see that there's always another choice—one that doesn't involve succumbing to the darkness."

Mami's heart raced, but a glimmer of hope began to form inside her chest. She wasn't alone. There was a way to keep going, to keep fighting without falling into despair. Her soul gem could be saved—not just by external forces, but through understanding how to use that very energy that threatened to consume her.

"Thank you," Mami said softly, her voice filled with gratitude. "Thank you for explaining all of this to me. I... I think I understand now. And I want to learn more. I want you to teach me."

The girl smiled, the warmth of her expression unmistakable, though it held a trace of something deeper. "Of course. But for now, you must rest. Your soul gem hasn't fully recovered from your battles, and it is nighttime. The training will begin tomorrow."

Mami nodded, feeling the weight of her body's exhaustion settle in now that her mind had begun to settle. The girl was right; she needed to rest. The journey she had been through, both physical and emotional, had drained her more than she realized. She hadn't even noticed until now how much she needed this reprieve.

Together, they turned to walk back toward the cabin. As they stepped through the forest, Mami couldn't help but marvel at the scenery. The soft rustle of the leaves in the wind, the moonlight filtering through the branches of trees, casting long shadows on the ground—it all felt surreal. The air was fresh, filled with the scent of pine and earth, and everything seemed alive in a way that grounded her. It was beautiful here, peaceful, as if the world itself was breathing in sync with her.

"This place," Mami said quietly, almost to herself, "It's unlike anything I've ever seen."

The girl, walking beside her, glanced up at the canopy above, where the stars peeked through the gaps in the trees. "I like it here, too. It brings me peace," she said, her voice soft. There was something wistful in her tone, something that made Mami feel as though there was more to the girl than what she had shown so far. But she didn't press her for more.

They reached the cabin, and as they entered, the girl led Mami back toward the bedroom. The warmth of the bed seemed to call to Mami, her body too tired to resist the pull. She looked over at the girl before she could slip beneath the covers.

"Who are you?" Mami asked, her voice carrying a note of curiosity and wonder. "I still don't know your name, or what your purpose is. You've helped me, but... I don't understand who you really are. Are you a magical girl?"

The girl stopped at the door, her hand resting gently on the frame. She looked over her shoulder at Mami, her face softening, but there was a sadness in her eyes that Mami hadn't noticed before. The girl smiled, but it was different from before—it held an edge of nostalgia, as if remembering something long past.

"Maybe... maybe another time," the girl said, her voice tinged with an emotion Mami couldn't quite place. And with that, she turned, disappearing quietly into the shadows of the cabin.

Mami watched her go, her heart filled with questions that would have to wait. *Another time*, she thought, settling into the soft bed, her eyes closing as sleep began to claim her. She could feel the weight of everything she had learned, the uncertainty of the future, but also a spark of hope she hadn't dared to allow herself before.

Tomorrow, she would train. Tomorrow, she would learn more. And with each new day, she would fight, but this time, she would do it with understanding. She would keep her soul gem safe. She would make the right choices.

And for the first time in a long while, Mami felt that maybe—just maybe—there was a future for her beyond the despair.

Chapter 7: A Fresh Start

Mami awoke with a clarity she hadn't known in years. The light that filtered in through the open window of the cabin felt warm and welcoming, and her body felt alive—refreshed, not just physically, but emotionally as well. She stretched out under the soft covers, her muscles awakening with a satisfying stretch. Her mind was calm, free from the burden of the constant battles and the weight of her responsibilities. The sense of peace that surrounded her was like a balm to her soul.

Mami's gaze moved to her soul gem, resting on the small wooden table beside her. It had been dull and murky just a short while ago, cracked and on the verge of shattering. Now, it gleamed brightly, its colors vivid and clear, as if the entire sky had poured into it. She blinked, feeling a sense of awe. It had been a long time since she'd seen her soul gem in such a state. She smiled softly, the thought of her old self—burdened and hopeless—feeling like a distant memory.

When she stood and approached the door, Mami noticed the soft sounds of movement coming from outside. She stepped out onto the cabin's porch and was greeted by the sight of the girl, who was performing a series of graceful stretches. Her movements were fluid, almost as if she were dancing, each motion a delicate expression of strength and serenity. The way she flowed through the stretches made it seem like she was in perfect harmony with the world around her, as if the forest itself was moving with her.

The morning sunlight kissed the girl's features, making her look even more ethereal. There was something about her presence that made Mami feel grounded in a way she hadn't felt in a long time.

"Good morning, Mami," the girl said, her voice as soft and calming as the gentle breeze rustling the leaves around them. "How did you sleep?"

Mami returned the greeting, feeling a lightness in her heart. "Good morning," she replied, her voice filled with a warmth she hadn't realized she'd been missing. "I slept better than I have in a long time. I feel... so much better. My soul gem is shining so brightly."

The girl's eyes softened as she smiled, her movements continuing with the same fluidity. "I'm glad to hear that," she said, her tone laced with genuine warmth. "Would you like to join me for some morning exercises?"

Mami hesitated for a moment, feeling an unexpected wave of happiness wash over her. For the first time in what felt like forever, someone was here for her. Someone was here to greet her in the morning, not as a battle partner or a comrade in arms, but as a friend. It felt strange but comforting.

"I'd like that," Mami said, her voice carrying a quiet gratitude. "It's been a long time since anyone has asked me to do something like this."

The girl nodded and moved into a flowing stretch, and Mami followed her, a smile tugging at her lips. She couldn't help but feel at peace here, surrounded by the serenity of the forest and the calm presence of the girl.

As they moved through the exercises, the girl spoke again, her voice steady and gentle. "A magical girl's soul gem is a reflection of her magical power. When a magical girl uses her power or succumbs to negative emotions, the soul gem dulls. But with rest and a calm mind, the soul gem is able to recover. It's not just about grief seeds," the girl explained, her words carrying a sense of calm wisdom.

Mami paused mid-stretch, surprised by the revelation. "I always thought a soul gem could only recover with a grief seed," she said, her brow furrowing. "I never knew that rest and emotional peace could help it recover."

The girl smiled, her expression serene as she nodded. "Many magical girls believe the same, but it's a misconception that has been ingrained over time. Grief seeds do help, but they are not the only solution. When a soul gem is in harmony with its owner's emotions, it can recover naturally. You were just in a state of imbalance before. But now, with proper rest and peace of mind, your soul gem is able to replenish itself effectively."

Mami absorbed this new knowledge, a sense of wonder blooming in her chest. "So... this means I don't have to rely on constant battles and grief seeds just to survive?" Her voice was almost hopeful, as though she had just discovered a new way forward, a new path she could walk without the constant weight of despair.

"Exactly," the girl said with a gentle smile. "Your soul gem will be your guide. It will tell you when you need rest, when you need to pause and reflect. And when you find peace, you'll find strength."

Mami smiled, feeling lighter than she had in a long time. She had always believed that magical girls had to keep fighting, keep pushing through the pain. But now, it felt as though she had discovered a new way to live—one that didn't rely on endless sacrifice.

She joined the girl in the next stretch, feeling the fluidity of the movement, the serenity in the air, and for the first time in ages, she didn't feel like she was fighting just to survive.

As the morning sun climbed higher in the sky, Mami felt a sense of peace and hope fill her chest, a warmth she hadn't felt in a long time. For the first time in what felt like forever, Mami truly believed there was a way forward.

The morning air was crisp and fresh as Mami and the girl finished their stretching exercises. Mami felt the strength in her body return with each movement, her muscles fluid and relaxed. The girl moved

with an elegance that made it seem like she was part of the forest itself—her form a graceful extension of the natural world. When they finished, the girl turned to Mami with a serene smile.

"Would you like to join me on a walk to gather food for breakfast?" she asked, her voice still gentle but carrying a certain invitation that made Mami feel both curious and eager to spend more time with her.

Mami nodded, still feeling lighter and more at ease than she had in ages. "I'd love to, but... how exactly do we gather food?" she asked, unsure of what to expect.

The girl's smile deepened, and with a small nod, she led Mami into the forest, her movements fluid and confident. Mami followed, her senses attuned to the peaceful sounds of the woods—the rustle of leaves, the soft calls of birds in the distance, and the occasional whisper of wind through the trees.

As they walked, the girl reached out to gently touch the plants that lined the path—delicate ferns, towering trees, and clusters of flowers. With each touch, Mami noticed something strange. There was no visible change in the plants, no immediate sign of any effect, but it was as if the air around them shimmered for a moment, and something seemed to shift in the surrounding environment. The girl smiled with quiet satisfaction as she continued her walk.

Mami blinked in wonder as a small creature—a rabbit, with soft fur and bright eyes—bounded toward them. It paused for a moment, eyeing the girl cautiously. The girl knelt down and extended her hand slowly, and the rabbit, seemingly unafraid, hopped closer to her. With a gentle touch, the girl stroked its fur, and the animal sat calmly in her presence.

"Is that... normal?" Mami asked, her curiosity piqued. "How did the animals approach you so easily?"

The girl's smile remained calm, serene. "I have a bond with nature," she explained, her voice calm and almost lyrical. "The plants and animals respond to me because they understand my intentions. I do not seek to harm them. I simply exist as part of their world."

Mami watched, entranced, as more animals—squirrels, birds, even a small deer—came to the girl, each drawn by the same calm energy that surrounded her. It was as though the forest itself was welcoming them.

After a while, the girl rose, and they continued walking deeper into the woods. Mami followed silently, still processing the strange, quiet magic of the girl's presence. They reached a clearing, and the girl turned to her, her eyes gleaming with a soft satisfaction.

"That's enough for now," she said, her voice as peaceful as the stillness around them. "Go back to the cabin. I will finish here."

Mami frowned in confusion. "But... we didn't gather anything. No food, no plants, no animals."

The girl turned to her, offering a calm and knowing smile. "You don't need to worry about that," she said. "I do not take from nature. Instead, I take its essence." She raised her hand, and the air around them seemed to shimmer once more. "I can use the energy of the plants and animals I touch. The

essence of life flows through everything, and I can create food from it without disturbing the balance of nature."

Mami stood still for a moment, the realization slowly sinking in. "Wait... you can create food just from the essence of plants and animals?" She blinked, the concept so far beyond anything she had ever known. "That's... incredible."

The girl nodded softly. "It's a gentle way of living with the world, instead of taking from it. The essence is already there. I simply channel it into something tangible. No harm done. Only what is needed."

Mami's mind was spinning, trying to make sense of it all. She had always been so used to fighting for every scrap of food, every moment of peace. To live in harmony with nature, without taking more than what was necessary, felt like a completely different existence.

They made their way back to the cabin, and when they arrived, the girl began working her quiet magic. With a subtle gesture, the air shimmered again, and ingredients began to form from the essences she had gathered—the soft glow of the forest air surrounding them. Fruits, grains, vegetables—all began to take shape on the table in front of them, as though the world itself had provided them everything they needed.

Mami watched in awe as the girl moved effortlessly, her hands weaving through the air, as if she were composing a symphony of ingredients. The girl smiled gently as she began preparing the food, and Mami joined in, her heart light as she helped chop and prepare what had been gathered—though, in truth, it felt like it had been given rather than gathered.

As they cooked, the girl spoke softly, as if trying to understand Mami's heart. "I haven't had the chance to ask you much about yourself, Mami. What was your life like before you became a magical girl?"

Mami hesitated, the question stirring something deep within her. The memories of her past—of the warmth of her family, of a time when things had felt simple and good—rose to the surface. Her smile was faint, touched with both sadness and a quiet sense of acceptance.

"My family... they died in a car crash when I was young," Mami began softly, her voice distant. "I was left alone after that, and I made a wish to become a magical girl, not to save the world, but just to survive. I thought if I could become strong enough, I wouldn't have to face the emptiness. I could keep fighting, keep pushing forward, even if I was all alone."

The girl listened in silence, her gaze steady, her presence calm and unhurried. Mami's words came slowly, as if the act of sharing them allowed the weight to lift just a little. "From then on, I fought alone. I found a teammate, but she left, and I kept moving from one battle to the next, trying to hold onto something... anything."

A faint smile tugged at Mami's lips as she stirred the ingredients in the pot, the warmth of the fire and the food filling the small cabin with a sense of home. "I never imagined that one day, I'd be cooking breakfast and sharing it with someone."

The girl smiled, her expression soft and understanding. "Sometimes, the things we long for most are the simplest, aren't they?"

Mami nodded, her heart lighter than it had been in a long time. They finished preparing the meal together, and when the food was ready, they sat down at the small table, enjoying the peaceful quiet of the morning. For the first time in a long time, Mami felt a sense of belonging—a connection, not through battle, but through something simple and real.

And for that moment, everything felt right.

Chapter 8: The First Test

After breakfast, Mami felt a strange sense of calm, the fullness of her stomach mingling with the lingering peace she felt since waking up. The morning's exercises, the quiet moments shared with the girl, and the unexpected comfort of having company—it was a stark contrast to everything she had known before.

Mami was still lost in thought when the girl's voice gently pulled her from her musings. "Are you ready to begin your training?"

Mami nodded, her resolve firm. "Yes, I'm ready."

The girl smiled, and before Mami could take another breath, the world around them shimmered. The scenery warped, the peaceful cabin fading from view as they were suddenly enveloped by an otherworldly glow. Mami's heart skipped a beat as she saw the familiar scene.

The muted colors, the air thick with an unfamiliar weight, as if the very fabric of reality was stretched too thin. It was a vast, empty space, a shifting void of soft, swirling lights and shadows.

They stood in the place where the girl and Mami fought the previous day.

The girl, standing confidently next to Mami, noticed the change in her expression. "This is the place where we will train," she said, her tone cool and controlled. "Here, you can face any opponent, and here, you can push yourself to grow without the risk of dying for real."

Mami blinked, surprised. "We're going to train here?"

The girl nodded. "Yes. In this realm, the battles are real, but there are no lasting consequences. It's the perfect place to learn without fear of truly losing everything."

Before Mami could respond, the air around them shimmered again. This time, a chilling, familiar presence filled the space, and the ground trembled underfoot. Mami's breath caught in her throat as she saw her—Charlotte, the witch that had torn her apart only the day before.

Charlotte's grotesque form emerged from the shadows, her long, twisted body slithering toward them with an eerie, disturbing grace. Her eyes locked onto Mami, filled with malice.

Mami froze, a knot of fear tightening in her chest. The memory of defeat flooded back—the crushing feeling of hopelessness, of being powerless. She had been so sure of herself then, so confident, but now, seeing Charlotte again, that confidence shattered. The cold terror of facing the witch again left Mami rooted to the spot.

Mami swallowed hard, but the fear didn't vanish. Charlotte was drawing closer, her distorted, monstrous form closing the distance with frightening speed. Her mouth stretched open in a grotesque grin, her intentions clear: to kill.

But then Mami felt something shift. A flicker of the resolve she'd found over the past few days. The warmth of the girl's presence lingered in her chest, and something within her sparked. She wasn't that same girl anymore. She couldn't be. Not after everything she had been through.

With trembling hands, Mami summoned her weapon. Her gun appeared in a flash, and instinctively, she raised it, pointing it at Charlotte's advancing form. But when she fired, something unexpected happened.

The bullet that shot from the barrel was no ordinary blast. It was huge, larger than anything Mami had ever conjured. The force behind it was immense, a powerful blast of energy that roared through the air, leaving a trail of white light.

Mami looked away instinctively, bracing for the impact of her attack. The blast hit Charlotte with overwhelming force. There was a deafening sound, like thunder crashing through the sky, and the witch was sent sprawling back, her body writhing in pain.

Mami's heart raced. What had just happened? That attack was far stronger than anything she had ever done before.

Charlotte let out a guttural hiss as the attack struck her. Though she was heavily injured, she wasn't finished yet. Her grotesque form, still twitching and seething with fury, rose again. The witch's eyes locked onto Mami, the malicious gleam still burning in them.

Mami stood still for a moment, her breath coming in shallow bursts. Her heart was racing, her adrenaline still coursing through her veins from the earlier blast. She hadn't expected it to be so easy. Charlotte should have been far harder to defeat. The witch's body writhed, but Mami wasn't about to let her get back up. She needed to keep going.

Summoning her weapon, Mami called upon her ribbons. With a practiced motion, she sent them flying toward Charlotte, expecting the same restrained attack she had always used. But as soon as the ribbons left her hands, Mami was struck with shock. The ribbons were massive, their speed and force far beyond anything she had ever done before. The threads of magic that powered her ribbons felt *alive*, humming with an intensity she had never known.

The ribbons wrapped around Charlotte with unrelenting force, coiling tighter and tighter, crushing her twisted form. Charlotte screeched, her body contorting violently in the constricting grip of the ribbons.

Mami kept her focus, the ribbons squeezing harder, and soon Charlotte's monstrous form crumbled, torn apart by the sheer strength of the attack.

The air was still, the battle over in an instant. Mami stared at the remnants of the witch's shattered body, her mind spinning. She had hardly *tried* to make such a powerful attack, yet the result had been overwhelming.

From the corner of her eye, she saw the girl walking toward her, a small smile on her lips as she clapped her hands softly. "Well done, Mami," she said with approval. "You've made great progress."

Mami turned to the girl, still stunned by what had just happened. "What... what was that?" Her voice was trembling slightly with disbelief. "Why were my attacks so much stronger? That was just my usual gun and ribbon attacks... I wasn't even trying to make them that big!"

The girl's smile deepened as she stood next to Mami, eyes warm but calculating. "Your soul gem," she began, "is shining brightly. It's in a much better state than it was before, and that's because you've finally had the rest you needed. When you're in a good emotional state, when your mind is clear and at peace, your magical power increases naturally. You were struggling with loneliness and sadness for so long, and now that those negative emotions are starting to fade, your potential is shining through."

Mami blinked in surprise. "So... it's because I'm not constantly weighed down by my grief and fear anymore?"

"Exactly," the girl confirmed, her voice steady and kind. "That's a major factor. Your soul gem is no longer dimmed by all the negative emotions you used to carry. That alone has given you a significant power boost. But there's more."

Mami listened intently as the girl continued, her expression thoughtful.

"You're also starting to use those negative emotions differently. You were afraid during that fight, weren't you? And that fear... you used it. Not much, but just a little bit. You didn't even realize it, but that fear *amplified* your attack."

Mami's heart skipped a beat. "You mean... I used fear to make my guns and ribbons stronger?"

The girl nodded. "Fear, sadness, anger—these emotions can be wielded, not just fought against. They're powerful, Mami, and when used properly, they can fuel your magic. You've taken the first step in learning how to use them instead of letting them overwhelm you. That fear made your guns and ribbons stronger than usual. It wasn't a large amount, but it was a good start. And the more you learn to control it, the more power you'll be able to harness."

Mami's mind raced as the weight of the girl's words settled in. She had always thought of negative emotions as a weakness, as something that made her falter. But now, she realized they could be a source of strength—a way to *amplify* her abilities.

"It's strange," Mami said quietly, her voice almost to herself. "I never thought fear could help me. It always felt like something I had to fight against."

The girl's expression softened, her eyes filled with a kind of knowing. "You've been fighting it all along, but what if you could work with it instead? What if you could *accept* it and let it make you stronger?"

Mami thought about it for a long moment. It was a lot to take in, but something in her felt... lighter. More hopeful. The girl wasn't just giving her power, she was teaching her how to wield it herself. And that made all the difference.

Mami smiled, a little more sure of herself than she had been in a long time. "I think I'm starting to understand."

The girl paused, her gaze shifting to the distance for a moment, as though weighing her words carefully. Then, she turned back to Mami, her expression serious yet reassuring.

"Now that you've begun to grasp the basics," the girl began, her voice steady, "it's time to learn higher-level techniques. These are things that will truly make you stronger—if you can master them."

Mami listened intently, her heart beating faster with both excitement and a hint of nervousness. She was starting to feel like she had the tools to take control of her fate, but she knew the road ahead wouldn't be easy.

"The first skill," the girl continued, "is to intentionally use your negative emotions to amplify your attacks. This is the next step after using them in response to fear, sadness, or anger, as you did during your fight with Charlotte. You've learned to harness them as they come, but to take full advantage of this power, you need to learn how to control and use them *on purpose*."

Mami nodded, her brow furrowed as she processed the information. "So, like... controlling my fear, anger, or sadness when I need it?" she asked.

"Exactly," the girl said with a nod. "But there's a more advanced technique. Instead of letting those emotions surge and fade as they come, you can let them build up over time. The more you can hold and store those feelings, the greater the energy you can release in a single attack. But there's a catch: the longer you hold on to them, the more dangerous it becomes. It's a balancing act."

Mami's eyes widened. "Dangerous? How?"

"If you let too much negativity accumulate, it can start to corrupt you," the girl explained, her voice steady. "You risk losing control. That's why it's crucial to have the discipline to recognize when to release that power and when to hold back. The most effective time to use this technique is just before you're about to become a witch—like when I used your negative energy during our fight, when you were on the verge of losing yourself. At that point, your soul gem is at its most fragile, but your negative emotions are also at their peak, making the energy much stronger."

Mami shuddered slightly at the memory of that moment—the terror, the despair, the overwhelming sense of helplessness. She had been so close to becoming a witch then. The idea of harnessing that same raw power, though, was both thrilling and frightening.

The girl continued, her tone shifting to something more practical. "The next skill is mastering magic control. Right now, you've seen how much stronger your base attacks are. You need to learn how to *tone them down* when needed. Use the minimum amount of magic to fight, and conserve your soul gem's energy. If you keep using magic recklessly, you'll burn out your soul gem faster."

Mami thought for a moment. "So, it's about efficiency? Only using what I need?"

"Exactly," the girl confirmed. "And once you can control the *minimum* amount of magic needed to start an attack, you can learn to add more magic right before the attack lands, creating an explosive effect. It's about the timing. *Precision* and *control*—those are the keys to this skill."

Mami's eyes sparkled with realization. "So, I could start an attack with just a small burst of magic, and then... when it's about to hit, *bam!*—I pour more energy into it for an explosive impact."

"That's right," the girl smiled. "And with that control comes even more potential. If you really apply yourself, you can unlock new abilities with your guns and ribbons, things you haven't even thought of yet. But that comes with creativity and imagination. The more you experiment, the more you'll discover."

Mami's heart raced at the thought of it all. Her ribbons could do more? Her guns could have new abilities? The possibilities seemed endless.

"And then," the girl's voice softened, a quiet seriousness in her tone, "there's the most advanced technique: *dis-connect*. This ability allows you to influence a target's magical energy, including their negativity, when your attacks land. You can sever their connection to their own magic, breaking down their power and weakening them. That was the technique I used to save you from becoming a witch."

Mami's eyes widened. "That sounds... intense. How do I even begin to learn something like that?"

"You need to master your own magic control first," the girl explained, her tone steady. "You can't influence others' magic if you can't control your own. Once you've reached a certain level of mastery, you'll be able to disconnect your enemies' magic, draining them of their strength and rendering them vulnerable. But this isn't something that can be rushed. You'll also need to learn 'connect' before you can master 'disconnect.'"

Mami nodded, a surge of determination building in her chest. "I understand. Is 'connect' the magical girl synchronization ability?"

The girl's lips curved into a soft smile, clearly pleased by Mami's curiosity. "Yes, but you've never really had the chance to experience it, since you've mostly fought alone. 'Connect' is the ability to synchronize your magic with others, to share energy and amplify each other's abilities when fighting together. It's a kind of bond between magical girls—a shared strength."

Mami's smile faded slightly as a trace of wistfulness crept into her voice. "That sounds like something I've never known," she said softly. "I've always fought alone."

"That's part of why I'm here," the girl said gently. "Once you've mastered your magic, you can learn how to *connect* with others, sharing energy to make each of you stronger. You'll also need to understand the process of *connect* to truly master *disconnect*. But for now, focusing on mastering your own magic is your first step."

Mami absorbed the words, a sense of excitement and responsibility building inside her. So much to learn, so much to do. But this time, she didn't feel overwhelmed. She felt ready.

"I'm ready to start," Mami said, her voice firm with resolve.

Mami looked at the girl, her thoughts a whirlwind of new possibilities. She had just been introduced to techniques that could elevate her abilities beyond anything she had imagined. There was so much to learn, so many paths to choose from.

The girl smiled gently, her presence calm. "Now," she said, "let's begin your training."

Mami furrowed her brow, unsure how to begin. "What should I do first?"

"Imagine that you want to start training," the girl instructed softly, her voice calm and steady. "Focus on the intent, the desire to learn something new."

Mami closed her eyes, the weight of the past few days lifting as she focused. Her mind was clear now, no longer clouded by grief and fear. Slowly, she thought about her desire to improve, to master her magic, to control her abilities. She pictured herself growing stronger, her soul gem glowing brighter, her attacks sharper.

As soon as she had fully imagined it, a soft light appeared in the air before her, a projection materializing out of nowhere. Mami blinked in surprise as a list of options appeared, glowing softly in front of her eyes. Each line had a different title:

- **Tutorial: Mastering Gun Control**
- **Drill: Amplifying Negative Emotions**
- **Battle Opponent: Witch - Charlotte**
- **Technique: Fine-Tuning Ribbon Attacks**
- **Drill: Soul Gem Management**
- **Battle Opponent: Advanced Witch – "The Forgotten Queen"**
- ...

Mami stared at the projection, a little overwhelmed by the sheer variety. Each option represented a different facet of what she needed to learn. Some were drills to improve her precision and control. Others were full battles with different kinds of opponents, each offering a different challenge to overcome.

The girl noticed Mami's gaze lingering on the battle options. "You'll notice that there are different kinds of opponents available," she continued, her voice calm and steady. "Each opponent is from a different time or place. Some are witches and monsters, others are magical girls. The choice of who you face will depend on the challenges you feel ready to tackle."

Mami's brow furrowed in curiosity. "You mean I can face other magical girls too?"

"Yes," the girl nodded. "Throughout history, there have been many different kinds of magical girls, each with their own unique skills, strengths, and weaknesses. Some are more tactical, others rely on raw power, and some are masters of controlling emotions or even manipulating the very fabric of the universe. You can face any of them here, but I recommend starting with something familiar to you. Facing a witch you've already fought, like Charlotte, could give you a better sense of how much you've improved."

Mami absorbed the information. "So, I could fight any magical girl, even those from other times or worlds?"

"Exactly," the girl said, her smile soft but reassuring. "You have access to a vast range of battle opponents. Some witches and magical girls have different abilities depending on their past experiences, and you can learn from them all. It's not just about defeating them; it's about adapting to their techniques and finding ways to improve your own strategy and magic."

Mami's mind raced with the possibilities. "Can I adjust the difficulty of the battles?"

The girl smiled slightly, her gaze thoughtful. "Yes, you can. The difficulty of each opponent can be adjusted. You can choose to face them at a level that's appropriate for your current abilities, or you can ramp up the difficulty if you want to challenge yourself. However, be mindful—if you choose to face a much stronger opponent before you're ready, it could overwhelm you. It's a balance, Mami. The goal is progress, not just victory."

Mami nodded, feeling a growing sense of confidence. "So, I can start with something easy, but when I'm ready, I can choose harder challenges?"

"Exactly," the girl affirmed. "You have full control over the pace of your training. This is your journey, and you can choose the path that suits you. The more you challenge yourself, the faster you'll grow. But it's always important to listen to your instincts. If you feel that you're ready for something harder, then go for it. But if you think you need more preparation, don't hesitate to refine your abilities first."

Mami smiled, feeling the weight of her options. "This is incredible. So many different ways to grow."

The girl nodded again, her eyes bright with encouragement. "That's the beauty of this training. You have the freedom to decide what's most important for you to learn and the way you want to face the challenges ahead. But remember, growth doesn't always come from winning battles—it often comes from how you learn and adapt.

And it's not just battle opponents. The tutorials and drills also have varying levels of difficulty. They are the good place to start before jumping into battles. If you want to build a solid foundation, the drills will teach you the basics of control, timing, and technique. Once you're comfortable with that, you can slowly ramp up the difficulty level. Think of them as stepping stones to refine your skills before facing stronger foes."

Mami absorbed this, now feeling more confident. "So, I can start with some basic tutorials to get used to things before diving into harder challenges?"

"Exactly," the girl confirmed. "The drills focus on fundamental techniques—things like magic precision, how to control your attacks, how to handle negative emotions when they arise, and how to build endurance. They'll give you the framework you need to perform well in battle. Once you've completed the drills and feel confident with your basic skills, you can move on to the battle opponents. But don't rush it. You'll find that practicing through drills will make you far more effective when facing real opponents."

Mami smiled at the prospect. "I like that idea. It sounds like I can really take my time to get stronger without feeling rushed."

"Exactly," the girl replied, her tone kind but firm. "You'll learn the pace that suits you best. It's not about how fast you go, but about how well you understand your abilities and control them. Mastering the basics will make the challenges ahead much easier. And remember, you can always adjust the difficulty at any time, based on how you're feeling. There's no pressure to complete everything right away."

With those words, Mami felt more at ease. There was no rush, no expectation to perform perfectly. She could take her time, learn at her own pace, and build herself into the magical girl she aspired to be.

"You're free to learn in whatever order you wish," the girl explained, her tone calm. "Pick what you think is most important for you to focus on first. But keep in mind—your progress here will depend on how much you challenge yourself. If you feel you're ready to face a stronger opponent, go for it. If you think your control needs more refinement, then start with the drills."

Mami took a deep breath, her eyes scanning the list. There were so many choices, but she knew she had to prioritize. The idea of battling a harder version of Charlotte seemed daunting, but the idea of mastering her ribbons and gun attacks was tempting. Yet, what stood out to her most was the **Drill: Amplifying Negative Emotions**—it was a concept she had just started to understand. The thought of learning to consciously control and channel her emotions into her attacks felt like it could be the key to unlocking her true potential.

"I'll start with this one," Mami said, her voice steady. "I want to understand how to control my negative emotions to make my attacks stronger."

The girl nodded with approval. "An excellent choice. Mastering that technique will give you control over one of the most powerful aspects of your magic. But remember—balance is key. Don't let the emotions overwhelm you."

Mami nodded, feeling the weight of the responsibility settling on her shoulders. She felt ready.

Before she could say anything else, the girl smiled warmly at her. "You're welcome, Mami. Now, I will do my own training. We can re-convene at lunch. Make sure you use this time wisely."

The girl gave her a final nod of encouragement before she vanished into thin air, leaving Mami standing alone in the strange, shifting realm.

Mami stared at the glowing projection in front of her, her mind buzzing with excitement. She couldn't help but wonder what kind of training the girl would be doing. The girl had already proven herself to be incredibly strong, graceful, and powerful—what could she possibly need to train for?

But Mami quickly dismissed the thought. She had her own path to focus on now. She had to learn and grow. She had to start somewhere.

Taking a deep breath, Mami selected the **Drill: Amplifying Negative Emotions**, her fingers hovering over the option. She was ready to dive in.

The projection flickered, and a new prompt appeared, detailing the drill's objectives and guidelines. Mami felt a rush of determination flow through her. It was time to start. The journey to mastering her magic, her emotions, and herself was just beginning.

Chapter 9 – Amplify – the energetic girl

The transition was seamless—one moment Mami was in the menu projection space, and the next, her boots touched down on a wide, open field covered in vibrant green grass. A gentle breeze swept over the terrain, brushing her hair and skirt softly, but the atmosphere didn't feel natural. It felt... staged.

Surrounding her were strange, natural-looking structures, almost like oversized flower pods, gently floating in mid-air. They swayed ever so slightly as if suspended by unseen magic, and though empty, Mami immediately recognized their shape—seating platforms. They were reminiscent of arena stands, like this place was meant for some kind of competition or spectacle.

She turned slowly, scanning the horizon. No audience. No other movement. Just an eerie stillness.

Before she could question it further, a voice rang out from behind her.

"Yoooo~! You made it!" It was the voice of a girl—cheerful, upbeat, and radiating with energy. There was a lilting musicality in her tone that instantly shifted the mood.

Mami turned sharply and was met with a flash of color. A girl stood several meters away, smiling brightly. She had fiery, orange-red eyes that sparkled with excitement, and her hair—a vivid crimson—was tied in high twin-tails that bounced with each movement. Her outfit was a striking blend of flame motifs and battle-ready elegance, accented with gold and jet black. Everything about her radiated motion and intensity, as if she were the embodiment of a wildfire.

Mami blinked in surprise. Just looking at this girl made her feel a bit warmer somehow. Her presence was dazzling and infectious, a perfect storm of charm and recklessness.

She couldn't help but compare her to *the other girl*. The difference was striking. Where the mysterious girl was calm, cool, and deliberate—this one was wild, expressive, and uncontainably vibrant.

"Um... hello," Mami said politely. "Who are you? Are you the one who's going to teach me about Amplifying Negative Emotions?"

The girl immediately started nodding up and down, her whole upper body bobbing comically with the motion.

Then, with a wide grin, she declared with way too much cheer:

"Welcome to Amplifying Negative Emotions — EXTREMELY HARD MODE — Unforgiving Trial by Fire — Merciless Boss Battle — Now with 50% more emotional destruction~!"

Her voice practically *sang* the entire sentence, like she was announcing a new theme park ride or limited-edition dessert. The contrast between her tone and the terrifying title was so ridiculous, Mami instinctively stepped back, caught between laughing and panicking.

"Wait... what?" Mami blinked. "I-I selected Drill: Amplifying Negative Emotions. The beginner one. The *first* one."

The girl didn't seem to hear her. Or more likely, she just didn't care.

She struck a casual, overly confident pose and flashed Mami two thumbs up. "Good luck, Takaradachi~! Don't die too hard!" she beamed.

Before Mami could object, a ripple of darkness surged through the air.

The cheerful girl's figure began to blur—her body fading into a curtain of thick, black smoke. Mami instinctively raised her hand to shield her eyes as the brightness of the open field was instantly swallowed by an oppressive gloom.

She could no longer see the girl. All that remained was her voice, echoing once, faintly and playfully:

"Worry not! Emotional trauma builds character!"

Then silence.

The light dimmed until it was almost pitch black.

And in the suffocating stillness, something *moved*.

A figure emerged from the shadows—not like a witch, not like any familiar enemy. It didn't walk or float. It *unfolded*, like a smear of pure shadow given form. It didn't have a face. Just shifting shapes—arms, claws, wings, fangs—constantly reforming in the dark.

Mami's breath caught in her throat.

The air had changed—heavier, denser. Even her heartbeat felt too loud. The aura that seeped from the monster was *wrong*. Not magical... but something else. Emotional? Existential? It was an overwhelming weight, like the embodiment of pure darkness. Fear. Rage. Guilt. Loneliness. Despair. The sensations pressed in from all sides, thick and suffocating.

As the creature loomed closer, Mami instinctively stepped back. She could barely breathe.

"What is this thing? What is this pressure?" she whispered, eyes wide. Whatever it was, she had never felt anything like it.

Her soul gem flickered.

She clenched her fists. The training had begun.

Mami steadied her breathing, trying to focus. *Remember what she taught me...*

The fear was there—pressing in on her chest, tightening her limbs—but this time, she didn't push it away. Instead, she pulled it in. Let it swirl inside her heart and settle, just enough to hold, not enough to break.

"I'm not running," she whispered to herself. "I'll use this."

In one swift motion, her ribbons flared to life, whipping through the darkness with sharp precision. She summoned several muskets around her in a circle, each one charging with golden light as she infused her magic—along with the fear she'd gathered—into every round. Her breath hitched as the pressure mounted, but she pushed through, her voice ringing out:

"Tiro Finale!"

The volley of blasts and slicing ribbons collided into the shadow monster with staggering force. The field trembled, a shockwave rippling outward, stirring the tall grass. The impact left a massive cloud of dust and magical debris in the air. Mami took a step back, lowering her arms, eyes wide and hopeful.

It had to be enough.

But as the dust began to settle, a sickening realization crawled up her spine.

The creature still stood.

Unmoving. Unscathed.

Mami's expression faltered, and her breath caught in her throat. "No way..."

The monster's eyes—if they could be called that—glowed with dark crimson light beneath the veil of shadow. It hadn't even flinched.

That was stronger than my attack on Charlotte... and it didn't do anything?

A creeping weight spread through her chest. It wasn't panic, not yet—but something heavier. Mami instinctively reached for her soul gem and held it up.

Her heart dropped.

The gemstone, which had glowed brilliantly that morning, now had a faint tinge of black coiling within it. Tiny wisps of shadow, just barely visible, curled beneath its surface.

“...But I still feel calm,” she whispered. “I'm not afraid like I was before. I'm not sad. I'm not... alone.”

Why was this happening? She wasn't overwhelmed, she wasn't spiraling into despair like she had when fighting as a magical girl alone.

And yet, the darkness was taking root.

Mami's mind raced. *Is it because I used fear in my attack? Did I do something wrong?*

But she didn't have time to dwell. The monster hadn't moved, hadn't even flinched. Its presence was unwavering—immovable. The pressure it radiated had not lessened. If anything... it was heavier now.

Fine, Mami thought, narrowing her eyes. *Then I'll push harder.*

Her grip tightened on her weapon. She could feel the dark threads swirling in her soul gem—fear, uncertainty, pressure. If they were already there... maybe she could draw from them, shape them into something powerful.

She stood tall again, magic flaring to life with renewed effort. Her guns appeared in formation, tighter and closer than before. Ribbons spiraled upward, threading through the air like golden lightning.

Use it. All of it. She pushed her magic harder, forcing it out with more intention, pouring her emotional energy into each ribbon and bullet. The blasts screamed through the field, ribbons cracked like whips. It was more effort, more force, more of *everything*.

And it changed nothing.

The monster remained still.

The attacks vanished into the inky darkness that surrounded it. No sparks. No stagger. No sound.

Mami's hands trembled, her arms dropping to her sides. Her soul gem pulsed faintly in her chest—dimmer now.

She looked down.

Darkness.

More of it.

The black wisps were creeping in again, deeper and more visible now. Every attack she launched only made them stronger.

"No," she whispered, staggering back a step. "Why? I'm not breaking down... I still feel okay. I'm not afraid like before. I'm not angry. I—"

But her knees buckled, and she dropped to one knee.

Her breath was ragged now. Her limbs were heavy. *This feeling...*

It was the same suffocating weight she felt before she nearly became a witch.

That time, when she had fought the other girl—when everything had gone dark. Her soul gem cracked. Her magic spiraled out of control. Her mind had frayed.

And now, here it was again.

The shadow monster took a slow, deliberate step forward.

Then another.

Mami stared up at it, her heart pounding. Her hands reached weakly for her weapon, but her magic barely responded. Her soul gem flickered with darkness. She was running out of time. Running out of herself.

The monster raised its arm, black claws forming like jagged blades.

Mami lowered her gaze, closed her eyes, and waited for the blow.

Then—

Flash.

Everything went white.

There was no impact. No pain.

Only silence.

And then—

Pop!

Whizzz—

Pa! Pa! Pa!

Confetti exploded all around her, bright streamers and party decorations bursting into the air in an absurd, colorful spectacle. Mami's eyes snapped open as she flinched from a balloon bouncing off her head. The monster was gone—replaced by nothing but a faint shimmer of golden sparkles and floating ribbons.

A familiar, hyper-cheerful voice rang out, full of laughter and way too much energy:

"And that concludes your bonus trial for Amplifying Negative Emotions 101: 'Despair With Style!'"

Mami blinked. She was back in the open arena. The sky was clear, the grassy field undisturbed. She was standing again, her energy completely restored.

Her soul gem?

She pulled it close—bright, clean, and untainted. As if none of it had happened.

"...What?"

She turned slowly to see the cheerful, crimson-haired girl waving at her from one of the floating spectator pods, sitting cross-legged on the edge with her hands resting under her chin, beaming like a child at a birthday party.

Mami could only stare, utterly baffled.

Mami, still blinking in disbelief, finally found her voice again—tinged with frustration.

"I selected *Drill: Amplifying Negative Emotions*," she said, carefully enunciating each word. "The beginner one. The *first one* on the list." Her arms crossed, foot tapping. "How was *that* a beginner drill?"

There was a pause.

Then, from above, the red-haired girl gave a theatrical gasp, leapt off the flower pod with an exaggerated spin, and did a full flip in the air.

"Wha—"

THUD!

A burst of dust exploded across the ground.

Mami winced at the unmistakable sound of someone landing the *wrong* way. A moment later came a raspy cough, followed by a groan.

"Ow. Owowowow... I totally meant to do that," came the girl's strained voice. "That was, uh, part of the performance."

Mami blinked as the dust began to settle.

Was that on purpose? she thought, staring in disbelief. "*I seriously can't tell if she meant to fall like that... or if she's just really clumsy and weak. She's nothing like the other girl. Is this really... my teacher?*"

The girl was crouched on the ground, one leg awkwardly twisted, her hands patting her clothes to knock off the dirt. One eye was shut tight in pain, but she gave Mami a bright, sheepish grin through the mess like nothing had gone wrong.

She stood up suddenly—much too quickly—and bowed deeply.

“I sincerely apologize, Miss Mami!” she said with dramatic flair. “Sometimes I *might*—just might—forget that people can’t *always* handle the most extreme possible experience their first time. But I *believe* in the deep-end method!”

Mami stared.

“I find,” the girl continued, brushing herself off while still grinning, “that the best way to learn a new skill is to be thrown head-first into chaos so you *really* understand what mastery will eventually feel like! Now that you’ve survived—*technically*—we can talk about what just happened in *Welcome to Amplifying Negative Emotions — EXTREMELY HARD MODE — Unforgiving Trial by Fire — Merciless Boss Battle — Now with 50% more emotional destruction~!*”

Mami raised an eyebrow.

Then pouted.

“...The other girl did the same thing.”

“Oh?” the red-haired girl perked up, head tilting in curiosity.

“She pushed me to the brink of becoming a witch,” Mami said, arms folding across her chest. “She lied to me—told me my friends were in danger. Forced me into a breaking point. Then apologized afterward, once I didn’t die.”

There was a short beat of silence.

Then the red-haired girl clapped her hands together with delight. “Aww, that sounds *exactly* like her! So calm, so serious, all that quiet mysterious intensity—classic! We’re total opposites,” she added, flashing a proud grin.

Mami’s eyes widened. “Wait... you *know* her?”

“Of course!” the girl beamed. “We’re close friends!”

Mami stared at her for a long moment, processing.

Two girls. Completely different.

One poised and composed. The other a whirlwind of color and chaos.

And *both* of them had a strange habit of nearly getting her killed in the name of “teaching.”

Still processing everything, Mami glanced at the energetic girl, her curiosity finally bubbling over.

“So... who is she?” Mami asked. “The other girl. What’s her name?”

The red-haired girl’s eyes sparkled. She tilted her head, lifted one finger to her lips, and closed one eye in a playful wink.

“That’s a secret~!” she said in a mischievous sing-song voice.

Mami let out a small sigh, pouting a little. “You’re not going to tell me *either*, huh? Fine. Then what about you? If you won’t tell me about *her*, can you at least tell me who *you* are?”

The girl’s expression immediately brightened. She straightened up, gave an exaggerated and flamboyant bow, then placed her hands on her hips proudly.

“Of course! I’d be *delighted* to!” she declared.

“My name is Kasumi Hoshizora,” she said with flair, her twin-tails bouncing with the motion. “And I’m an adventurer!”

Mami blinked. “An... adventurer?”

Kasumi nodded enthusiastically. “Yep! I travel the world—seeing new places, trying all the food I can find, meeting people, soaking in local stories and culture. You wouldn’t *believe* the sea monsters off the coast of Okinawa. Oh! And the pastry festivals in Southern France? *Delicious!*”

She paused, placing a finger to her chin.

“...Also,” she added more casually, “to learn magical techniques, rituals, and fighting styles from different parts of the world. I like keeping up with magical girls and their struggles too. You can learn a *lot* from what people are trying to overcome.”

Mami’s mouth opened slightly in surprise. She hadn’t expected such a sincere and open answer—especially not after how secretive the other girl had been. Kasumi’s openness was... oddly refreshing.

“So... wait,” Mami asked slowly, narrowing her eyes. “If you travel to meet magical girls... does that mean *you’re* a magical girl?”

Kasumi’s response came instantly.

She closed one eye, raised a finger to her lips, and grinned just like before.

“That’s a *seeecret*~!”

Mami groaned, slumping her shoulders. “Of *course* it is...”

Chapter 10 – Amplify – what mastery looks like – battle lust

Kasumi laughed suddenly, a bright, carefree sound that echoed through the open arena.

"Okay, okay," she said, wiping a dramatic tear from one eye, "I *have* to admit—watching your desperate battle against *Miss Mysterious* was *so intense*. You were on the edge of becoming a witch, your soul gem practically black, she lied to you about your friends being in danger, *and* you still kept going like a heroine in a tragedy! It was... kind of hilarious!"

Mami's face dropped into an unamused pout. "I *genuinely* thought I was going to die," she muttered. "And that my friends would die because I was too weak to protect them."

Kasumi flinched playfully at the seriousness in Mami's voice, then straightened herself and gave a deep, exaggerated bow, her long twin-tails drooping dramatically.

"I'm sorry, I'm sorry!" she said. "Jokes aside—seriously—I mean it. What you did was amazing."

She looked up, her usual carefree expression softened by a sincere smile.

"The fact that you kept fighting, even when you thought you were completely alone, even when you were on the edge of despair... That's not something just anyone can do. You were willing to lose everything for the people you cared about. That's not funny. That's *awesome*."

Her fiery eyes sparkled with admiration, and her smile was so earnest that it caught Mami off guard.

Mami blinked, a warmth spreading across her chest. She wasn't used to this kind of energy—this loud, vibrant sincerity. Most magical girls she had met, if not jaded, were serious, quiet, or cold. Burdened. Like herself.

But Kasumi... Kasumi was different. Chaotic, unpredictable, even annoying sometimes—but also kind. Genuine. And, Mami realized, just as compassionate as the other girl... just in her own, very loud way.

A small smile tugged at Mami's lips before she could stop it.

"You're... really different from her," she said quietly.

Kasumi grinned wide, placing her hands behind her head as she rocked on her heels.

"Yup! And yet we still get along. Isn't that great?"

Mami let out a soft laugh.

Maybe... it *was* great.

Kasumi clapped her hands together once with a loud, echoing *smack*.

"Alrighty! Now that you've survived your surprise boss battle and emotional meltdown, we can *finally* start the beginner drill! For real this time!"

With a dramatic flourish, she raised one hand into the air and spun in a little circle.

"Pod seats, please~!"

At her command, several of the floating flower pods gently descended from the sky like giant petals on the wind. One hovered just in front of Mami and Kasumi, its surface blooming open with a soft glow to reveal two cushioned seats.

Kasumi hopped onto the pod and patted the spot next to her. "Come on, come on. It's movie time!"

Still half-suspicious, Mami stepped onto the pod, and it lifted them back into the air with a graceful motion. Once they were floating again above the grassy field, a translucent screen materialized in the air before them. It shimmered briefly before playing a familiar scene.

Mami's battle against the shadow monster.

Every detail—the rising pressure, the suffocating negativity, her soul gem darkening—played out in vivid clarity. She watched herself fight, her attacks futile, her growing panic obvious in her expression.

Kasumi leaned forward, eyes wide with glee.

"Okay, *right here*—this part—watch your face when your ribbons do *nothing*. Absolutely priceless." She laughed out loud. "And then the part where you just *stand there* when the monster's closing in—whew! That expression! Utter confusion! It's like *déjà vu* from your fight with *Miss Mysterious*!"

Mami twitched slightly. A small vein pulsed on her forehead.

"You know, it's a little hard to appreciate the comedy when you're *in it*," she said through tight lips. But despite herself... she smiled. Just a little.

Kasumi glanced sideways, clearly pleased. "See? You're learning already."

The screen faded, and Kasumi turned her full attention to Mami. Her tone shifted, still light but more focused.

"So... tell me. What were you feeling in the fight? What did you try to do?"

Mami took a breath and let her thoughts settle before speaking.

"I... tried to use what I learned from the other girl. I knew I was afraid. So I tried to use that fear—to let it into my magic and amplify it. Like she said I did with Charlotte. I used more of my own magic this time, too, since I thought I had to hit harder."

She paused, remembering the weight in her chest, the frustration, and the creeping darkness.

"But it didn't work. The attack felt stronger than usual... but the monster didn't even flinch. And then... my soul gem started filling with negativity. Fast. Like way faster than before. Even though I didn't feel *that* bad. I wasn't overwhelmed, and I wasn't hopeless like I used to be."

She looked down, thoughtful.

"I don't understand why I was losing myself so quickly when I felt like I was doing everything right."

Kasumi leaned back with a thoughtful hum, kicking her feet gently as the pod swayed beneath them. "Yup, that tracks."

Mami blinked. “That... tracks?”

Kasumi nodded, her smile easy and unbothered. “You were doing a lot of things right, actually. You *did* use your fear. You *did* channel more magic into your attacks. But what you didn’t know—because it’s part of the trial—is that the shadow monster and arena were both secretly syncing with your soul gem using a form of **Connect**.”

“Connect...?” Mami repeated.

“Mhm!” Kasumi twirled her finger in the air like she was drawing loops. “The whole environment was linked to you. It was designed to fill your soul gem with negativity, no matter how peaceful or in-control you *felt*. That’s why it all got so dark so fast. Think of it like an accelerated test—pushing your emotional system to the limit while you try to channel that energy into magic.”

Mami’s eyes widened. “So I wasn’t doing anything wrong...”

“Not really,” Kasumi said brightly. “But you *were* fighting uphill without realizing it. The moment you stepped into the arena and the shadow monster appeared, your soul gem started absorbing negativity like a sponge, whether you wanted it to or not. That’s the *real* lesson of Amplifying Negative Emotions 101.”

Mami’s expression darkened slightly. “That’s a very... cruel setup for a beginner drill.”

Kasumi gave a half-shrug, grinning unapologetically. “Welcome to emotional combat! But hey—you survived, didn’t you? That’s a win!”

She leaned forward again, her fiery eyes gleaming with energy.

“Now, want to know the real trick? The key isn’t just using negative emotions in your attack—it’s learning how to *hold them*, *shape them*, and *release* them without letting them poison your soul gem. That’s what I’ll teach you next.”

Mami took a deep breath, trying to process it all. It wasn’t just about feeling the fear—it was about *mastering* it. Holding the blade by its edge and not getting cut.

And somehow, with Kasumi smiling beside her and the sky wide open above, it felt... possible.

As the screen faded and the projection vanished into sparkling particles, Mami leaned back slightly, arms crossed. A thought bubbled to the front of her mind—an image, really.

THUD.

That awkward, dusty, barely-a-stick-the-landing mess Kasumi had made when she leapt off the pod earlier.

Mami’s eyes narrowed slightly, her expression turning playful.

“...Say,” she began in a sweet, curious voice, “for someone claiming to be my teacher, your landing earlier was... shall we say, a little *less than graceful*?”

Kasumi blinked, caught off guard.

Mami pressed forward with a smirk, her voice teasing. “I mean, really. Any magical girl should be able to stick a basic jump. But you... you looked like someone tripped over their own feet midair.”

Kasumi gasped, clutching her chest like she’d been struck. “Mami!” she cried out dramatically. “How could you say something so cruel to your beloved teacher?!”

She flopped backward on the flower pod dramatically, fake-sobbing into her sleeve. “So mean... so heartless... I’m emotionally destroyed! **Emotional damage** at 200%!”

Mami couldn’t hold back a laugh. “You’re impossible,” she said, shaking her head. “I was trying to get you to pout. Or glare at me. Something. But you really don’t care, do you?”

Kasumi sat back up, eyes sparkling. “Nope! I’m completely immune to teasing. But nice try!”

Then she gave Mami a grin—one full of fire and challenge. “Buuut, if you doubt my abilities that much, maybe I should show you just how serious I can be.”

Mami tilted her head. “Oh?”

Kasumi stood, striking a heroic pose. “I, Kasumi Hoshizora, will now enter...”—she drew in a huge breath—

“Welcome to Amplifying Negative Emotions — EXTREMELY HARD MODE — Unforgiving Trial by Fire — Merciless Boss Battle — Now with 50% more emotional destruction~!”

She winked. “Again.”

Mami’s mouth dropped open. “Wait, *seriously*? You’re going to do it *now*?”

Kasumi nodded, her crimson twin-tails bouncing.

Mami narrowed her eyes. “You’re probably just going to set it to ‘Now with 0% emotional destruction~!’ instead.”

“Maybe.” Kasumi grinned, giving her a thumbs up. “Sit tight and enjoy the show!”

With that, she leapt off the pod—

THUD.

A puff of dust shot up.

“OW. That one might’ve been a little off-center...” Kasumi’s voice wheezed from the smoke.

Mami burst out laughing. She covered her mouth, but it was no use. “She’s really going to do this?” she said out loud between giggles. “She might be the worst lander I’ve ever seen. How is she a teacher?”

From below, a familiar voice called up through the dust cloud—

“I heard that~!”

The smoke parted just enough for Mami to see Kasumi still lying on the ground, one eye shut in mock pain, giving her a big thumbs up.

“With how much you’re enjoying this,” Kasumi teased, “someone sounds like a *total hypocrite!*”

Mami blinked.

Kasumi grinned up at her, voice sing-song and smug. “*How could you laugh at someone’s genuine suffering~? I really thought I was going to die~!*”

Mami’s eyes widened, her cheeks puffing out as she tried not to laugh again.

Kasumi winked. “Looks like you’re *just like me*, Mami~!”

Still laughing, Mami leaned forward, curious and more than a little skeptical.

This, she thought, *I have to see.*

The arena darkened.

The sky turned a heavy shade of violet, the soft lights above fading into a deep gloom. Shadows bled out across the field, and the same thick, oppressive aura returned—malice and despair weighing down the air like smoke.

Mami’s smile vanished as she stood in her pod, eyes locked on the familiar dark shape forming below.

The shadow monster was back.

Her hands gripped the edge of the pod. “It’s the same one...” she whispered. The same creature. The same soul-crushing atmosphere. This wasn’t a toned-down version. Kasumi hadn’t changed the difficulty. This was no joke.

And yet... Kasumi stood calmly on the field, a few meters away from the forming creature.

There was no Soul Gem glowing on her body—just like the other girl. Mami stared, her brows furrowing. *No Soul Gem?* That unsettling realization returned. She still didn’t know whether either of them were magical girls at all. Kasumi had just smiled and said, “That’s a secret.”

Is that how she’s doing this? Mami thought. *If she has no Soul Gem, there’s nothing to corrupt... no darkness to build up. That has to be how she’s cheating the system... right?*

But before Mami could dwell on the idea longer, Kasumi reacted to the monster’s full appearance—with a wide grin.

Mami blinked. *She’s not afraid?*

Kasumi cracked her knuckles and crouched slightly, fire in her eyes and a manic excitement bubbling in her voice. “Let’s goooo!”

Then she charged.

Her feet kicked up dust as she dashed in with no weapon, no flash of magic—just a full-bodied leap and a punch aimed square at the monster’s massive body.

“WATAAAAAH!”

The punch landed.

It did absolutely nothing.

The monster didn't even flinch.

Mami flinched *for* it.

Kasumi landed with a soft skid and launched back in again. Another punch. Then a kick. Then three more strikes in rapid succession, all punctuated with exaggerated sound effects and cartoonish cries.

“POW! BAM! HIYAH! SHORYU—ow!”

Mami stared, confused. None of Kasumi's movements were particularly fast or sharp. They weren't weak, but they weren't enhanced by magic either. No blinding speed, no explosive power, no elegance. They looked... normal. Like something anyone could do with basic training.

What is she doing...?

Then Mami saw it—darkness starting to swirl around Kasumi's body. It pooled in the air like black smoke, trailing from her back, twisting like tendrils around her limbs. That same awful pressure Mami had felt before—she could see it gripping Kasumi too.

Her eyes widened.

That aura... she remembered it all too clearly. It was the same dark energy the mysterious girl had drawn into herself when Mami was on the edge of despair. Right before Mami had nearly turned into a witch.

Mami's breath caught. *Wait... is she not cheating?*

She stared at the red-haired girl, now nearly swallowed in shadow, still throwing absurdly animated punches with that same fiery grin on her face.

She's really taking in all that negativity... just like the other girl...

And with that, Mami's earlier doubts began to falter.

Kasumi's string of silly punches and exaggerated kicks continued for another few moments—until suddenly, her movements faltered.

She staggered slightly mid-step, and then dropped to one knee, her breathing ragged and loud even from where Mami sat. Sweat dripped from her brow, her crimson hair clinging to her cheeks, and her arms hung limply at her sides.

A grimace twisted her face.

Mami leaned forward in the pod, heart skipping. *She looks just like I did... right before I almost turned into a witch...*

Was the negativity finally catching up to her?

Or was this just another act? Another exaggeration to tease Mami, to playfully mimic her suffering?

Mami couldn't tell.

And then—everything changed.

The shadow monster vanished.

In the blink of an eye, it reappeared—right next to Kasumi. It didn't walk. It didn't make a sound. It simply warped through the gloom, as though the darkness itself had folded inward to deliver it where it wanted to be.

Kasumi barely had time to lift her head before a massive blow struck her side.

The impact echoed like thunder.

She was launched across the arena like a ragdoll, slamming into the far wall of shadow with a bone-rattling *CRACK* that echoed through the void. Dust and black mist exploded on impact, leaving nothing but a smoking dent in the arena's edge.

"KASUMI!" Mami screamed, hands pressed against the barrier of her pod. Her voice cracked with panic.

But it wasn't over.

From the walls, the floor, even the faint shadows hanging in the air, tendrils of pure darkness twisted together like writhing snakes—and they surged toward the spot where Kasumi had fallen.

In an instant, they wrapped around her and began to whip her around the arena.

"Stop it—STOP!" Mami shouted, eyes wide with horror.

The shadow slammed Kasumi against the ground, then hurled her into the air only to smash her back down like a toy. Her body spun out of control, bouncing off the walls, flung like a lifeless doll across every inch of the battlefield.

Mami couldn't follow the exact path she was being thrown—the attacks came too fast, too chaotic, too brutal. The shadow monster's movements blurred through the gloom, a storm of darkness, violence, and cold fury.

And Kasumi—Kasumi was just a blur of red and gold, vanishing and reappearing in flashes of impact.

This isn't like before... Mami realized. *When the monster hit me, it vanished in a puff of confetti. But now... this is real. This is actually happening to her!*

Finally, with a roar of shadows, the tendrils pulled inward and slammed Kasumi down at the very center of the arena.

The entire field trembled from the force of the blow.

The arena fell silent.

The shadows stilled. The violence ceased.

Mami's hands trembled as she pressed against the edge of the pod. Her eyes were wide with tears, her breath hitched in her throat. She could barely look.

No one—magical girl or not—could've survived a beating like that.

She wanted to scream again. To leap down. To do something.

Then—

“...ow.”

The single pained sound echoed softly across the arena.

“...owowow. Owowowowowow...”

Another wheeze. A sputter. A string of half-choked groans delivered in a tone far too familiar.

Mami blinked, confused—shocked—as the dust began to clear.

No way...

There stood Kasumi.

Barely.

Her legs wobbled. Her back was hunched forward, arms limp at her sides. Her outfit was shredded in places, soaked with blood and dirt. Her body was covered in cuts and bruises, one eye half-closed, swollen, her lip split open. And all around her, a dense, seething aura of negativity twisted in the air—far more than Mami had ever seen around herself.

She looked like someone who had been through hell.

And yet—

She smiled.

Kasumi lifted her head slowly, blood trailing down her chin, and grinned at the monster standing before her. It wasn't the playful smile she'd given Mami before. It was wild. Deranged. Gleeful.

“Yes...” she croaked, her voice hoarse and shaky. “This feeling... this pain... this negativity... just what I need to get my battle lust going...”

Mami's jaw dropped. *Is she serious...?*

Kasumi bent low into a stance and, without another word, *launched* herself forward.

With a cry, she drove her fist into the monster's face.

This time, it staggered.

There was real impact.

Mami gasped, practically leaping forward in her pod. “It *worked*?!”

The monster reeled back, then countered—tendrils of shadow erupting from the ground, hurling toward Kasumi like a storm.

“Oh No. KASUMI!” Mami screamed, clinging to the edge of the pod.

But Kasumi didn’t dodge.

She didn’t flinch.

She just grinned wider.

The attacks slammed into her. One—two—three. Each one landed with crushing force—blows that, by all rights, should’ve sent any magical girl—or anyone at all—flying.

But Kasumi *stayed*.

Blood flew from her mouth, but her eyes never lost their spark.

“Yesss,” she hissed through her teeth, grabbing one of the tendrils mid-strike, her fingers trembling but tight. “Good... That’s it.... This is what I wanted from you... The more you do that—”

Her smile flared into something fierce, intense, and joyful.

“—the hotter my battle lust burns!”

With a shout, she yanked the tendril backward, dragging the core of the shadow monster toward her with brute force. The monster shrieked, caught off guard.

Kasumi reared back her arm.

“Time for a goodbye kiss, darkness freak!”

Her fist collided with the shadow’s center mass.

BOOM.

The explosion of energy rippled through the entire arena, bursting with fire and light and darkness all at once.

Mami shielded her face from the shockwave, her heart pounding in her chest. The pod trembled beneath her as the wave passed.

Then—

Silence.

When Mami opened her eyes, the monster was gone.

In its place, golden confetti and fireworks burst into the air with a comical *pop!*, the arena shifting back to its calm grassy state once more.

In the center of it all, Kasumi sat slumped on the ground, looking completely spent. Her face was battered and bloodied, but that ever-present grin never left her lips—and Mami still couldn't tell if she was genuinely exhausted or just putting on another act.

She looked up at Mami, closed one eye, gave a cheerful thumbs up, and smiled.

Bright. Warm. Unbreakable.

Mami's mouth fell open.

She gripped the edge of the pod with both hands, her golden eyes sparkling like a child seeing something magical for the first time.

"She's incredible..." Mami whispered.

Her heart fluttered with awe and excitement.

And maybe, just a little bit...

Admiration.

As the dust finally settled and the arena returned to normal, Kasumi looked up at Mami from where she sat, still bruised and bloodied, her posture slack but her grin as bright as ever.

"How was the show?" she asked with a cheeky tilt of her head. "Come on down, Mrs. 'I can jump down and land better than you,'" she added with exaggerated air quotes and a teasing lilt in her voice.

Mami rolled her eyes but smiled. She stood, stepped off the pod's edge, and landed gracefully on the ground with perfect balance—nothing flashy, just clean and controlled. A textbook magical girl landing.

Kasumi threw her arms in the air with a dramatic gasp. "Showoff," she said, puffing her cheeks in mock offense.

Mami giggled. "That fight was incredible. A true spectacle—suspenseful, intense, a little terrifying... and honestly, kind of fun to watch."

She paused, tilting her head slightly. "But... are you okay? I really can't tell if you're actually exhausted or if you're still playing around."

Kasumi's pout deepened, and she flopped onto her back dramatically. "How can you say it was fun to watch when I'm in such a sorry, sorry state?" she moaned, throwing a hand over her eyes. "Hypocrite! Absolute hypocrite!"

Mami burst into laughter. "That's payback for earlier. Now we're even."

Still lying on the ground, Kasumi suddenly sprang to her feet with a burst of energy that made Mami flinch in surprise.

“Alright then, watch this~!” Kasumi declared, striking a ridiculous pose. She began performing an odd dance—limbs flailing, hips twisting, all punctuated by random English phrases that didn’t belong together at all.

“DYNAMITE... JUICEBOX... STARDUST... RECOVERY... *KABOOM!*”

Mami stared, completely dumbfounded. “What are you even—?”

Before she could finish, a soft shimmer of magic spread over Kasumi's body. In the blink of an eye, her bruises faded, her blood vanished, her clothes stitched themselves back to pristine condition. She was glowing—sparkling, even—like she’d just stepped out of a transformation sequence.

Mami gasped aloud. “What?!”

Kasumi finished with a twirl and bowed deeply, arms outstretched with flair. “I asked how the *show* was, didn’t I?” she said with a wink.

Chapter 11 – Amplify training begins

Kasumi stretched her arms above her head and motioned for Mami to follow her back to the flower pods.

“C’mon, let’s relive that masterpiece,” she said with a grin, already hopping up onto her pod like nothing had happened.

Mami followed, and once they were both seated, the pods ascended. The sky around them shimmered, and a massive projection of Kasumi’s fight against the shadow monster lit up the air around the arena like a theater screen.

As the recording began, Kasumi immediately reacted with exaggerated flailing.

“AH—right here, I *felt* that one!” she yelled, twitching dramatically as one of the monster’s blows landed on her past self. She clutched her ribs and kicked her feet in mock agony. “Owwwww! My spleen! My spleen’s spleen!”

Mami tried to hide her laughter, but it was no use. Kasumi’s energy was too infectious.

“Here it comes, here it comes—pause!” Kasumi stopped the projection and zoomed in on herself being thrown across the battlefield. “LOOK at this trajectory! I went full ragdoll mode!”

Mami laughed again, eyes wide. “How are you still alive...?”

Kasumi pressed play — at a slower speed so that Mami could follow — and kept bouncing in her seat, reliving the chaos with delight. Then Mami, now settled and watching intently, spoke up.

“Your fighting style is... so different from hers.”

Kasumi glanced over, her smile softening a bit.

“The mysterious girl,” Mami clarified. “She’s fast, elegant, powerful. Everything about her movement is graceful. She doesn’t just fight—she dances. She dodges, parries, strikes with perfect efficiency. It’s almost... beautiful.”

Kasumi’s grin returned full force. “And me?”

“You,” Mami said with a smirk, “start out flailing around with nonsense attacks and somehow turn into a *deranged fiery freak of nature* who beats a monster into the ground with sheer insanity and brute force.”

Kasumi cackled. “A deranged fiery freak of nature—thank you!” She gave a dramatic bow in her pod. “I accept this honor with pride.”

Still grinning, she leaned back and said, “There are lots of ways to apply Amplifying Negative Emotions, you know.”

Her voice changed subtly—still cheerful, but there was a nostalgic edge to it that caught Mami off guard.

“The two of us,” Kasumi continued, “we’re different in just about every way. Personality, fighting style... everything. She’s genuinely beautiful—on and off the battlefield. Watching her fight is like watching a divine performance. She draws in negativity with this quiet calm, and channels it with precision. You saw it, right? How she used your emotions when you were about to become a witch?”

Mami nodded silently.

“And me?” Kasumi went on. “I like the heat of battle. I *need* it. That pain, the fear, the anger—it ignites something in me. I call it battle lust,” she said, placing a fist over her chest. “The fire in the soul that burns hotter the more life throws at you.”

Mami let out a breath and laughed, shaking her head. “I can definitely see that—it suits you perfectly. Honestly, even your outfit screams ‘fire.’”

“But...” she trailed off, thoughtful. “I didn’t realize the same technique could look so... different. You and her feel like opposites, yet you’re using the same core ability.”

“Yup!” Kasumi beamed. “There’s no one right way to fight. But there *are* lots of wrong ones, so be careful.”

She turned, looked Mami in the eye, and smirked. “Didn’t she tell you to use your *creativity and imagination* to unlock your potential?”

Kasumi’s voice softened, briefly shifting into a gentle, hauntingly beautiful tone that mimicked the mysterious girl’s perfectly: “*Let your heart guide your magic. Creativity and imagination—those are your keys.*”

Mami blinked. Her jaw nearly dropped.

“Wha—how do you do that voice so well?!”

Kasumi wiggled her eyebrows. “I’m talented.”

Mami laughed. “Still... yes. She *did* say that. And I’m starting to understand what she meant.”

She paused, then gave Kasumi a sly look. “So tell me. Could you have finished the fight quickly if you’d fought seriously from the start?”

Kasumi gave her a mock gasp. “Mami, I *was* serious! Don’t you know nonsense attacks are the *true path* to victory?”

“Uh-huh. And what about the landing from the pod?”

“Also serious!” Kasumi declared, though her eyes sparkled mischievously.

Mami folded her arms, clearly unconvinced. “Right... And you said something earlier about increasing the battle lust in your *soul*. That makes me wonder...” She narrowed her eyes. “Are you a magical girl or not? Where’s your soul gem?”

Kasumi closed one eye, raised a finger to her lips, and grinned just like before.

As she started the gesture, Mami groaned and rolled her eyes, already bracing for it.

Together, they both said in perfect unison:

“That’s a seeeecret~!”

And then, they laughed.

Chapter 11 b – Amplify – first drill

Kasumi clapped her hands with a spark of excitement.

“Alrighty, Mami~! You ready for your *first real drill*? Say hello to...”

She stepped forward, arms wide like a stage magician about to reveal a trick.

“Drill 1: Emotional Echo! — Feel It, Don’t Be It!”

Mami raised an eyebrow. “That name sounds like a motivational seminar.”

Kasumi grinned. “Exactly! Except instead of emotional healing, we weaponize the sadness.”

With a snap of her fingers, the arena shimmered. A few glowing memory-shards floated into the air like glass panes suspended by magic. Each one shimmered softly—Mami recognized the faint images in them. One showed her younger self eating dinner alone. Another, a distant memory of a battle where her ribbons snapped and her gun jammed. A third showed her meeting Madoka and Sayaka for the first time, only to fade to black with a sense of loss.

Mami’s breath caught in her chest.

“Don’t worry,” Kasumi said, now hovering beside her on the flower pod. Her voice softened, for once not dripping with mischief. “These aren’t meant to hurt you. I tuned them to be light echoes—just enough to *remind* you of the feeling without dragging you back into it.”

Mami nodded, steadying herself.

“**The goal here,**” Kasumi continued, “is to *call up a specific emotion*, like fear, frustration, or loneliness... hold onto it *just enough*—and then channel it into an attack. Not too much. You’re not trying to drown in it, just dip your toes.”

Mami took a deep breath. “Alright.”

She stepped down from the pod, now standing before the gently floating memory shards.

Kasumi flicked her wrist and summoned a few basic floating targets shaped like little shadow creatures.

“Go ahead,” Kasumi said. “Try a basic shot. No power-ups yet. Just shoot normally.”

Mami aimed, summoned a musket, and fired. The shot hit the target and it popped easily.

“Good. Now pick a memory—just one. Let yourself *feel* it, but don’t get pulled under. Then try again.”

Mami turned toward the image of her sitting alone, her home dark and quiet.

She felt the ache, the emptiness—not overwhelming, but present. A hollow echo in her chest.

She focused. Felt that loneliness wrap around her fingers like thread. She conjured another musket, raised it, and pulled the trigger.

BOOM.

The target burst apart with a blast noticeably stronger than before.

Mami’s eyes widened slightly. “That was...”

“Stronger, right?” Kasumi smirked. “And you didn’t even cry about it. That’s how you know you’re doing it right.”

Mami gave her a sideways look but smiled. “So that’s what it’s supposed to feel like.”

“You’ve got it.” Kasumi gestured toward the other shards. “Try again. Use frustration this time. Try the one where your ribbon snapped.”

Mami nodded, then focused again.

She cycled through the targets, one after another—*loneliness, frustration, fear*. Each shot felt heavier, more charged. But Mami could also feel the weight creeping into her soul gem, just a tiny bit. Kasumi’s training environment was still actively connecting, even if gently.

By the fifth shot, she stopped to breathe.

“Kasumi,” she asked, “how do I know when I’m going too far? What if I hold on too tightly?”

Kasumi leaned back, her smile now a little more serious.

“You’ll know. Your soul gem will tell you. The pain will tell you. But more than that...” she tapped her temple, “*your intuition will grow stronger with practice*. You’re learning to dance with your own darkness—not let it lead.”

Mami steadied herself. Each shot she fired now carried weight—not just magical energy, but emotional intention. It was draining in a different way. Not physical. Not magical.

Emotional.

The next shard floated before her—an image of Kyoko walking away after their argument. The memory struck deeper than expected. It wasn’t rage. It wasn’t betrayal. Just... regret. A moment lost. Words unspoken.

She focused.

The emotion surged in her chest like a low, warm burn. She summoned a rifle—not one, but several, her classic ribbon weave forming a swirling formation around her.

BANG. BANG. BANG.

The shots exploded in rapid succession, each one more precise than the last, bursting through the shadow dummies with controlled force. Each bullet left golden trails in the air, infused with flickers of her emotion.

Kasumi gave a sharp whistle from above. “Now *that’s* what I’m talkin’ about!”

But Mami was breathing harder now. The weight of calling up those emotions—*deliberately*—was taking its toll. Not in the way the shadow monster had crushed her, but in a way that felt more subtle... and real. Like dipping your hand into water and feeling the cold slowly seep in.

Her soul gem glowed faintly, just a touch dimmer than when she began. She glanced at it, monitoring its light. It wasn’t alarming yet. But it was a reminder.

Kasumi floated down from the pod and hovered nearby, arms crossed in a relaxed pose.

“Alright, I’m calling it there. That’s enough for today,” she said. “You hit all the required emotion nodes and kept control the whole time. Very nice, *Miss Elegant Gunner*.”

Mami let out a long breath, wiping her forehead. “That was... harder than it looked.”

Kasumi nodded. “Amplifying Negative Emotions is never about pretending the bad stuff isn’t there. It’s about being able to *use it without letting it consume you*. That takes strength.”

She floated closer, her tone growing gentler.

“But let me tell you something important.”

Mami looked up.

“There’s no shame in showing weakness when you’re facing negativity. It’s not about being cold, or distant, or pretending nothing hurts. If anything... you have to let it hurt. Let it sting. That’s how you *face it*.”

Kasumi gave her a soft smile, one that for once lacked any of her usual dramatic flair.

“You don’t grow stronger by hiding your cracks. You grow stronger by knowing where they are—and choosing to stand anyway.”

Mami looked down at her soul gem, and then back at Kasumi. The words resonated more deeply than she expected. It reminded her of what the other girl had said—different tone, same core truth.

She smiled. “Thanks. I think... I’m starting to understand.”

Kasumi grinned and gave her a thumbs up, back to her usual self. “Heck yeah you are! One drill down, many more to go!”

Then she winked. “But first: *Lunch break!* I believe that’s what the mysterious miss told you, right?”

Mami chuckled, feeling lighter than before—even with the emotional weight of the drill still lingering.

“Right. Lunch.”

Chapter 12 – Lunch with a family

As Mami dusted herself off and caught her breath, she turned to Kasumi, still glowing faintly in the quiet aftermath of battle.

“Are you coming with me for lunch?” Mami asked.

Kasumi gave her a sly wink, arms folded behind her head. “Mmmm... I’ve got something else to take care of. But don’t worry—we’ll see each other again very soon~.”

Mami blinked. “Wait, what does that mean—?”

Before she could finish her question, Kasumi spun on her heel with a theatrical bow, ribbons of golden-red light surrounding her in a whirl. Then, with one last grin, she vanished in a burst of shimmering flame-shaped sparkles.

Mami let out a small sigh, smiling in spite of herself. “Of course.”

Moments later, she found herself at the entrance to the cabin—the same cozy, serene spot where all this had begun. The door opened before she could knock.

The mysterious girl stood in the doorway, her expression calm, yet brightened by the gentlest of smiles.

“Welcome back, Mami.”

Without another word, she extended a chilled glass toward her.

Mami took it with both hands, pleasantly surprised by the coolness of the drink against her skin. “Thank you,” she said gratefully, taking a sip. Sweet. Refreshing.

They moved to a shaded spot nearby—a quiet clearing beneath a tall, flowering tree. The breeze was soft. The silence, comforting.

The girl sat down first, her posture elegant as always. Mami followed, taking a seat beside her in the grass, letting the cool drink rest on her lap.

“So,” the mysterious girl asked gently, “how was your training?”

Mami looked at her, thoughtful, her golden eyes catching the light.

Mami leaned back into the grass with a small sigh, drink still in hand. She looked up at the sky for a moment before turning to the girl beside her.

“Well... it was a lot.”

The mysterious girl gave her a knowing glance, her smile unreadable but encouraging.

Mami laughed under her breath. “I picked the beginner drill for Amplifying Negative Emotions... but then this girl shows up—Kasumi. She had bright red hair, twin tails, and this huge, fiery energy. I thought maybe she’d teach me step-by-step or something, but no—she just *threw* me into this ‘Extreme Hard Mode Boss Fight with 50% more emotional destruction,’ or something like that.” Mami waved her hands for emphasis, her voice rising with amusement and disbelief.

The girl beside her let out a soft chuckle, her eyes crinkling at the corners. “That sounds exactly like her.”

“She didn’t answer any of my questions! Just wished me good luck and disappeared into the shadows while this horrible monster appeared—this giant thing made of pure negativity. I tried to do what you taught me, using my fear to amplify my attacks, and I thought it was working at first...” Mami’s smile faded slightly, her voice growing softer. “But the attacks didn’t do anything. I just kept pushing, but the more I fought, the more negativity built up in my Soul Gem.”

The mysterious girl nodded, listening quietly.

“I thought I was going to lose control again. It felt just like that moment when we fought... like I was right at the edge.” Mami gripped her drink a little tighter. “But then everything went *poof*—literal confetti—and Kasumi was back, all smiles, calling it ‘Amplifying Negative Emotions 101.’ I was so confused I couldn’t even be mad.”

She paused for a second, then laughed, the sound bubbling up as she remembered the image. “She even landed from a jump with the most ridiculous *thud*. Total dust cloud, coughing, groaning—it was like watching a comedy routine. I couldn’t tell if she was being clumsy or just playing around.”

“I imagine it was a little of both,” the mysterious girl mused softly, amusement dancing in her eyes.

Mami turned toward her more fully, warming to her story. “She’s... honestly a mess. But also amazing. I watched her do the same trial I went through, and she got *pummeled*—slammed around like a ragdoll. It was horrible to watch. I thought she was done for, but then... she stood up. Bloody, bruised, surrounded by this intense aura of negativity—and she just smiled. Like she was *enjoying* it. She called it ‘battle lust’—something about using all that pain and negativity to fuel her attacks.”

Mami looked down at the grass, brows furrowed thoughtfully.

“It’s the same technique you taught me, but completely different. You were calm, methodical, beautiful... graceful. And she was... a deranged, fiery freak of nature.”

The mysterious girl let out a gentle laugh, her hand over her mouth. “That also sounds exactly like her.”

“She said something similar about you,” Mami added, glancing at her. “She said your fighting was like watching a dance that refreshes the soul. That you’re beautiful on and off the battlefield.”

The mysterious girl blinked, surprised. “She said that?”

Mami nodded, smiling. “She really admires you. I think you two are close in your own strange way.”

There was a quiet pause, the breeze whispering through the grass and trees around them.

“She’s... difficult to explain,” the girl finally said. “Loud. Chaotic. She doesn’t seem to take things seriously. But when she fights, she burns with everything she has. There’s sincerity in that fire—even when it’s reckless.”

“She told me there’s no one right way to fight,” Mami murmured. “But there are a lot of wrong ways. And that I need to use creativity and imagination—just like you told me.”

The mysterious girl looked at Mami fondly, her eyes gentle. “And you’re already starting to. You were scared, and still, you fought. You learned. You laughed.” Her gaze softened further. “That’s how growth looks.”

Mami blushed slightly and smiled.

Then her brow furrowed with a playful pout. “She still won’t tell me if she’s a magical girl or not. No Soul Gem, same as you. And when I asked, she just said—”

The two spoke in unison, grinning:

““That’s a seeeecret~!””

They both burst into laughter

As their laughter faded into comfortable silence, Mami puffed out her cheeks in a pout and crossed her arms.

“Honestly... both of you almost got me *killed* during training,” she muttered, half-joking, half-genuinely exasperated. “First you with your whole fake emergency situation, then Kasumi tossing me straight into emotional destruction hard mode like it was a game.”

The mysterious girl chuckled softly, the sound warm and melodic. “Mm. I suppose we have more in common than it seems.”

“That’s the scary part,” Mami said, glancing sideways at her. “You two couldn’t be more different at first glance—one calm and composed, the other loud and reckless—but somehow, you *both* ended up using near-death experiences as a teaching method.”

The girl covered her mouth politely, trying—and failing—to stifle another laugh. “We have our own styles... but the heart behind it is the same.”

Mami sighed dramatically, but her lips curled into a small smile. “You’re lucky I’m still alive to appreciate the sentiment.”

Mami took another sip of her drink, the coolness refreshing after the intensity of the morning’s events. She glanced at the mysterious girl, her curiosity bubbling again.

“So... what about you?” Mami asked. “You said we’d meet back at lunch, so... what did *you* do for training?”

The girl gave her a soft smile, serene as always. “I sparred with Kasumi.”

Mami blinked. “Huh? But... how? Kasumi was with me the whole time.”

“She was,” the girl agreed with a gentle nod. “But in the arena, opponents can be replicated based on real data—past fights, known patterns, combat profiles, and their essences. That’s how the opponents function. It’s what makes it possible for one person to train while another is busy elsewhere.”

“Oh...” Mami leaned forward slightly, intrigued. “So... you fought a copy of her? Like, a simulation?”

The girl shook her head, the soft sway of her hair brushing her shoulders. “No. I fought the real Kasumi. Not a data copy. She used a bit of her own essence to create a special clone to train you—different from the arena-generated opponents. The clone shares her mind, so Kasumi retains all the memories and experiences afterward.”

Mami’s mouth dropped open. “You mean... you both actually fought for real? *While* she was also running me through that whole emotional destruction boss battle?!”

The girl chuckled softly. “That’s Kasumi for you.”

Mami blinked a few more times in disbelief, then asked the obvious question: “So who won?”

“I did,” the girl said, perfectly composed.

But before Mami could react—

“I did!” chimed in a cheerful, energetic voice from nearby.

Mami turned, startled, and the mysterious girl calmly looked to her side.

Kasumi came skipping toward them with a huge grin, one hand waving energetically over her head. “Hi hi~! Hope I’m not interrupting something juicy!”

Mami stared. “W-Wait—you’re already *here*?”

Kasumi winked. “Of course! I told you we’d see each other *very* soon!”

Kasumi skipped the last few steps up the hill and struck a wide pose in front of Mami, one hand on her hip, the other raised in a grand wave. “Nice to meet the *real* me at last!” she beamed. “Kasumi Hoshizora—adventurer extraordinaire and your one-of-a-kind trainer!”

Mami stood and gave a polite bow, still smiling. “It’s good to finally meet the *actual* you too.”

Once they’d all settled under the shade again, Mami blinked and tilted her head. “So... who really won that sparring match? Since you *both* claimed victory.”

Kasumi immediately leaned in with a fiery grin. “Obviously *I* did. My overwhelming battle lust, raw passion, and explosive power couldn’t be stopped. No one can stand against the full burn of my soul.”

The mysterious girl gently shook her head, her expression composed but teasing. “Kasumi’s style is certainly... spirited. But predictable. She’s like an open book when she gets excited. I dodged nearly everything and struck with precision. It was only a matter of time.”

Kasumi pouted, crossing her arms. “You’re leaving out the most *important* part—the end! When I hit my peak! My flames were practically *singing*, and your elegant little dances couldn’t keep up with that chaos!”

The mysterious girl raised an eyebrow. “Singing flames? Is that what we’re calling it now?”

Kasumi turned to Mami, hands on her hips. “Alright, Mami. You’ve seen both of us fight now. Who do *you* think is telling the truth?”

The mysterious girl gave a soft chuckle, clearly amused. “Yes... I’m curious too.”

Mami glanced between the two of them. Two opposite energies—one like wildfire, the other like still water. Both powerful. Both terrifying in their own way.

She took a breath, unsure if this was a trap... or just another lesson.

Mami tapped her chin, pretending to ponder it seriously. Then, slowly, she turned to Kasumi with a mischievous glint in her eyes. “I think...” She paused dramatically. “The mysterious girl probably won.”

Kasumi gasped, staggering back like she’d been struck in the heart. “Mami! How could you say something so cruel?! After all we’ve been through! I taught you, I fought for you, I—I bled for you!” She fell to her knees theatrically, head tilted back in fake despair. “Et tu, Mami?!”

Mami folded her arms with a smug smile. “That’s payback. For laughing at my emotional destruction. Twice.”

The mysterious girl gave a soft, genuine laugh. “You two really are alike in your own way.” She looked at Mami, smiling warmly. “Very clever. That’s how you deal with Kasumi. Give her a taste of her own theater.”

Kasumi lifted her head just enough to peer at Mami with one eye. “This betrayal will echo through the chambers of my heart for eternity...”

Mami giggled and offered her a hand. “You’ll survive.”

Kasumi sniffled dramatically but took the hand with exaggerated gratitude. “I’ll try to stay strong...”

Mami just rolled her eyes playfully, already bracing herself for whatever came next.

Kasumi suddenly turned to the two of them, eyes sparkling. “Hey! Let’s gather some ingredients from the forest! Fresh stuff always tastes better.” She grinned and started walking ahead.

Mami glanced at the mysterious girl with curiosity. “Kasumi, do you have the same kind of connection with nature as you? Like, using the essence of nature to make your ingredients?”

Kasumi laughed, a carefree, bright sound that danced with the rustling leaves. “Nah, I’m more of a kid who just loves to play outside.” She skipped forward, touching the plants gently as if greeting old friends. Her eyes lit up with wonder at every flower and leaf.

She moved through the forest like a whirlwind of energy, her laughter echoing between the trees. Twirling and spinning, arms outstretched as if flying, she skipped over roots and soft moss. Every so often, she’d pause to kneel by a cluster of wildflowers, cupping a delicate bloom and breathing in its sweet scent, her eyes shining with pure delight.

“The forest is amazing, isn’t it?” Kasumi said, tracing patterns on a fern leaf. “I love how everything feels so alive here—the colors, the smells, the sounds... it’s like the whole place is breathing.”

Suddenly, a rustle nearby caught her attention. A small group of animals appeared—rabbits with twitching noses, squirrels with bushy tails, and curious fox kits. Kasumi crouched low, eyes sparkling mischievously, hands ready like claws. “Alright, you little rascals! Let’s play tag! But beware... I’m at the top of the food chain, and I’m coming for you!”

The animals scattered with playful hops and darts, teasing her by running just out of reach. Kasumi laughed, chasing after them with exaggerated slow-motion lunges and mock menacing growls. “I’m gonna eat you all! Ferocious, unstoppable Kasumi is coming!”

Squirrels chattered excitedly, darting up trees, while rabbits bounded around her legs like fluffy missiles. Birds fluttered overhead, adding chirps and tweets to the joyful chaos.

As the game went on, a cheeky flock of birds swooped down one by one, aiming little “surprises” Kasumi’s way. With a startled yelp, she flailed her arms wildly, twisting and dodging like a clumsy dancer. “Eeeek! Hey, no fair!” she shrieked, making a series of odd, comical noises—a mix between a squeak and a whoop—as she tried to catch the teasing birds.

The birds cawed and tweeted in mocking delight, darting away just before she could tag them, turning the chase into a joyous game of cat and mouse.

Mami laughed uncontrollably. “Looks like even the animals like to tease you.”

The mysterious girl chuckled quietly. “Kasumi’s just as much a part of the forest’s playful spirit as any creature here.”

After what felt like an eternity of laughter and playful chaos, Kasumi stopped in a sun-dappled clearing, breathing hard but glowing with happiness. She knelt and gently stroked the fur of a trusting fox kit curled up at her feet. “Alright, my little friends,” she said warmly, “time for me to go. Thanks for the game—and the fun! Don’t get into too much trouble while I’m gone.”

She stood, turning back toward Mami and the mysterious girl, waving with a bright grin. “See you later, forest family! I’ll be back to visit soon.”

The animals chirped and rustled in response, as if saying goodbye, and Kasumi’s laughter lingered in the air long after she disappeared down the forest path, leaving behind a trail of warmth and joy.

Kasumi turned to Mami and the mysterious girl. “Let’s head back to the cabin. Lunch is waiting, and I’m starving.”

Mami smiled, feeling the warmth of the moment settle in. The three of them walked back together, the forest alive with gentle sounds and a hint of magic.

Back at the cabin, the kitchen came alive with motion, color, and the mingling aromas of herbs and spices. Kasumi clapped her hands and declared, “Time to cook! Let’s make something that’ll blow your taste buds away!”

“Before we begin,” she said, wagging her finger like a magician preparing for a grand trick, “we need only the *finest* ingredients—fresh from the heart of nature!” She snapped her fingers with theatrical flair.

With a whirl of golden light and a puff of harmless smoke, ingredients began to appear on the counter—vegetables gleaming with dew, herbs tied in perfect bundles, cuts of meat marbled just right. A bundle of mushrooms even bounced lightly as if landing from mid-air.

“Tadaaa!” Kasumi struck a pose like a stage magician, one leg out, arms wide, and a comically smug grin on her face. “Nature’s bounty—brought to you by *Kasumi’s Magical Culinary Arts™!*”

Mami blinked, stunned. “Wait... can you really just conjure ingredients like that?”

Kasumi winked. “Technically, I’m pulling them from the essence of nature, just like Miss Mysterious over there. I just do it with a bit more *flair*.” She gave a twirl, and a bunch of green onions spiraled into the air and landed neatly in her hand.

The mysterious girl, already calmly preparing the kitchen, let out a soft laugh. “It’s not quite how I do it, but... the result is the same.”

“Exactly!” Kasumi chimed, striking another theatrical pose. “Why walk the peaceful path of nature when you can *stage dive* into it?”

Everyone laughed and started food prepping.

Mami stepped in to help, and the three of them moved around the kitchen like parts of a strangely harmonious dance—if that dance included a little chaos.

The mysterious girl floated through her tasks with effortless grace. Her hands moved with fluid precision, slicing vegetables with serene poise, each cut uniform and elegant, as though she were composing a work of art rather than preparing a meal. She stirred sauces with delicate, practiced care, her motions so smooth and measured they looked choreographed—like she was conducting a quiet symphony of flavors.

Her entire presence in the kitchen was calming. She never rushed, never wasted a movement. When she poured broth, it flowed in a perfect ribbon from ladle to pot. When she plated ingredients, they landed gently and beautifully in perfect alignment, as if guided by invisible threads of balance and harmony.

Even the way she wiped down a cutting board or folded a towel had a quiet rhythm, as though her every gesture was a part of some greater ritual. It was like watching a traditional tea ceremony performed in the language of cooking—every motion filled with purpose, care, and tranquility.

Her expression remained serene throughout, a gentle smile playing on her lips as she moved, her long hair swaying softly with each step. To Mami, it felt less like the girl was cooking, and more like the ingredients were choosing to become something beautiful in her hands.

In stark contrast, Kasumi cooked like she was putting on a show. Flames roared from under her pan as she shouted dramatic commentary like a TV chef performing for a live audience.

“BEHOLD, THE SIZZLE OF DESTINY!” she cried, dramatically flicking her wrist as she flipped ingredients high into the air—somehow catching every single one without breaking the rhythm of her act.

She spun across the kitchen like she owned the stage—juggling cherry tomatoes, balancing a spoon on her nose, flipping a knife between fingers (safely), then tossing a ladle into the air and catching it behind her back with flair before using it to stir. At one point, she even flipped a piece of ginger into a bowl from behind her back with a “HYAAAH!” that echoed like a martial arts call.

“Now for the legendary twirl of *FLAVOR FUSION*!” she shouted, pirouetting with a sprinkle of herbs that rained into the pan in a perfect spiral. Her flourishes were ridiculous, her energy boundless, and her laughter echoed off the cabin walls like firecrackers.

It was chaotic, dazzling—and surprisingly effective.

Yet, despite their differences, the two worked together seamlessly. Kasumi would dramatically slide a pan down the counter, and the mysterious girl would catch it with a quiet smile and start plating with meticulous elegance. The mysterious girl would gently hand off ingredients, and Kasumi would throw them into her pan with a loud “HYAAH!” It shouldn’t have worked, but it did.

Mami couldn’t stop smiling as she chopped vegetables alongside them, basking in the warmth of the moment. Her heart ached softly—grateful for this moment, but also wistful. Back when she fought alone as a magical girl, moments like this never existed. There had been no warmth, no laughter—only battles, and the silence between them. No one to share burdens, or to laugh with over a cutting board. Seeing the mysterious girl and Kasumi laugh and help each other, shoulder to shoulder, made her wish she’d had something—someone—like this back then.

But now... she had this. And that meant everything.

Soon, the kitchen filled with the rich scent of something warm and savory, laced with sweet herbs and just a hint of spice. The three of them sat down to eat together, laughter still lingering in the air.

The meal was delicious—colorful vegetables sautéed in bright sauces, handmade dumplings, sweet rice, and something vaguely terrifying-looking that Kasumi insisted was “a flavor explosion” (and to her credit, it kind of was).

They shared stories and jokes between bites, teasing each other and laughing until they were wiping tears from their eyes. The cabin felt full—not just with sound or smell, but with something deeper. Something warmer.

Mami looked across the table at the two girls—one calm and quiet, the other blazing and wild—and for the first time in what felt like forever, she felt like she had a family again.

Chapter 13 - 2nd emotion control training session and the talent show

The sun had dipped lower in the sky by the time their lunch ended, casting golden beams through the windows of the cabin. Plates were cleared, and the comforting haze of a full belly hung in the air.

Kasumi stretched with a dramatic yawn, arms above her head. “Alrighty! Time for me to dash~!” she said, already half-turning toward the door.

Mami blinked. “Wait—where are you going?”

Kasumi turned on her heel with a spark in her eyes, like she’d just remembered something exciting. “Oh! That’s right!” She grinned and struck a finger-in-the-air pose. “Wanna come to a school talent show with me tonight?”

“A talent show?” Mami repeated, tilting her head curiously.

“Yup! Kamihama City’s local school is hosting one later today,” Kasumi said, practically bouncing on her heels. “And guess who’s been roped into performing?”

Mami’s eyes widened. “You’re performing?!”

Kasumi beamed with both pride and chaos. “Mmhmm~ I’m part of a girl band—some students invited me to join in for fun. We’ll be performing one song! I’ll be on electric guitar and vocals.” She wiggled her fingers like she was already shredding the air. “It’s gonna be awesome!”

The mysterious girl smiled softly. “That sounds like a wonderful idea. What do you think, Mami? Would you like to go?”

Mami looked between the two of them, surprise still written across her face. “I didn’t think you’d be involved with... school stuff,” she admitted to Kasumi.

Kasumi laughed. “It’s part of the adventuring life! Gotta meet new people, make connections, have fun. Besides, Kamihama’s been gathering a lot of magical girls lately. They’re fighting tough witches out there.” Her tone softened a little. “So, I want to do what I can to help lift their spirits—spread some joy, y’know? A silly song and some stage lights might not fix everything, but... maybe it helps.”

Mami’s chest warmed, touched by the sincerity behind Kasumi’s fiery nature. She smiled and gave a playful smirk. “Aww, look at you—Kasumi the musical morale support unit. Who would’ve thought?”

Kasumi gasped dramatically, placing a hand over her heart. “Such *hurtful* teasing from my dear kouhai!” She then grinned and gave a theatrical bow. “But I’ll accept it as praise.”

Mami laughed, genuinely.

Then she turned to the mysterious girl. “Will you be coming too?”

The girl nodded. “Yes. In fact... I’ll be performing as well.”

Mami blinked. “Wait, seriously?”

The girl’s serene smile didn’t waver. “I was invited to play flute with a small student orchestra. Just one piece. But... I thought it might be a good way to help too. Music can soothe the heart. And there are magical girls who will be there tonight. Some just to listen. Some... who need to hear it.”

A gentle silence followed as that truth hung in the air.

Mami looked at her, then to Kasumi, and back again. Her mind drifted to the first night she arrived—how she had sat by the lake, listening to the mysterious girl play her flute and harp beneath the moonlight. The music had reached something deep inside her, something wounded and quietly crying out.

She thought about both girls now—how kind they were in their own way. So different. And yet, both doing everything they could to help magical girls smile again.

Mami looked down for a moment, then smiled softly.

They were strange.

But maybe... exactly the kind of strange she needed.

Mami lingered in her thoughts for a moment, watching the light dancing across the wooden floor. Then she looked up at the mysterious girl, a trace of hesitation in her voice.

“Wait... how can I even go to a school talent show?” she asked. “Didn’t you say that this place is... ‘a place between places’? Not the living or the dead?” She furrowed her brow, recalling that first night beneath the moonlit sky. “You said it’s where people go to find clarity before they’re called to move forward. So... how can I leave?”

The mysterious girl met Mami’s gaze with her usual calm smile. “You’re right. This place is still between,” she said gently, her voice carrying a breeze-like softness. “But with a little help, you’ll be able to visit the world again. Just for this talent show, for now.”

“Visit?” Mami echoed, leaning in slightly.

“You’ll be able to go in an ephemeral form,” the girl explained. “You’ll feel like yourself. Think like yourself. But you won’t have your Soul Gem, so no one will recognize you as a magical girl—not even other magical girls. It will keep you from becoming entangled in any conflicts or burdens in Kamihama.”

Mami let out a breath of relief, her shoulders easing. “That actually sounds... kind of perfect.”

The girl’s expression softened further. “You’ll be safe. And more importantly... free to enjoy yourself.”

Mami smiled, a soft warmth blooming in her chest. Still, her mind caught on one phrase. *Just for a time*. “For now, huh...” she murmured quietly. She wanted to ask more—what did *for now* really mean? Was there a limit to her time here? But something in her heart told her not to ask. Not yet.

So she nodded. “Alright. Let’s go see that show.”

“Woohoo!” Kasumi pumped her fist in the air, practically glowing with joy. “Yes! I knew you’d say yes!”

She struck a dramatic farewell pose and gave a deep, theatrical bow. “I’ll see you both later tonight at the performance of a lifetime! And good luck with your next training session, Mami!”

Then, with a cheery wave and a little hop, Kasumi turned and darted off toward the trees, humming the start of some high-energy rock anthem as she went.

Mami watched her disappear into the forest, her smile lingering long after Kasumi’s footsteps faded.

Chapter 13b: Negativity Endurance – Descent and Recovery

After Kasumi’s departure, the cabin returned to its peaceful quiet. Mami followed the mysterious girl, who gently beckoned her toward the arena once again. The sun outside still cast its warm glow.

They entered the arena. The flower pod beneath their feet descended slowly as Mami looked down at the vast, open floor.

The mysterious girl stood at the edge beside her, hands lightly clasped in front of her. “This training will focus on building your tolerance,” she said, her voice like wind brushing through leaves. “If you wish to use negativity to empower your magic, you must learn not only to accept it, but to carry it—at least for a while.”

Mami looked toward the arena floor, nodding slowly. “So... this is about holding it in without letting it break me.”

“Exactly,” the girl replied. “We call this drill *Negativity Endurance*. The arena will gently increase the emotional weight around you—slowly, safely. Your task is to endure it for as long as you can. The longer you hold, the stronger the burst of power you’ll be able to use later.”

Mami took a deep breath. She had felt negativity before—crushing, wild, all-consuming. But this was different. It wasn’t about surviving a storm. It was about *riding the edge* of it.

The flower pod kissed the ground with a soft thud. Mami stepped forward onto the empty floor.

Behind her, the pod began its silent ascent. “Good luck, Mami,” the girl’s voice echoed softly from above.

The arena slowly darkened, a dim, almost grayish light enveloping the space. Not as severe or theatrical as the fight against the shadow monster, but it was heavy in its own way. A soft hum of tension began to fill the air—subtle at first, like the static before a storm.

At first, Mami stood tall in the quiet arena, her breath steady, her mind focused.

She recalled the words Kasumi had spoken with such passionate fire, and the serene lessons from the mysterious girl that followed. “*Accept it. Let it flow through you. Master it.*”

The atmosphere of the arena began to shift—softly at first. Like clouds slowly dimming the sky, a weight settled into the space. It was subtle, like walking into a room filled with lingering tension. But Mami held her ground.

I can do this, she told herself.

The feelings came in like a slow tide—unease, uncertainty, the bitter sting of long-ago regrets. The arena was amplifying fragments of her past: being alone in her fight as a magical girl, her fears of being forgotten, the times she questioned whether her efforts ever really mattered.

But she focused on her breathing.

“I’m not the girl I used to be,” she whispered under her breath, fists clenched. “I have friends now. I have strength.”

For the first several minutes, Mami endured. Her magic responded faintly to the negativity, absorbing it without letting it tip the balance. It was working.

But then... the weight began to grow.

Her breath grew short. The memories sharpened, and the whispers in her mind got louder—more cruel. *You were always replaceable. A pawn. A tool.* Her legs began to tremble.

She gasped, sweat trickling down her temple. Her arms shook, and her body tightened as if trying to fight off an invisible force wrapping around her chest. She dropped to one knee.

The arena grew darker.

Hold on... hold on... don't break.

But the feelings no longer dripped in slowly. They flooded in. A surge of hopelessness and fear—the kind she hadn't felt since her darkest days. The kind that once drove her close to despair. Her vision blurred. Her limbs froze.

And then...

Everything faded to black.

The weight dragged her down into a void of silence. She was floating. Lost. Her heartbeat pounded in her ears as thoughts spun wildly, crashing into one another with no escape.

I'm falling again... like I did back then.

But through the void... came **a sound**.

Soft at first. Gentle. A single note... then a few more. A harp.

Then a voice. Wordless, ethereal—singing a melody that felt like starlight. A voice that didn't call out to her with power or force... but with compassion. Mami turned toward it in a daze.

In the center of the darkness stood the mysterious girl—surrounded by shimmering white petals that glowed faintly. She sat at a harp, hands gliding across its strings. Her eyes were closed, her expression serene. She sang no words, yet her voice reached Mami like a warm breeze on a winter night.

It cut through the fog.

Mami's hands unclenched. Her breathing slowed.

The darkness didn't disappear—but it faded back, no longer pressing in from all sides. Like it was giving her space to breathe.

This song... she's pulling me back.

Light slowly returned to the arena. Mami found herself lying on the ground, eyes fluttering open as the illusion faded. Her chest rose and fell with deep, tired breaths. But she was okay.

She blinked, sitting up slowly.

The mysterious girl stood nearby, her harp already gone, a soft smile on her face. "You came very close to the edge."

Mami nodded, wiping her forehead. “I thought I could carry it... and I did... for a while. But then it was like it swallowed me. I couldn’t hold it anymore. It felt like being buried alive.”

Her voice trembled slightly, but she looked up. “And then... I heard you. That melody. It pulled me back. I thought I was gone.”

The mysterious girl knelt beside her. “You did well, Mami. This was your first time. The fact that you lasted so long—and recognized your limits—is a strength, not a weakness.”

Mami gave a weak smile. “Thank you... for the song. It wasn’t just beautiful. It felt like you were... touching something inside my soul. Like telling me I wasn’t alone.”

The girl nodded gently. “There are many ways to counterbalance darkness. Some laugh it off and embrace it to strengthen themselves, like Kasumi. And others... soothe it. Music, for instance, can calm the mind, and remind the soul of its light.”

Mami looked down at her hands. “So I need to find my own way to recover. To manage it when it builds too much.”

“Yes,” the girl replied softly. “There will be times when you’ll need to let go of the weight before it breaks you. Finding your own method to reset—to breathe again—is just as important as learning how to bear the load.”

The air around them lightened.

The mysterious girl’s eyes twinkled. “And besides,” she added with a gentle chuckle, “that little performance was a good warmup for my orchestra piece tonight.”

Mami smiled, her spirit feeling just a little lighter again. “I think you’ll have the whole audience in tears if you play something that beautiful.”

“Let’s hope they are the good kind of tears,” the girl replied with a mischievous wink. Then, her expression shifted back into one of quiet encouragement, her eyes locking onto Mami’s with renewed focus. “Try again, Mami. Let the darkness back in, but this time, look for your own anchor. See what helps *your* specific soul resist the descent into despair.”

“Right.”

Mami closed her eyes, centering her mind. She relaxed the defensive barriers around her heart, allowing the latent, dark corruption to intentionally seep back into the crystalline depths of her Soul Gem.

Chapter 14 – the talent show

After the second training session and a bit of free time to rest, the mysterious girl approached Mami near the cabin’s entrance, her gentle expression tinged with quiet excitement.

“Are you ready to go?” she asked softly.

Mami nodded. “Yeah, I think I am.”

The girl raised her hand, and a translucent, glowing projection shimmered into existence before them, displaying a catalog of clothes that rotated like a fashion hologram. “Pick anything you like. You’ll want to blend in for this.”

Mami’s eyes lit up. “I get to choose?!” She leaned closer, flipping through outfit after outfit with wide, delighted eyes—like a young girl let loose in a candy store. Her fingers hovered over several styles before finally settling on a casual yet stylish ensemble: a pale yellow blouse with frilled sleeves tucked into a white skirt adorned with small golden patterns that shimmered faintly in the light. A soft pink ribbon tied around her waist, matching the delicate shoes on her feet. Her signature curled hair remained, but was pulled slightly to the side with a small bow pin. It was a cute, modest look—light, cheerful, and warm.

Once she confirmed her choice, the mysterious girl quietly selected her own attire: a soft, layered sundress in flowing sky blue, accented with silver embroidery that caught the sunlight like water glinting in motion. A lightweight shawl draped gently over her shoulders, and her long hair was braided slightly at the sides, giving her an elegant but approachable look. She looked more like a music teacher or visiting alumna than anything unusual—subtle, but striking.

Mami looked her over and smiled. “You look really pretty,” she said honestly.

The girl turned, returning the compliment with a gentle bow. “And you look lovely, Mami. That outfit suits you.”

A soft glow surrounded them, and in an instant, the world around them shifted. When the light faded, they were standing just outside the entrance to a local school in Kamihama City. Evening sunlight poured across the buildings, casting long golden shadows across the ground. Warm laughter and excited voices filled the air.

The scene was vibrant—alive with joy and energy. Children ran across the courtyard, playing games and chasing each other. Couples walked hand-in-hand, laughing and chatting. Families gathered near the main entrance, looking over event programs and talking excitedly about what their kids would be performing tonight. Conversations floated past them—parents talking about their children’s futures, hopes, and dreams.

Mami’s smile faltered just slightly as she looked out over the crowd. A quiet ache settled in her chest.

What would my life have been like, she wondered, if my family hadn’t died in that car crash? Would they have come to see me perform at a school talent show? Would I have had memories like this—ones full of laughter and love?

She held that thought for a moment, eyes downcast, then took a breath and steadied herself. She had made peace with it... mostly. And today wasn’t about the past.

Then she noticed a group of girls entering from the side path—familiar uniforms, casual banter, and a strong aura of presence. Mami’s eyes widened slightly. They were magical girls—she could tell by their subtle energy, the kind only another could sense. But she didn’t recognize them.

She looked toward the mysterious girl, uncertain.

The girl noticed her glance and gave a warm, encouraging smile, followed by a soft nod.

With that reassurance, Mami stepped forward, and the two of them approached the group.

The girls turned as they heard footsteps and greeted them with friendly curiosity. The one with short pink hair spoke first.

“Hi! Are you here for the talent show too?”

Mami nodded. “Yes, we are. I’m—” she paused for just a second, then offered a gentle smile. “I’m Mami. This is my friend.”

The mysterious girl gave a small, polite bow. “Just a guest visiting for the performance.”

“I’m Iroha Tamaki,” said the pink-haired girl warmly. “And these are my friends—”

“Yachiyo Nanami,” said the tall blue-haired girl with a graceful nod.

“Tsuruno Yui, the Mighty!” the cheerful girl in the twin buns declared proudly.

“Sana Futaba,” came a quiet voice, almost a whisper, from the teal-haired girl peeking from behind the others.

“Felicia Mitsuki!” the blonde girl grinned. “We’re all part of the same team!”

Mami’s heart stirred at the sight of them—these girls were close. A team, a family. They fought together, lived together. She could sense it in the way they spoke and stood beside each other. It was everything she wished she had once... but she was grateful now. She had her own people: Kasumi, the mysterious girl, and the bonds she was slowly building.

“And you two?” Yachiyo asked politely. “Are you students?”

“Visitors,” the mysterious girl answered simply. “Just here to enjoy the show.”

“We heard there’s a student band performing tonight,” Mami added, deflecting smoothly. “And a guest guitarist. Her name is Kasumi.”

“Ohhh, Kasumi!” Tsuruno clapped her hands together. “Yeah! We heard she’s some kind of wandering adventurer or something? Super cool!”

“Very energetic too,” Sana added with a soft smile.

“I wanna see if she actually sets anything on fire,” Felicia grinned.

“There’s also going to be an orchestra,” Iroha said. “One of the students said they invited a guest flutist for the closing piece.”

Mami glanced at the mysterious girl with a smile. “Sounds like it’ll be a beautiful performance.”

The girls looked back at them. “What about you two?” Iroha asked. “What are you most excited for?”

Mami thought for a moment, then smiled, her voice sincere. “Honestly... I’m just happy to be here. To enjoy something beautiful.”

The mysterious girl nodded beside her. “To hear the music. And support those who put their heart into it.”

“Yeah!” Tsuruno pumped her fist. “It’s gonna be great!”

The group began walking together toward the auditorium, the air alive with excitement and growing anticipation. Mami’s heart beat a little faster—not from nerves, but from something else.

She was part of something again.

And the night had only just begun.

The group of magical girls found seats together in the auditorium, settling into a middle row near the center where the view was perfect. Mami sat between the mysterious girl and Iroha, quietly taking in the warm chatter around her. Students, teachers, and families filled the venue—laughing, clapping, taking photos—creating an atmosphere brimming with anticipation and joy.

As the lights dimmed, the talent show began in earnest. Acts flowed across the stage: a pair of students performing a heartfelt piano duet, a comedy skit that had half the room in stitches, and even a surprisingly skilled juggling routine involving sports equipment.

Mami smiled through it all, her heart light. Sitting here with the others, hearing their laughter and feeling the collective energy of the crowd, she felt like just another girl in the audience—no soul gem, no battles, no burdens. Just now.

Chapter 14a - Kasumi’s performance

Then, after a short intermission, the stage lights flared again and the MC returned to the center mic.

“All right everyone, next up is a student band from Kamihama High. Give them a warm welcome!”

The crowd clapped and cheered as a group of four girls walked confidently onto the stage, each holding or standing near their instruments. They waved to the audience with bright smiles, clearly excited—but also holding something back, like they were hiding a secret surprise.

The **drummer**, a lively girl with a wild ponytail and a pair of bright star-shaped earrings, gave a quick spin of her sticks and made an exaggerated bow to the audience. She radiated energy, practically bouncing on her heels behind her set. Her shirt was slightly untucked like she’d rushed to get on stage, but her grin showed she lived for this.

The **bassist**, taller and more composed, had sleek black hair cut just above the shoulders and glasses that gleamed under the stage lights. She adjusted the strap of her bass guitar with practiced ease, her

calm expression a contrast to the drummer's hyper energy. She gave a polite nod to the crowd—reserved, but not cold.

Next to her was the **keyboardist**, a soft-spoken girl with dyed pink tips in her hair and flower pins tucked just behind her ear. Her fingers hovered just above the keys as if the music was already playing in her mind. She had a dreamy look in her eyes, mouthing what might've been song lyrics or a quiet pep talk to herself.

Finally, the **lead guitarist and vocalist**, a short-haired girl with a lightning bolt decal on her guitar, stepped forward. She had an unmistakable "band leader" aura—confident stance, playful smirk, and a wink to the audience that got a few cheers from the front row. She adjusted the mic stand, then leaned in.

"Hey everyone!" she said, her voice clear and warm. "We're really excited to be here tonight—thank you for giving us the chance to perform!"

The crowd clapped again, supportive and lively.

"But we're not just here alone," she added, her grin growing wider. "We've got a surprise for you. Tonight, we're joined by someone very special..."

She exchanged a knowing look with the other girls, who tried (and failed) to hold back their laughter.

"...An adventurer who has seen the world—please welcome... **Kasumi!**"

Everyone in the audience erupted into cheers.

"Kasumi?! Is she really here?!" some of the students shouted, craning their necks toward the stage wings.

The name rippled through the crowd like electricity—some clapped, others stood up in anticipation.

But then... no one came out.

The stage remained empty.

A voice from the back shouted with a grin,
"Maybe she's already off on another adventure!"

Laughter bubbled up around the room, easing the growing tension.

The cheering slowly tapered off, replaced by curious murmurs.
There was a beat of silence.

Then—

From behind the curtain, a brightly-colored clown outfit emerged... pedaling a tiny children's toy bicycle.

The crowd blinked in disbelief.

Kasumi rolled out, knees bent awkwardly as she pedaled with theatrical effort, her face painted in exaggerated colors, topped with a crooked rainbow wig and a plastic red nose that squeaked with every bounce.

In one hand, she held a cheap plastic recorder—and began playing it with deliberate, painful awfulness.

“ScreeEEE—HOOOOONK!”

“♪~ Welcome to my miiiiiind, yeah~ ♪” she sang with wild abandon, dragging out the final note on the recorder with a wobbly vibrato like she was performing in a stadium.

The crowd erupted—some in **raucous laughter**, some **cheering**, others **booing in good fun**. A few students clutched their sides, unable to breathe. A voice from the back shouted, “Is this for real?!”

Kasumi spun the bicycle in a wide, clumsy circle, wobbling with theatrical flair as she neared her electric guitar and mic stand. Just as she reached it—

THUD.

She **fell straight off the bike**, landing on the stage in a tangled heap of squeaky clown fabric and rubber nose. Her recorder let out one final dying **“screeEEeek!”** as it slid away across the floor.

A beat of silence.

Then the auditorium **exploded with laughter**.

Some people clapped wildly, others wheezed with laughter, and a handful gave dramatic gasps like it was the most shocking thing they’d ever seen. A student in the front row choked out, “SHE COMMITTED TO THE BIT!”

Mami blinked in disbelief, covering her mouth in a vain attempt to contain her laughter—but it burst out anyway. She doubled over, tears forming in her eyes.

“Just like when she jumped off the pod,” she managed between giggles.

Beside her, the **mysterious girl** smiled softly, amused and unbothered, and offered a gentle, approving clap. “She certainly knows how to make an entrance.”

Just beside Mami, the Kamihama girls sat wide-eyed and slack-jawed for a moment—then **burst into varying reactions**.

Tsuruno was already halfway out of her seat, fists clenched in the air. “YES!! This energy! I LOVE HER!” she shouted, completely invested in the chaos. “That’s the spirit of a true performer!”

Felicia was howling with laughter, slapping the armrest of her chair. “She fell! She actually fell off the bike! That’s the funniest thing I’ve ever seen!”

Sana had both hands over her mouth, eyes wide, but she was smiling too—more quietly, but no less genuinely. “She’s... really something else...”

Iroha blinked a few times and then giggled, her shoulders relaxing. “I didn’t expect *this* kind of performance, but... it’s nice. It’s really fun.”

Yachiyo, ever the composed one, was trying hard to keep her cool—but a small smirk had crept onto her face. “At least she’s committed,” she murmured, shaking her head lightly.

Mami glanced at them all and felt a warmth bloom in her chest. Seeing these girls—each one a fighter, a survivor—*laughing* together, free from the weight of battle even for just a moment... it was beautiful. Their laughter filled the space where grief and exhaustion often lived.

It reminded her of what Kasumi had said earlier—that lifting spirits could be a kind of strength too.

The mysterious girl beside her smiled softly, watching the scene unfold with quiet contentment.

Meanwhile, Kasumi dramatically rose to her feet, hands thrown in the air as if she’d just nailed a perfect stunt. “I meant to do that!” she shouted with gusto and then did a low bow, sending the crowd into **another round of cheers and laughter**.

Mami murmured softly to herself, a hint of disbelief lingering in her voice, “Of course you did...” She was still trying to make sense of the time Kasumi had landed poorly—*twice*—after jumping from the pod during their earlier training.

The mysterious girl beside her let out a quiet chuckle, her eyes sparkling with amusement. “That’s Kasumi for you,” she said gently. “Always turning mishaps into moments of brilliance.”

“Thank you, thank you!” she beamed, striking a stage pose as she stood next to her **electric guitar and mic**. “I’m Kasumi the Adventurer, I would like to thank this band for the opportunity to be here!”

Laughter and applause rippled across the room.

The band girls were nearly doubled over in laughter behind her. The lead girl wiped a tear from her eye and stepped up. “We’re **Second Period Detention**, and we’re honored—truly—to be joined by Kasumi tonight.”

Kasumi gave a double thumbs-up, her clown outfit shimmering under the lights like some kind of performance art. “So Kamihama,” she shouted, raising one hand like a rock star, “you ready to have some *fun*?!”

The crowd responded with a roar of applause and cheers.

Kasumi turned to the band leader.

She gave a sharp nod.

“Three... two... one—”

The music hit.

The drums hit hard—

A sharp, driving rhythm kicked the air alive, followed by the thrum of bass, tight and pulsing like a heartbeat ready to charge into battle. The lead guitarist shredded the opening riff with wild precision, and the crowd was immediately locked in.

The spotlight landed on **Kasumi**, who leaned into the mic with a mischievous grin and lit the first verse on fire with her voice—raw, unrefined, but bursting with fierce heart.

*“There’s a wall in front of me I can’t break—
I’ve thrown everything at it, and still, it stands.
My fists are bleeding, my hope is frayed,
But I’m still here. I’m still here.”*

The crowd whooped, already on their feet.

Then, in a clean, seamless shift, **the band leader** stepped up and grabbed her mic.

Her voice, while more practiced than Kasumi’s, carried a sharp edge of emotion—vulnerable, and clear. She picked up the second verse like it was her own story.

*“I’ve cried, I’ve screamed, I’ve fallen low,
And yet you still demand more.
Fine—TAKE IT ALL!
But I won’t run anymore!”*

Their voices collided during the chorus—Kasumi with fiery conviction, and the band leader with steady power. The contrast made the chorus hit even harder:

*“No more masks, no more fear,
I’ll show it all—my anger, my tears!
I won’t break. I won’t bend.
I’ll fight ‘til the very end!”*

The energy surged.

The guitar wailed into a solo, and Kasumi stepped back with a wide grin, shredding her part with theatrical flair—fingers flying, sparks of joy in her every move.

When the bridge came, **Kasumi took over solo**, slowing the pace for a moment. Her voice lowered, almost trembling—her expression distant, vulnerable.

*“I’m tired... I’ve lost more than I can name.
I’m scared... but I won’t be ashamed.
If this is the end—then let it see me standing.”*

A beat of silence.

Then the band leader re-entered with power, lifting the song from the depths.

*“I’ll carry you when your light gets low—
Just say the word, and I won’t let go!”*

The chorus roared back in with both of them singing now—Kasumi’s passionate grit and the band leader’s steady strength fusing in a perfect storm:

*“We’ll find a way—any way—
To stand again, to fight again, to rise again!”
—“As long as we burn—”
—“As long as we burn—”
“We won’t stop!”*

Kasumi glanced at the audience, sweat shining on her brow, and locked eyes with the magical girls in the crowd. She grinned, winked—and sang the final line directly toward them:

“We’re not alone anymore.”

The final chord struck with thunderous unity. Guitars, drums, bass—all crashing to an explosive, defiant stop.

The lights flared.

The audience roared.

But Kasumi wasn’t finished.

With a sudden burst of energy, she **dashed across the stage**, her clown shoes squeaking wildly with every step. She **scooped up the discarded plastic recorder** from earlier, raised it high like a sacred relic... and blew into it with all the theatrical drama of a world-class soloist.

“ScreeeEEEEEEEE—”
The note was hideous.

Unbearably flat. Breathy. Wobbly.

And **absolutely perfect.**

The crowd exploded into *chaotic* applause—**not just cheering the performance**, but the sheer, ridiculous genius of that final touch. Students were wheezing, doubled over with laughter. Some clapped wildly while others just shouted things like:

“ICONIC!”
“I CAN’T BREATHE—”
“SHE’S INSANE—I LOVE HER!”

Even the other band members had completely lost it, leaning on their instruments, laughing so hard they nearly missed their cue for the bow.

Kasumi bowed again with a proud, exaggerated flourish, recorder still in hand like a trophy.

Mami could only shake her head, laughing as she wiped a tear from her eye. The mysterious girl smiled softly beside her, clapping with a kind of gentle appreciation—as though she were applauding more than just the music.

Chaos, heart, and a plastic recorder.

That was Kasumi.

And the crowd adored her for it.

Felicia jumped to her feet, fists pumped into the air. “YEAH!! That’s what I’m talking about!” she shouted, eyes wide with adrenaline. “I wanna fight someone right now!”

Tsuruno wiped a tear from her eye, then pointed a proud finger toward the stage. “That was passion! That was spirit! That’s what it means to never give up!”

Yachiyo nodded silently, arms crossed but her expression softened. She said nothing—but the glint in her eyes said she understood. She’d lived that fight.

Sana had a small smile on her face, her hands neatly folded in her lap. “It was like she was singing to us,” she said quietly. “I felt it. Every word.”

Iroha was quietly glowing with emotion, her hand pressed over her heart. “Does she know who we are?” she whispered, almost to herself. “The way she looked at us, it’s like she understands.”

The mysterious girl smiled warmly, hands lightly folded over her knees. “Music is a kind of magic,” she said softly. “One that touches even the parts of us we hide.”

Mami said nothing at first. She just sat there, eyes locked on Kasumi’s silhouette under the fading stage lights. Her throat felt tight.

And then she smiled—a real, quiet smile.

“...She really meant that,” Mami whispered. “Every word of it.”

Chapter 14b - The mysterious girl’s performance

As the cheers for the band faded into a hum of excited chatter, the mysterious girl rose from her seat beside Mami. She gently brushed down her dress and turned toward the group with a warm smile.

“I need to take care of something,” she said softly, giving Mami a subtle wink.

Mami blinked, curious, but before she could say anything, the girl had already slipped into the crowd, graceful and unhurried.

Not two seconds later, the cheers reignited at the other end of the room.

Kasumi had descended from the stage like a whirlwind of energy, high-fiving students, exchanging fist bumps, and striking dramatic poses for the cameras as flashes lit up around her. A few kids begged her

to sign their notebooks, and one asked if she was actually a real adventurer. Kasumi only grinned wider and gave a mysterious wink.

Eventually, she made her way over to Mami and the Kamihama girls, cheeks slightly flushed from the attention but still riding high from the performance.

“Hey, Mami!” she beamed, plopping down in the seat the mysterious girl had just vacated. “These your friends?”

Mami gave a small nod, smiling. “We just met tonight. But... yes. I think they are.”

Kasumi’s eyes sparkled. “Nice.”

The magical girls introduced themselves one by one.

“I’m Iroha. That was amazing—really,” she said, still clearly touched by the performance. “The way you looked at us... it felt like you were singing to us directly.”

Tsuruno clapped her hands together enthusiastically. “It was like a battle anthem! I’ve never felt so fired up in a school auditorium!”

Sana gave a shy smile. “You were... very brave. And loud. But in a good way.”

Felicia grinned and gave Kasumi a fist bump. “You’re the coolest clown I’ve ever seen!”

Yachiyo gave a small nod, her expression calm but sincere. “You conveyed something powerful. It resonated.”

Kasumi soaked in the praise with a grin and an exaggerated bow. “You’re all too kind. And I meant every word up there—glad it reached you.”

Before they could say more, the lights in the auditorium dimmed again, and the voice of the MC echoed over the speakers.

“And now, for our final act of the evening... the Kamihama High Student Orchestra!”

A ripple of applause moved through the audience as a large group of students began filing onto the stage, instruments in hand—violins, cellos, brass, and woodwinds all settling into place in neat rows. The conductor stepped up to the front, raising his hands to settle the noise.

“Thank you all for being such a wonderful audience tonight,” he said warmly. “Before we begin, we’d like to announce a very special guest flutist joining us for this performance. Please welcome...”

Mami leaned forward, eyes wide. This was it—she was finally going to hear the mysterious girl’s real name.

“...the artist known as **Lunaria!**”

Mami froze.

“‘Known as’ Lunaria?” she whispered aloud, incredulous. “That’s not her real name...”

Next to her, Kasumi was trembling—barely containing her laughter.

Then, from stage left, the mysterious girl emerged.

No longer in her simple, serene attire, she now wore a soft, moonlight-colored dress that shimmered like starlight under the auditorium lights. Her long indigo hair had been braided with ribbons that sparkled subtly, and in her hands, she carried a silver flute that gleamed in the spotlight.

The crowd was enchanted from the moment she stepped out. Whispers passed through the rows, and then cheers rose like waves.

She bowed gracefully to the audience, then to the orchestra, and took her seat among them.

“She’s the flutist?!” Iroha gasped.

Yachiyo narrowed her eyes slightly. “She was with us the whole time...”

Sana stared in amazement. “She didn’t even say anything.”

Felicia scratched her head. “Wait, so is Lunaria her real name or like... her cool name?”

Tsuruno gave a dramatic gasp. “She’s a mysterious artist with a stage name?! That’s so cool!”

Meanwhile, Mami sat there, arms folded, her lower lip puffed out in an unmistakable pout.

Kasumi couldn’t take it anymore and burst out laughing. “You thought you had her this time, huh?”

The magical girls turned to Mami, who quickly shook her head, blushing. “It’s nothing,” she muttered.

The crowd settled down as the conductor raised his baton. The orchestra quieted. A hush fell over the auditorium.

And then—

The music began.

The first notes drifted into the air like a breeze through spring leaves—soft strings and gentle winds weaving together a melody that felt as though it had just awakened from a dream. The sound was delicate, tentative, almost shy. As if the music itself were taking its first steps into the world.

Mami listened with her eyes half-lidded, her heart slowing to match the gentle pulse of the orchestra. The Kamihama girls beside her fell quiet, expressions relaxed. Even Felicia, restless by nature, was leaning slightly forward in awe.

Then, gradually, the music shifted.

The soft melody grew into something brighter, fuller. The strings danced into a lilting 3/4 rhythm, sweeping into a joyful waltz. Flutes, clarinets, and violins joined together in a song that shimmered with elegance and warmth. It was the kind of music that made you want to twirl beneath lantern light on a marble floor, surrounded by laughter and starlight.

People in the audience began to sway in their seats, a few whispering softly to each other with wide smiles. A couple near the back clasped hands. Some students tapped their feet or gently nodded along to the rhythm.

Mami found herself smiling again—softly, genuinely. This part reminded her of what could’ve been. The happiness she’d always imagined living out. It didn’t hurt, though—not now. It just... felt warm.

But then the music shifted again.

The violins surged, and the tempo leapt. The cellos and basses thundered beneath the melody as the full weight of the orchestra came crashing in.

The calm was swept away by a tempest of sound.

Sharp staccatos clashed with sweeping crescendos. French horns and timpani echoed like distant thunder. The winds whirled through frantic scales while the strings tangled and untangled like a stormy sky splitting open.

The conductor’s arms moved furiously, guiding the rising chaos with precision. Every player was locked in—focused, passionate, alive.

Kasumi leaned forward in her seat, eyes gleaming. “Now *that’s* a storm,” she whispered.

Yachiyo nodded solemnly, her gaze never leaving the stage. Tsuruno’s hands were clenched, mirroring the music’s tension. Iroha looked stunned—like she was watching a memory take shape in sound.

And then—just as the storm reached its peak—

Silence.

The conductor froze. Every instrument halted in perfect unity.

The stage was quiet. Not a sound. Not even breath.

Then—

A single spotlight illuminated Lunaria.

She lifted her flute.

And played.

The first note was like moonlight slipping through an open window—gentle, quiet, perfect.

Her melody was slow and tender, but unmistakably full of emotion. Each note felt as though it carried a weight that had only just been lifted. There was a warmth in her phrasing, and a sorrow too—one that didn’t ache, but lingered like a bittersweet memory.

It was the kind of melody that came at the end of something difficult. A song for survivors.

The auditorium sat in utter silence. Enchanted.

Even the Kamihama girls didn't speak. Sana had her hands clasped together in her lap, tears brimming in her eyes. Iroha touched her collarbone gently, as if something was blooming inside her chest.

Mami's breath caught. Her own soul, still recovering from what she'd endured in the realm between places, felt wrapped in the quiet balm of the flute's song. It was like Lunaria was playing just for her.

As the final phrase neared its end, the rest of the orchestra softly rejoined her—one section at a time. First the strings, tender and warm. Then the woodwinds and horns, surrounding her flute like an embrace. The music rose together—united now—into one last harmonious swell.

And with one final, breath-held chord—

The music ended.

Silence held for a beat.

Then the room exploded into applause.

Cheers, whistles, claps. The crowd stood to their feet. Even the faculty in the back gave a standing ovation.

Lunaria lowered her flute, rose from her seat, and bowed again—graceful and serene as ever.

And somewhere in the second row, Mami Tomoe wiped a tear from her cheek and whispered, without meaning to—

“...Thank you.”

Chapter 14c - After the talent show

The house lights rose as the final echoes of the orchestra faded from memory. The MC returned to the stage, beaming brightly as the thunderous applause slowly settled.

“What an amazing night!” he called out, his voice full of energy. “A huge round of applause once more for all of tonight's performers—from the solo acts, the bands, the dancers, to our incredible orchestra!”

Another wave of cheers rolled through the auditorium.

“And remember,” the MC continued, “some of tonight's performers will be in the reception area for a short meet-and-greet! If you want to thank them, ask questions, or just say hi, now's your chance!”

He gave one final, heartfelt bow.

“On behalf of Kamihama High, thank you all for coming to this year's talent show! Goodnight—and keep your dreams alive!”

The crowd responded with an explosion of cheers and applause. The lights dimmed gently as students and families began to rise from their seats, buzzing with conversation and energy.

Kasumi turned to Mami and the others, eyes gleaming. “C'mon, let's go say hi! I want to introduce you all to the amazing girls I played with!”

The Kamihama magical girls lit up with curiosity, and Mami gave a small nod, still visibly glowing from the orchestral performance. “I’d like that.”

Kasumi grinned and turned, confidently weaving her way through the exiting crowd. As they made their way toward the reception area, the hallway outside the auditorium swelled with people. Posters from the event lined the walls, and warm overhead lights bathed the space in a soft glow.

“Kasumi! You were incredible!”

“That intro had me in tears—of laughter!”

“You shredded on the guitar! Please sign my program!”

One after another, students, staff, and families flocked to Kasumi, showering her with praise and admiration. Young kids ran up for high-fives; students held out their phones for selfies. A few even brought sketchbooks or notebooks to be signed.

Kasumi didn’t miss a beat. She met every greeting with a beaming smile, laughing heartily, signing her name with a flourish, and offering dramatic poses for photos. She exchanged fist bumps, made silly faces for selfies, and even knelt down to give a wide-eyed child a high-five and a wink.

As they moved deeper into the reception space, the band from earlier—Second Period Detention—spotted them and immediately waved Kasumi over.

“There she is!” the lead guitarist called out, her cheeks still pink from earlier. “Kasumi, you *killed* it!”

“You were amazing!” one of the others added. “Seriously, thank you so much for saying yes to performing with us. It was a dream!”

Kasumi gave them a heartfelt bow and a mock-dramatic salute. “Are you kidding? You girls rocked. I had an *absolute blast*. If you keep playing like that, I’m coming back for your next show—clown bike and all.”

The band laughed, still riding the high of their performance. They turned to Mami and the Kamihama group with friendly smiles.

“And these are your friends?” the lead asked.

“Yep!” Kasumi said proudly. “All stars in their own right.”

The band greeted Mami, Iroha, Yachiyo, Tsuruno, Sana, and Felicia with genuine warmth.

“I saw you all in the front rows,” one girl said. “Thanks for the energy—it was contagious!”

“You looked like you were *feeling* that song,” another added to Felicia, who puffed up proudly.

The conversation flowed naturally, laughter and praise filling the air. Kasumi, glowing with joy, slung an arm around Mami’s shoulders and gave her a squeeze.

“This is what it’s all about,” she whispered. “Music, connection, joy. It keeps us lit.”

Mami smiled softly, nodding in agreement, her eyes scanning the happy crowd. Something in her chest felt warm—and steady.

The band girls lingered after the initial rush of photos and laughter, their excitement still buzzing. One of them—shorter, with springy brown curls and a bass guitar slung over her back—grinned as she pulled out her phone.

“If you liked the song we played,” she said, addressing Mami and the magical girls, “you can find more of our stuff online. We upload everything to MeTube and StreamMuse—we’re ‘Second Period Detention.’ Spelled exactly like it sounds.”

“Catchy name,” Felicia smirked, arms crossed behind her head. “Kinda makes me wish I got detention more often.”

Tsuruno clapped her hands. “I’ll look you up tonight! I need more high-energy music for my morning runs!”

Yachiyo nodded politely, offering a rare smile. “Thank you for the recommendation.”

Mami stepped forward slightly, her hands clasped together in front of her. “You were all wonderful up there. The energy, the message... it really resonated. I’m glad people like you are making music like that.”

The band’s lead singer, still holding her electric guitar, flushed with pride. “Thank you so much. That means a lot coming from you all. We just hope it lifts people up, you know? Helps them find their fire again.”

Sana nodded softly. “It does. It really does.”

“We’ll be cheering for all of you,” added Iroha, her voice gentle. “Keep making music that speaks like that.”

The band beamed, clearly touched.

After a few more rounds of laughter, photos, and signatures with the girl band, Kasumi clapped her hands together and gestured toward the far side of the reception hall.

“Alright! Let’s go see how our lovely flutist’s holding up,” she said with a cheeky grin, already starting to walk. “I wonder if she’s got a bigger fan club than me by now.”

The group made their way through the crowd once more, following the soft hum of conversation and scattered camera flashes toward a polished table decorated with simple arrangements of white lilies and

music note motifs. Around it stood the members of the student orchestra, still in their formal black and white attire, glowing with the satisfaction of a performance well done.

At the center of the small crowd was Lunaria.

She stood poised, calm, and graceful, her deep indigo hair catching the light with an ethereal shimmer. A soft smile rested on her lips as she nodded politely to those around her. Members of the orchestra crowded close, speaking animatedly.

“Thank you again for accepting our invitation,” the conductor said, offering a small bow. “Your solo was... transcendent.”

Lunaria bowed slightly in return, hands delicately folded in front of her. “It was my honor. Thank you for allowing me to be part of something so beautifully alive. I would be happy to play with you all again.”

The students gathered around her like quiet stars around a glowing moon. Several took turns asking for autographs, and others shyly asked for a photo. A few parents and staff joined in, their expressions full of warmth and admiration.

She accepted each request with a gentle nod, writing her alias with elegant strokes and posing with a soft, serene smile.

Then she noticed Kasumi and the others approaching—and her face lit up just a little more.

“Kasumi. Mami. Iroha, Yachiyo, Tsuruno, Sana, Felicia.” She greeted each one in turn with a small, knowing smile. “I’m glad you came.”

“Hey, you weren’t going to sneak away without us, were you?” Kasumi teased with a smirk.

The orchestra students turned, immediately recognizing Kasumi.

“Wait—you’re *her*! Kasumi the Adventurer!”

“You were hilarious—and somehow still cool?”

“Can I get a picture with you?”

Kasumi raised her hands dramatically. “I will *grace* you all with my presence and my signature, so long as you accept the sacred contract of enduring my terrible recorder playing!”

That got a wave of laughter from the orchestra.

One of the violinists chimed in, grinning, “About that—you *really* need to practice. That was, like, legally a crime against music.”

Another added, “Seriously. Get that sorted, and we might let you audition to play with us.”

Kasumi gasped with exaggerated offense, then dropped into a deep, theatrical bow. “I take your challenge! I shall return, mightier in breath and pitch!”

The students laughed harder, clearly enjoying her energy.

Meanwhile, the magical girls gathered near Lunaria, who greeted them with her usual calm warmth.

Tsuruno gave her a bright grin. “You were *amazing*! Why didn’t you say you were performing?”

Felicia crossed her arms, puffing out her cheeks. “Yeah! You totally tricked us!”

Yachiyo raised an eyebrow, though her tone remained gentle. “You did say you were just here to enjoy the show.”

Iroha nodded in agreement, recalling the moment. “And to support those who put their heart into it...”

Lunaria’s smile deepened just a touch. “And I did. Every word of that was true.”

“You showed appreciation for all of the performers... but it felt like you were speaking to us. Through the music.”

“Music doesn’t need to explain itself,” Lunaria said softly. “Sometimes it’s enough just to be heard.”

The girls fell quiet, thoughtful. There was something serene in her answer—a kind of clarity that settled over them like a calm breeze.

Mami, still standing beside Lunaria, looked up at her with a light pout. “You still haven’t told me your *real* name,” she whispered.

Lunaria glanced at her sidelong, her smile quietly mischievous. “I haven’t, have I?”

Kasumi burst out laughing, nearly knocking over a chair in the process. “Oh, brutal! You’re not gonna let her live, huh?”

Mami folded her arms with exaggerated patience, though a small smile tugged at the corner of her lips. “I think I deserve at least that much.”

Lunaria gave a soft laugh and finally turned to face her properly, brushing a strand of indigo hair behind her ear. “Maybe so, but unfortunately...”

“Unfortunately what?” Mami blinked.

Lunaria closed one eye, raised a finger to her lips, and grinned—
Looking a *lot* like a certain other girl.

Kasumi lost it again.

Mami blinked—was Lunaria... mimicking Kasumi? Just like how Kasumi had mimicked Lunaria during their training?

The realization made her laugh quietly. It was clear now how close the two were—so different, yet in sync in the most unexpected ways.

As the laughter died down, one of the student orchestra members—still holding his violin case—approached the group with a friendly wave. “Hey, if you liked tonight’s performance, we actually post recordings of our concerts online. The Kamihama High Orchestra has a page on StreamMuse and SoundNest—search for us and you’ll find full performances and behind-the-scenes stuff.”

“We’ve got the spring concert up too!” another member chimed in, clutching a clarinet. “That one had more upbeat themes, if you’re into that.”

Sana looked intrigued. “I’d love to listen. Thank you for sharing.”

Yachiyo gave a small nod. “You were all very skilled.”

Tsuruno gave a playful wink. “Guess I’ll have my entire next week’s playlist sorted.”

The students beamed with pride. “Glad to hear it! Music’s meant to travel, after all. Hope it brings you something good.”

Mami smiled warmly. “I think it already has.”

Chapter 15 – Under Starlight, With Open Hearts

After the final wave of laughter, photos, and heartfelt goodbyes, the performers and guests slowly filtered out of the reception hall. The night air greeted them with a cool, refreshing breeze, the sky above painted in deep twilight blues and soft hues of starlight. Crickets chirped in the distance, and the warmth of the event still lingered in everyone’s hearts.

Lunaria, her hands gently folded behind her back, walked beside Mami. Kasumi, ever the energy source of the group, stretched her arms out wide and took in a deep breath.

“Aaaaah! That concert gave me life—and now I need food to keep that life going!” she declared dramatically. “Who’s hungry? I vote we eat!”

“That’s a great idea,” Mami said with a light laugh. “It’s been a long day.”

Tsuruno perked up instantly, fists on her hips and eyes gleaming with pride. “Then you’re all in luck! My family owns a Chinese restaurant not far from here. I work there too! Come on—my treat tonight!”

“You don’t have to do that...” Iroha began.

But Kasumi was already linking arms with Tsuruno. “Lead the way, fearless chef! I’m ready for noodles, rice, dumplings—bring it all!”

Lunaria offered a gentle nod. “It sounds like a lovely end to a beautiful evening.”

They all made their way through the softly lit streets of Kamihama, the school lights behind them fading as they walked. The glow of signs and streetlamps shimmered gently on the pavement, giving the evening a dreamlike charm.

Soon, they arrived at the restaurant: a quaint, cozy place with a warm golden light spilling from the windows. A sign reading **Banbanzai** hung proudly above the entrance.

Inside, they had the place to themselves. Tsuruno disappeared into the kitchen, tying an apron around her waist with expert flair. “Sit wherever you want! I’ll cook up something delicious for everyone!”

True to her word, a short while later, the table was filled with steaming dishes—fragrant stir-fried noodles, plump dumplings, perfectly cooked rice, and a savory mapo tofu that made Kasumi’s eyes sparkle with awe.

“This is amazing!” Kasumi exclaimed between mouthfuls.

“Delicious,” Lunaria agreed, her tone serene but genuine.

As they all ate, the conversation drifted and flowed. Between bites and refills of tea, one of the magical girls leaned forward.

“So, Kasumi,” Sana asked gently, “you’re really an adventurer? You’ve seen the world?”

Kasumi wiped her mouth with a napkin and leaned back with a satisfied grin, eyes sparkling with fond memories.

“Yup. Been a lot of places—fought some weird things, found some beautiful ones too. I go where I’m needed... or where the wind takes me.”

Mami glanced sideways at her, remembering the chaotic whirlwind that was Kasumi in combat—flames swirling, laughter echoing through smoke and steel. *I wonder what she would consider ‘weird’ while fighting*, Mami thought.

She leaned forward, elbows on the table now, excitement building. “I once helped a village in northern Hokkaido deal with what they *thought* was a spirit that only showed up during snowstorms. Real shy type—only responded to yōkai jazz music. Turns out, it was just some really confused wildlife and weird acoustics bouncing off the mountains. But hey, I still had to learn how to play a trumpet underwater. Don’t ask.”

Felicia blinked. “Wait. What?!”

Kasumi waved a hand dramatically. “True story! Oh—and off the coast of Okinawa? Total sea monster hotspot. Like, three kinds of krakens. I had to bribe one with pickled squid. Irony, right?”

Tsuruno let out a short laugh from the kitchen. “That sounds fake.”

“Painfully real,” Kasumi insisted, placing a hand over her heart. “My lungs still smell like ocean trauma.”

The girls chuckled.

“Oh! And you haven’t lived until you’ve danced your way through a pastry festival in Southern France,” she went on. “So many sweets, it was basically a boss rush of sugar. I made friends with a caramel sculptor. We’re pen pals now.”

Mami gave her a knowing smile. “That sounds familiar.”

Kasumi grinned sideways at her. “Told you, didn’t I? I travel the world—seeing new places, trying all the food I can find, meeting people, soaking in stories. Every place has its own kind of magic. You just have to listen for it.”

Iroha’s eyes softened as she listened. Sana looked quietly amazed.

“And Kamihama?” Yachiyo asked, voice calm.

Kasumi nodded slowly, her expression briefly more thoughtful. “This place... felt like it was calling out. Like something important was happening here. I followed that feeling.”

She smirked, her usual playfulness returning. “And hey, got invited to perform. Can’t say no to a good stage.”

Yachiyo, calm and composed, but unmistakably serious, rested her chin on her hand. Her eyes studied Kasumi carefully, then swept to Lunaria, then Mami. “During your performance... when you said, ‘*We’re not alone anymore*’—you looked straight at us.”

Kasumi didn’t deny it. She only smiled, tilting her head slightly. “I meant it.”

Yachiyo didn’t let up. She sat a little straighter, her voice quiet but direct. “So... do all three of you know about us?”

The question hung in the air. Not explicit—but unmistakable.

Iroha leaned forward, her hands wrapped around her teacup. “During the music... both your performances—it felt like you were talking to us. All of us.”

Sana nodded from her seat. “It wasn’t just music. It felt personal.”

Felicia, having just cleaned off another plate, looked up and muttered, “It made me feel like we weren’t alone anymore. Like we didn’t have to fight everything by ourselves.”

“I felt it too,” Tsuruno called from the kitchen, peeking around the doorframe. “Like someone out there was cheering us on. Someone who *knew*.”

Yachiyo’s gaze remained locked on Lunaria. “So... were you trying to connect with us through your performance? Why?”

Mami looked between her two companions, her fingers tightening slightly around her chopsticks. Her voice faltered before she could speak, uncertain.

Lunaria’s face was calm, her eyes half-lidded, expression unreadable. She didn’t speak. Not yet.

Kasumi, meanwhile, grinned like she hadn't heard the tension in Yachiyo's tone at all.

Kasumi was the first to break the silence. She let out a light, genuine laugh, then glanced at Yachiyo with an amused sparkle in her eyes. "Wow, Yachiyo, you're sharp. You notice everything, don't you?" But she didn't answer the question directly—just smiled and shook her head playfully.

Yachiyo didn't miss a beat. Her tone remained calm, but there was a quiet insistence behind it. "Then tell me—what are you doing here in Kamihama? And who exactly are you?"

Kasumi settled into her seat, crossing one leg over the other, and gave a small nod before answering. "Well, I travel the world—to enjoy myself and broaden my perspective..."

She paused briefly, then continued, "But that's not the only reason. I also want to learn more—about magical techniques, rituals, and fighting styles from different parts of the world. I keep up with magical girls and their struggles wherever I go. There's a lot to learn from what people face and try to overcome."

The magical girls exchanged surprised glances. Some faces flushed, others stiffened, and a few leaned forward, wide-eyed. Kasumi's awareness of magical girls—and her casual talk about their struggles—was more than they expected.

Yachiyo's gaze sharpened further. She stood slowly, folding her arms, her voice low but firm. "Kasumi, Lunaria, Mami—you need to explain yourselves. None of you show any sign of a soul gem. Who are you, really? And how do you know so much about magical girls?"

The room went quiet, the question hanging heavy in the air.

Kasumi, expression undeterred and unchanged, met Yachiyo's gaze with an unwavering smile. She leaned forward just slightly, hands folded loosely on the table.

"I get it," she said. "That's a sharp eye you've got, and fair questions too."

She glanced around at the rest of the table—at Iroha's open curiosity, Sana's gentle trust, Tsuruno's wary focus, Felicia's visible impatience, and Yachiyo's calculating calm. Then her gaze rested on Mami and Lunaria beside her. Mami gave no expression away. Lunaria sat in her usual composed stillness.

Kasumi looked back to Yachiyo.

"I'm sorry, but... we can't really answer *that* question," she said with surprising sincerity, voice softening. "Not the one about who we are."

Tsuruno's eyes narrowed. Felicia sat up a little straighter. Yachiyo didn't respond—but the room grew ever so slightly heavier.

"But," Kasumi added quickly, "we *can* answer the others."

There was a pause. Yachiyo gave the slightest of nods—permission to continue, though not forgiveness.

Kasumi took a breath, her usual casual brightness dimming just enough to show that what she was about to say came from something deeper.

“As I’ve traveled... from one city to another, one country to the next... I started noticing something. Certain girls—always girls—who behaved differently from the people around them.” She looked down at her hands briefly, fingers threading together. “They weren’t just shy or quiet. They felt... distant. Detached. Like they were carrying something no one else could see.”

She glanced up again, her voice softer now. “Some of them were serious. Others cold. Some sad... or lonely. Some wore a smile, but it didn’t reach their eyes. But no matter the country or language, I started to recognize that look.”

She leaned back again, folding her arms loosely.

“And also... I started noticing something else. Strange events would happen—always near places where there seemed to be more of those girls. Accidents, disappearances, eerie rumors. Like something was bubbling under the surface.”

“I don’t know everything,” Kasumi said, offering a half-smile, trying to defuse the tension building in the room. “But I reached out. I talked to them, learned what I could. Some told me little. Others told me more. I started to understand that there was a hidden world—something quiet and painful that no one else seemed to see.”

She glanced to Lunaria beside her.

“And when I told Lunaria... she said we should try to support them. However we can. Even if they didn’t always ask for it.”

“The performance tonight,” she added, “was just one way of doing that.”

At the table, no one moved at first.

The silence stretched, not awkwardly—but heavily.

Each of the girls felt it land in their own way.

Sana looked down into her tea, her fingers curled gently around the cup. Her eyes shone faintly.

Tsuruno stared at her plate, unusually quiet.

Felicia’s hands slowly clenched into fists on the table. She didn’t speak.

Iroha brought her hand to her chest, her eyes wide, searching Kasumi’s expression for any hint of insincerity—but finding none.

Yachiyo remained as still as stone—but her gaze shifted subtly toward Mami.

And **Mami**, ever composed, gave no outward reaction. But inwardly, she felt something tug—sharp and unshakable.

Kasumi continued smiling, as if her words hadn’t landed like stones in still water.

She didn't explain more. She didn't need to.

Yachiyo went quiet.

She didn't look down at her food, nor did she retreat from the moment—but something in her eyes shifted. Kasumi's words, her observations, had landed close. Too close. *Strange events... a hidden world...* It sounded eerily familiar to the phenomenon Yachiyo had been tracking meticulously: the incidents tied to the Witch's Kiss, and more recently, the spreading "Rumors" plaguing Kamihama.

Could she know about those too? Or is it just coincidence?

Yachiyo's thoughts briefly drifted to Iroha—how the girl had come to Kamihama chasing fragments of memory. Visions of a sister... a girl named Ui... someone who, by all records and memory, no longer existed. But Iroha's determination hadn't faltered. And now, perhaps, someone like Kasumi might hold a piece of the puzzle. Even if she didn't realize it.

Yachiyo glanced subtly around the table. Iroha's eyes were still filled with curiosity. Sana's posture was relaxed, her expression open. Felicia, finishing her third serving, was unusually quiet, listening instead of interrupting. Tsuruno leaned against the kitchen doorway, arms crossed but smiling softly.

They all nodded, as if silently agreeing.

Kasumi, Lunaria, and Mami... whatever they were hiding, it didn't feel malicious. They didn't carry the weight of liars or manipulators. Just people who knew more than they could say—and perhaps had their own wounds.

Yachiyo finally nodded once, then spoke, her voice composed. "Thank you for the explanation," she said. "I understand you can't answer everything. Everyone has their secrets."

Her words were calm, but inside, a flicker of something churned.

Isn't that the very reason you hesitate to work with others? her inner voice asked.

She thought of Kanae. Of Mel. Of the others. Of how her wish *to survive* had become a silent weight—one that had driven her to distance herself from others, even when they needed her. Even when she needed them.

Kasumi's smile widened, full of warmth and not a trace of mockery. "Wow. Look at you, Yachiyo. Turns out you're pretty nice and understanding behind that cold exterior."

Yachiyo blinked.

Then she sighed. "...You really are infuriating."

The rest of the girls burst out laughing—especially Tsuruno and Felicia.

"She's not wrong!" Tsuruno grinned. "Yacchan's got a frosty shell, but deep down she's a big softie!"

"Didn't think *anyone* could get away with saying that to her face," Felicia added, mouth full.

Even Iroha giggled, one hand covering her mouth. “It’s kind of true...”

Yachiyo rolled her eyes and rested her cheek in one hand, but her lips twitched—just slightly—at the edges.

Kasumi beamed, basking in the laughter like it was a stage spotlight.

Lunaria gave a quiet chuckle, her eyes warm with approval as she sipped her tea, clearly enjoying the scene.

Mami, sitting beside her, smiled softly—relieved to see this kind of warmth, this kind of trust forming. She leaned back just a little, a quiet breath leaving her lips. Maybe, just maybe... they were in the right place.

Chapter 15b – Whispers and Warmth

Yachiyo, her gaze still steady, looked over at Kasumi. “Do you, Lunaria, or Mami... know anything about the rumors of Kamihama?”

Kasumi tilted her head slightly, then gave a theatrical shrug. “Rumors? You’ll have to be more specific. Assume we know nothing.”

That answer seemed to satisfy Yachiyo—at least enough to continue.

She rested her elbows lightly on the table. “Strange things happen in Kamihama. More than usual. We’ve been investigating them—distortions, disappearances, strange anomalies tied to local folklore... we call them Rumors. Some are minor. Others are dangerous.”

Tsuruno chimed in with a nod. “They’re like living urban legends. But worse.”

“I’ve been recording everything I can about them,” Yachiyo continued. “Patterns, sightings, outcomes. Most people don’t notice anything. But magical girls can feel the distortion—sometimes even get drawn into it.”

Iroha set her teacup down carefully. “There’s something else too...” She looked down, hands folding in her lap. “Sometimes... I see a young girl in my dreams. Or visions. I know I should recognize her—but I don’t. Every time I try to remember her face, my mind goes blank.”

Felicia and Sana looked at her gently, the atmosphere quieting for a moment.

“I don’t know who she is,” Iroha added softly, “but I can’t shake the feeling... that I’m supposed to.”

Kasumi leaned forward slightly, her earlier grin fading into a thoughtful expression. Lunaria’s calm gaze sharpened with interest. Mami glanced from Iroha to Yachiyo, her expression unreadable.

“Interesting,” Kasumi murmured. “Dreams and distortions. That’s heavy stuff.”

Lunaria nodded slowly. “If what you’re saying is true, then something more is happening here than just coincidence or isolated magic.”

“We’ll look into it,” Kasumi said, now addressing the entire group. “All three of us. No promises, but we’ll keep our ears open. If we find anything that sounds like one of your Rumors, we’ll let you know.”

Mami gave a quiet nod. “We’re not here to interfere. But we’re also not here to ignore what’s happening.”

Yachiyo, after studying them a moment longer, finally smiled just a little. “Thank you. That’s all I could ask for.”

Iroha brightened. “Really—thank you. It means a lot.”

Then Kasumi clapped her hands. “Aaaand enough of that serious talk! This is a girls' night out, remember?”

Sana giggled, and even Yachiyo rolled her eyes with a faint smirk.

Kasumi lifted her glass of chilled tea. “To good food, good music, and great company!”

The others lifted theirs in return.

“Cheers!”

Laughter followed, warm and easy. The tension melted into the aroma of delicious food and the soft clinking of dishes. They chatted about simple things—funny school stories, food preferences, embarrassing moments, and hobbies. Felicia somehow started a debate about the best kind of dumpling, which quickly turned into a passionate discussion between her and Tsuruno, while Sana quietly shared her favorite picture books with Lunaria.

The night stretched on peacefully, filled with conversation, clinking glasses, and the laughter of girls who—just for a little while—let themselves be ordinary.

The plates were nearly empty now, only a few lingering bites of food left behind as the warmth of the evening settled into full contentment. The restaurant was filled with the soft hum of conversation and the occasional burst of laughter.

Felicia stretched with a loud yawn. “I’m stuffed. That hit the spot.”

Tsuruno beamed proudly, hands on her hips. “Of course it did! The best food in Kamihama, cooked by yours truly!”

Kasumi leaned back in her seat, letting out a happy sigh. “Man, that was perfect. I should come here after every adventure.” She looked across the table at the group, a glimmer of mischief in her eye. “And don’t think this is the last you’ll see of me.”

Yachiyo raised an eyebrow. “Oh?”

Kasumi stood and brushed off her coat, then slung her bag over one shoulder. “I’ve got a feeling our paths are going to cross again. Real soon.” She gave them all a wink.

Lunaria stood gracefully beside her, giving a soft nod. “We’ll be around.”

Mami offered a gentle smile. “Take care of yourselves. All of you.”

They waved their goodbyes, with Kasumi throwing one last dramatic pose at the door—hand to heart, other arm extended like a performer taking her final bow. Then, with a spin of her heels, she disappeared into the night alongside Lunaria and Mami.

The door slowly shut behind them, the soft chime of the bell above the frame echoing briefly into the quiet left behind.

The group sat in silence for a moment.

Yachiyo was the first to speak.

“What do you think about them?” she asked, her tone thoughtful rather than suspicious. “Who they are. If they’re... like us.”

Iroha gently ran her finger along the rim of her teacup, staring into the empty porcelain. “Kasumi seemed to know too much for it to be just a coincidence. And Lunaria... she feels different. Like she’s seen the same things we have, but from a step removed.”

Sana nodded slowly. “They didn’t lie—not really—but they didn’t say everything either. Still, I didn’t feel unsafe. Kasumi’s music... Lunaria’s presence... It felt sincere.”

Felicia shrugged. “Kasumi’s weird. But the good energetic kind of weird, she reminds me a bit of myself. Not dangerous. Besides, anyone who rocks that hard on stage is okay in my book.”

Tsuruno leaned back in her chair, arms crossed behind her head. “They were holding something back, for sure. But it didn’t feel like a threat. More like... they’re waiting for the right time.”

Yachiyo looked at each girl as they spoke, her mind turning over their words. Then her gaze drifted to the window beside them, where the night stretched on—cool, calm, and vast.

“They’re not normal civilians. That much is obvious,” she said quietly. “But if they are magical girls... then they’re hiding their Soul Gems. And they’re very good at it.”

Her reflection flickered against the dark glass as she continued. “Kasumi’s story had holes—but there was truth in it. Maybe not all of it was literal. But the part about seeing that look in people’s eyes...”

She trailed off, thinking of all the girls she’d lost, all the silent burdens magical girls carried. The haunted stares. The forced smiles. That part, she knew, was real.

She looked into the night, watching the street where the three had disappeared.

“They’ve seen the same world we have,” Yachiyo said at last. “Maybe even more of it.”

She folded her hands in her lap.

“We’ll keep an eye on them.”

Chapter 16: Beneath the Quiet Stars

The quiet night wrapped around them as they stepped out of the restaurant's warm glow and into the cool evening air. Kasumi glanced around, her eyes glittering under the moonlight.

"Alright. Back home we go."

In a flash of distorted light and rippling magic, the world around them warped. The glowing city streets of Kamihama stretched and folded, fracturing like glass, then stitched themselves into the darkened trees and stars of another realm entirely.

The three girls stood just outside the cozy cabin nestled deep in that surreal forest—their sanctuary. Moonlight filtered through the trees, and the hum of this otherworldly space settled softly in the air.

As they stepped toward the front door, Mami turned to Lunaria. "Hey... can I keep calling you Lunaria?"

Lunaria stopped in her tracks, a smile gently forming on her lips. "I would be delighted," she replied, her voice like a calm stream under starlight. "It suits me, doesn't it?"

Mami nodded with a small smile, brushing a golden curl behind her ear. "It really does."

They entered the cabin, the wooden floors creaking softly beneath their feet. Lanterns flickered on with a warm glow, welcoming them home. Shoes came off, cloaks hung up, and the comfort of familiarity returned. A calm silence wrapped around them as they moved about their little space.

Soon enough, all three had changed into their sleepwear—Kasumi in her usual mismatched colors, Lunaria in something elegant and soft, and Mami with her classic sense of refined taste. They gathered briefly in the main room, sprawled across floor cushions and sipping warm tea.

Kasumi, stretched out and already halfway into a yawn, broke the silence first. "So," she asked, arms tucked behind her head, "what do you two think about tonight?"

Lunaria folded her legs beneath her, cup resting delicately in her hands. "The performance was meaningful. The music... the energy... it reached them. Especially those girls."

"They were just like you said," Mami added softly. "Each one of them carrying something deep. Pain. Regret. Hope. It was all there in their eyes."

"The rumors of Kamihama," Lunaria mused, glancing toward the window. "They're not mere whispers. There's something bigger and tangled in that city. Something that watches quietly."

"And that girl," Mami said slowly, "Iroha. She doesn't remember her own sister? That's not a simple memory loss. It felt wrong... unnatural."

Kasumi nodded, more serious now. "I felt it too. Like something's shifting beneath the surface. That group of girls—they're in the middle of something way bigger than they realize."

“We need to tread carefully,” Lunaria said, voice calm but firm. “There’s danger there. But also... hope.”

Kasumi smiled, her gaze softening. “I like them. They’ve been through a lot, but they’re still standing. I think we’ll be seeing them again sooner than they think.”

She gave a small stretch, arms arching behind her head. “But all that thinking and talking has made me sleepy. I’m ready to crash.”

Kasumi stood, gave a theatrical bow, and shuffled off toward her room with a wave. “Nighty night~ Don’t let the moon spirits bite.”

Lunaria followed with a quieter goodbye. “Goodnight, both of you.”

Mami remained seated for a moment longer, finishing the last sip of her tea before setting the cup down with a quiet clink.

As she slipped under her covers, the quiet hum of the cabin around her, her thoughts lingered in a soft, sleepy haze.

So much had happened.

Meeting Lunaria and Kasumi. The wild, dizzying training sessions. Crossing back into the real world—if only briefly. The stage lights, the music, the warmth of the crowd. The laughter with new faces. The spark of connection.

But that was only the surface.

As she lay there, eyes closed beneath the soft hush of nighttime, memories rose like waves—some gentle, some jagged. She remembered *that day*. The day she “died.”

Charlotte.

The surreal, almost absurd moment when her world had been torn away—by teeth, by betrayal, by something cruel hiding behind something innocent. The pain wasn’t just physical. It was the shattering of trust, of certainty, of the illusion that she could protect anyone.

And then... she heard a mysterious and beautiful voice calling out.

And then silence.

A void she hadn’t expected. But not the end.

She awoke in an entirely different place—a strange realm that felt unmoored from reality. The colors were muted, almost drained, and the air carried a heavy, otherworldly stillness. Around her stretched a vast expanse, empty yet somehow alive, a shifting void of soft lights and restless shadows. Time and space seemed to twist and blur, as though neither held meaning there.

Then Lunaria appeared—mysterious, composed, gentle... and impossibly strong.

Their first meeting had been a battle. A test, perhaps. A challenge. But also a kind of conversation. Lunaria didn't speak much, yet every movement of her body, every subtle shift in her stance, said: *I understand your pain. Show me what you carry.* And Mami had shown her.

She remembered the moment when the despair nearly swallowed her whole—when the black energy surged, and her soul gem came terrifyingly close to corruption. And then Lunaria saved her. Just as she was about to fall, Lunaria stepped in... and Mami blacked out.

She awoke again—this time in a different place entirely.

A warm cabin nestled in the embrace of nature. Soft grass beneath her fingertips. Crisp, clean air. A sky awash with stars, the moon glowing brightly above. It was peaceful. Too peaceful, almost—like stepping into a dream she wasn't sure she deserved.

At first, she didn't understand. She was supposed to be gone. Finished. And yet... she was here.

Then she heard it—a gentle sound drifting through the night. Music.

She followed it, drawn forward by the hauntingly beautiful melody. And there, sitting gracefully on the grass, was Lunaria. A flute hovering at her lips. A harp in her hands. She played as though she were part of the wind, part of the stars.

The lake behind her shimmered with moonlight, reflecting the heavens. Mountains framed the horizon, silent and still. The scene was ethereal—too perfect to be real, and yet undeniably present.

The harp and flute sang together, wordless yet full of meaning. The music didn't just soothe Mami's aching soul—it *unraveled* it. With every note, years of tension slipped away. Guilt. Pain. Isolation. It all loosened its grip. She had never felt so at peace inside.

She thought of the truths Lunaria had revealed. The cruelty of the magical girl system. The despair. The lies. And yet, also... hope. There *was* a way forward. A way to live without breaking. To fight without being swallowed whole. The practices Lunaria taught weren't just techniques—they were ways to live.

And then came Kasumi.

Wild, theatrical, full of energy that made the whole world feel a little more awake.

Her presence wasn't just loud—it was radiant. As if she carried the sun in her pocket and let it spill out wherever she walked.

Their meeting in the arena had been absurd and unforgettable. The chiming of bells, the flicker of flame, the echo of a stage voice proclaiming her every move like it was the climax of a play. Kasumi didn't just enter Mami's life—she *burst* into it, like a storm that wore glitter and confetti and left behind laughter in its wake. And somehow, in all that chaos... everything felt lighter.

Training with her had been exactly what Mami never knew she needed. Joyful chaos. Whimsical nonsense.

And warmth.

Kasumi never taught with a cold edge. She encouraged with puns and parries, cheered with fireworks and jokes, and had an uncanny ability to pull Mami out of her own head. Mami had laughed again. *Really* laughed—not out of politeness, not to fill silence, not as a mask—but because she couldn’t help it. Because Kasumi was infectious in the best way.

There were moments when Mami had caught herself smiling just from watching Kasumi talk—her wild hand gestures, her endless metaphors, her habit of assigning grandiose titles to the simplest moves. And beneath it all, there was sincerity. Despite all her theatrics, Kasumi cared. Deeply. She listened. She paid attention. And Mami, who so often felt like she had to be the composed one, the strong one, found herself being *held up* instead.

For the first time in what felt like ages, she had been allowed to be soft. To joke. To falter. And Kasumi never judged her for it.

If Lunaria had met her with a mirror to the soul,
Kasumi had met her with a hand outstretched—
inviting her to dance through the fire.

Then she thought of how Kasumi and Lunaria gathered ingredients—not taking from nature, but drawing its essence, gently, with reverence. They spoke to plants and listened to animals. They gave back more than they took. It was a kind of magic Mami had never imagined. A kind of *life* she hadn’t believed was possible.

And then there was the talent show.

Walking among the living once more—no one knowing who she was. Being part of something ordinary, yet beautiful. Watching the magical girls—girls who reminded her so much of herself. Hearing them laugh. Seeing them be *kids* again, if only for a while. The performances had been incredible, but it was that sense of connection that lingered most.

That moment on stage when Kasumi had stared at the group and said, “*We’re not alone anymore*”—Mami had felt it.

Not just heard it. Not just understood it.
Felt it.

Like someone had reached inside and gently touched the parts of her that still ached. As if someone had lit a candle in the dark corner of her heart—a quiet, flickering warmth she hadn’t realized she needed.

Kasumi, bold and brilliant, had delivered the message with all the subtlety of a flare gun. With roaring chords, crashing drums, and a terribly played recorder, she had screamed to the world: *You matter. You're not forgotten. You don't have to fight alone anymore.*

And Lunaria...

She hadn't needed words at all.

That flute solo—so quiet, so tender, so *achingly beautiful*—had felt like a lullaby for everything Mami had been too afraid to say out loud.

Peaceful. Nostalgic. Like a memory she'd never had, but somehow still missed.

Mami remembered watching her under the soft stage lights, the crowd silent, enchanted.

That single spotlight catching the shine of her indigo hair.

Every note she played seemed to say:

I see you. I hear your pain. I've felt it too.

It hadn't just been a performance.

It was a conversation—a dialogue in sound and soul.

Kasumi and Lunaria, so different in style, yet perfectly in sync.

One shouting to the skies.

The other whispering to the quiet places inside.

And Mami had been sitting there, surrounded by magical girls who bore the same scars.

The same regrets.

The same heavy truths.

She'd realized something then.

They weren't just putting on a show.

They were *fighting*—not with weapons, but with music.

Fighting to give hope.

Fighting to remind them all that healing was still possible.

Even for someone like her.

And then there was dinner.

Warm lights. Familiar clatter. The scent of soy, ginger, and something sizzling from the kitchen.

Banbanzai wasn't fancy, but it didn't need to be. It was full of life—Tsuruno's bright laughter echoing from behind the counter, Felicia stealing bites from other plates when she thought no one was looking, Sana politely scolding her while hiding a small smile.

Yachiyo, ever composed, quietly keeping watch over everyone with subtle grace.

Iroha, gentle and attentive, like she carried a thread that kept them all connected.

It was noisy. Lively. Messy, in the most beautiful way.
And Mami sat among them, not as a guest of honor or a teacher, but simply as one of them.
A girl at the table.

She hadn't realized how much she missed that—*needed* that.
A place to belong.
A seat already waiting for her.
Laughter shared without expectation.
Food passed without obligation.

Back then, she had played the part of the strong one. The big sister. The protector.
And she had believed she could bear it alone—until she couldn't.

Now, watching these girls bicker, tease, support, and protect each other so openly... it stirred something old in her chest.
A kind of ache.
Not one of pain, but of remembrance.

If only I had something like this back then, she thought.
Would things have turned out differently?
Would she have leaned on them instead of folding in on herself?

She would never know.
But she knew one thing now:
She was grateful—grateful that these girls *had* each other.
And now, she was not alone anymore.

So much had changed since the day she “died.”

Not in the way most people understood death—there was no final breath, no funeral. Just a quiet shift, a step sideways into somewhere... in between.
This place wasn't for the living or the dead. It was for those still searching.

And Mami was still searching. But not just for answers anymore.

She was searching for how to *live*.

And as she drifted off to sleep, one final thought nestled in her chest like a warm ember:

Despite all she had lost, her life had never felt more full.